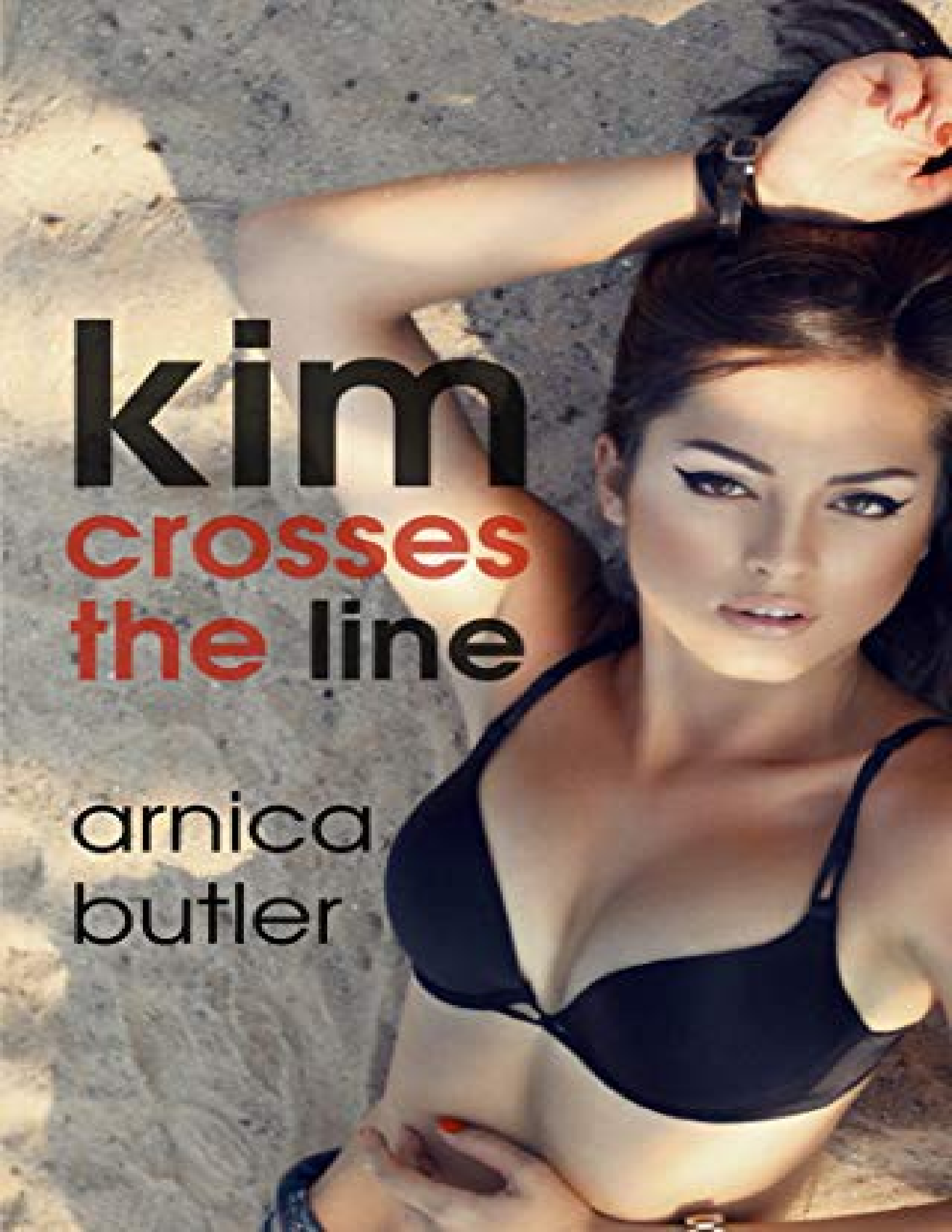


A woman with dark hair and dramatic eye makeup is lying on a sandy beach. She is wearing a black bikini top and has one hand behind her head. The background is a bright, sandy beach with some shadows.

kim crosses the line

arnica
butler

KIM CROSSES THE LINE

ARNICA BUTLER

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CHAPTER 1

It felt strange talking to her like this, at 6pm, looking out into the green-blue light of the city caught in the clouds. She sounded distant, freshly annoyed; like she still wanted to make the point that she wasn't happy with any of these decisions, even though they'd had countless "discussions" about it, and this is what they'd decided to do.

"So what are you doing with yourself?" he asked. The words felt like words for a friend you haven't seen in ten years and no longer recognize. The garage-band lead singer of your high school who worked at Merrill Lynch now.

It was a repetitive question, one he'd asked before, maybe even this same evening. She let out a sigh like she was tired of hearing it.

"You know, same old," she said.

Her voice was flat. He wondered if she was watching TV, or was on her computer, and a fountain of annoyance bubbled up inside of him. Then he realized that he himself was on his computer, scanning his daily reports; his mind was in two places at once.

"Is everything okay?" she asked suddenly, and her voice sawed through the thick silence like a blunt knife.

"Yeah," he said carelessly. "Why?"

He minimized the window he was looking at, as though he could make a point to her, somehow, over the phone and thousands of miles away, that he was now giving her his full attention.

"I don't know," she said.

She sounded bored: that was it. They both sounded bored, like this conversation, and everything else, was just a matter of going through the motions. "It's just... what were you calling about?"

"I just wanted to say 'hi,'" he said.

Too quickly. He cringed at the defensive tone in his voice.

Why did she *ask* things like that? Couldn't he call his wife?

"It's just a weird time to call," she retorted, and her voice was equally defensive.

There was another swampish silence.

"You have any big plans for tonight?" he asked, trying to sound cheerful. He came across, at least to himself, as almost maudlin. He could

almost hear Kim's eyes roll in their sockets over the phone.

"Yeah," she said. "I'm going to hit the bars, maybe tag along on one of those pub crawls, and then have a hot tub party with Mike and Elise."

This was pure sarcasm: Mike and Elise were an antiquated odd couple living in the only remaining original construction on Dillon Beach. They sunbathed naked at 5am and then disappeared inside their strange home, where Kim was convinced they were building a bomb shelter.

There was no hot tub, not in their house or Mike and Elise's.

"How *are* Mike and Elise?" Jessie asked, grateful that he could make a joke on some kind of common ground. He and Kim had spent countless hours laughing about them together.

"Haven't seen them," Kim said dryly. "They might be dead."

"No saggy boobs on the beach in the morning?"

"Nah. I don't get up at five anymore."

"No?"

Kim was refusing to lighten up, but he couldn't be deterred.

"What for?" Her tone was serious, a firm, steel-enforced concrete wall that had no cracks. She was not, she was telling him, going to forgive him for any of this. She was still mad. And he was going to pay for it, again and again and again.

He sighed. He was tired. "Look," he began. "I know this is tough, but it's just a few months, and then everything will be back to normal."

That's what you wanted, isn't it? He wanted to add.

"Don't *start*," she said dryly.

There was another long silence.

"Look, Kim, if you hate it so much, we can always... I don't know. Find a property manager. You can just come back now. Just bail on that contract." He tried to dampen the impatience in his voice, because he knew it was like gasoline on Kim's temper, but his own nerves were frayed to the edge when it came to this "topic."

He held back what he thought: "...because it isn't like it's a job that will go anywhere, anyway."

But her response was just as if he had said precisely the thing he had withheld. She clucked. Or tisked.

The sound reverberated through the receiver, rattling inside his ribcage. There was a particular, infuriating soreness in his chest that Kim

was able to ring like a bell whenever she wanted, and now it was clanging away inside of him.

“What are you doing tonight?” she asked abruptly. The question was delivered flat, a well-worn trope to change the subject.

“Uh...” he said. He had re-opened the window of his reports while he waited through the silence, and he was caught off-guard. There was something on the screen that was bothering him, a niggling error, but he couldn’t quite get at what it was.

Kim sighed.

“Just...uh, working,” he said.

“Right. Of course.”

The “of course” was sharp.

Another silence.

“Okay,” Kim said uncertainly. “Well, thanks for calling,” Kim said. And then, trying to make a joke: “I have to go darn my socks now.”

Jessie’s mind was half-buried in the numbers swimming across his screen, and perceived the playful note in her voice too late to react to the joke. “Okay, babe, have a good night, okay? I love you.”

There was no answer, and he was only just catching up to the sock darning comment when he pulled his phone from his ear, and saw that Kim had terminated the call without saying anything more.

He knew it was this kind of thing that made Kim mad. It didn’t help. He had a pang of guilt, and then a moment of anger, and then his mind was distracted from any musings on his marriage by the more visible problems on his computer screen.

CHAPTER 2

Kim tossed the phone on the glass table, where it landed with a disturbing crunching sound. She was satisfied for a moment, thinking maybe she'd broken it, and then she hurried to pick it up and make sure she hadn't.

Her eyes were wet, and her vision a little blurry. She tossed the phone again, more gently this time, and fumed, pulling her thumbnail repeatedly against her front teeth.

She picked up the phone again to look at the time. 6:27.

He was still at the office. Presumably. Since when had he ever called her out of the blue like that in the evening?

Her thoughts sank, like they were prone to do these days, getting darker and darker as if they were settling on the bottom of the ocean.

He was probably having an affair. Having an affair neatly accounted for the things that bothered her now: his willingness to let her stay here in Dillon Beach (an offer, made in haste and anger and thrown at him like a rock, because she *was* so very angry at him for dragging her here and then uprooting her *just* when she had started to like it. But she couldn't back down. Especially – *especially* – because he had agreed to it); his calling her at times like this, times he had never called her at before, as though he were trying to get her out of the way so that he could have the rest of his evening free.

Her eyes got hot and wet again and she wiped them impatiently. She liked to tell herself she was not an overly emotional person, though she was aware that anyone who knew her well would probably say something quite different. It was an example of one of those character flaws a person detests about themselves that everyone else finds charming.

She stared at the white, modern, walls of the house in Dillon Beach, which looked blankly and soullessly back at her. It felt like a reflection of her marriage, their fortunes: always being renovated, but growing more distant and cold with every "upgrade" to their lives. She hated this house, and she hated Dillon Beach. She hated all the bright colored shirts, the unhurried atmosphere that everyone called "relaxed," but which she took for stagnation, personally. It came across as Disney-fied and made her queasy.

Not only that, everything they'd left behind in Boston was gone. Their friends from the neighborhood had an out-of-sight, out-of-mind attitude about them, or moved somewhere else. Len and Michelle, who were a strange kind of friends - the kind you almost wanted to call frenemies - were the only people left in their lives. Len had been the one to convince Jessie to try Florida: they had a house here and they spent most of the year here. But they weren't the sort of people Kim felt she could confide in. They were, in fact, the sort of people she specifically didn't trust all that much.

The condo on Charles Street was sold, and they would never be able to live in that neighborhood again: it was the kind of place where real estate doubled like yeast in a petri dish, overnight, and the door closed quickly if you cashed out. There wasn't any real "going back" to Boston, not the way it had been when they'd left - and now it felt like a metaphor for their whole lives.

She had a flare of resentment toward Jessie, but it quickly burst, deflating into a murky sadness. Thoughts of the affair she imagined him having bubbled to the surface again. They were deeply entwined: her resentment, her jealousy, her paranoia, and her feelings of being slighted. It was easy to start being angry at Jessie if she was alone and let herself sink into the mood.

But she knew what she really wanted was for things to be like they were in the past, when Jessie was never too busy with work to spend time with her. She wanted their love life to be passionate again, less routine. For the first five years of their marriage, they had been like teenagers. But, as Jessie spent more time working, and especially after they had moved, they saw less and less of each other and sex had turned into something done more like eating dinner: a task without a ton of cheer in it, or enthusiasm. It was hard to say whose fault that was. Jessie wasn't exactly imaginative, and she wasn't inclined to be, either, and she felt like each of them was stubbornly refusing to take up the slack to make things exciting. The attitude seemed to be one of: *you* make it interesting, if that's what you want.

They'd gone to a therapist, but only made it to two appointments before everything went upside-down again. She hadn't liked the therapist much either, and she felt like Jessie wasn't all that inclined to go. They

hadn't spoken about returning since they cancelled the last appointment because Jessie was in Boston.

She stood up and swiped a bottle of wine off the counter, walking toward the sliding doors that led to the pool area, and then to the beach. Dillon Beach was not exactly Malibu: the water was usually gray, the sand was dark, and seagulls screeched relentlessly above an island about a mile out where, it was rumored, trash collected on the ocean side. But it was an up-and-coming area, one of those outposts that had become trendy through some queer blend of venture capital and millennial intrigue and an algae bloom of Airbnb's.

She plopped on the sand where it was still dry and opened the bottle of wine. Immensely enjoying the scene she was privately making, she chugged it without a glass.

She was so bored.

Every day in Dillon Beach dragged out. She could never be sure why she hadn't told Jessie that her class had been cancelled. It had probably been out of anger: when he had told her they needed to move back to Boston, she had flipped her lid. Maybe she should have told him she had only just adjusted to Dillon Beach, she had finally reconciled herself with the house, the tropical climate, the boozy college kids and the surfer lingo. It felt as if he had literally waited until the *second* she had started to feel at home to shift the winds on her again, and while intellectually she knew that couldn't possibly be true, she felt angry about it in her chest as though it were.

"And what about my class?" she had demanded.

She had probably really meant, *and what about me?*

But it hurt too much to ask him that. It hurt that she even had to ask him a question like that, it felt like, to get him to think about it, about her.

Her employment at University of Tampa was tenuous from the start, and she had never really expected the contract to go through. But she had staged a theatrical production about it, and Jessie had suggested that she stay in Florida so she could complete it, and by the time she had him acquiescing to her demand, it was far too late to take it back.

So here she was, with nothing to do but go to the gym, wait for Michelle to come back from whatever trip she had taken, and sit on the beach. She was of very English stock: porcelain-skinned and raven-haired, with green-blue eyes that smoldered over tidy, pretty features. She

possessed an ability to look hot, in a burning, sexual, depraved way, but she herself didn't know it, and instead kept her appearance well-groomed like an English garden. She looked a little like Megan Fox, people told her, when caught by surprise as a lock of hair slipped loose or she went too heavy on eye shadow and was caught in a glowing light. But Megan Fox restrained, a sort of librarian version of her.

She had drunk half a bottle of wine, she noted with satisfaction. Sometimes the idea overtook her, to become an alcoholic and "show Jessie," but she knew she couldn't commit to anything that self-destructive. She gulped some more wine. Who cared? It wasn't like she had to be anywhere tomorrow anyway.

It wasn't as if there was n't anything to do: she went to the gym obsessively, and she was actually very proud of how toned she'd gotten. She didn't like that she was more interested in how Jessie would react to it than her own personal pride or health, but the truth gnawed away at her. It also gave her something to do.

She could have joined a club or gone to a Meetup, or even just wandered into any one of the clubs or bars downtown, and she had gotten dressed up a few times to do just that. But when she caught a look at herself in the mirror on the way out, it seemed desperate. She was either desperate-looking, or too old, and her wedding ring gleamed at her admonishingly.

She heard a scuffle behind her, and a spray of sand raked across the exposed part of her back, just before she heard: "Get off me you fucking idiot!" and a male laugh. And then something struck her, hard, across the back, and she went sprawling forward into the sand.

"Jesus!" someone yelled, and Kim pushed herself up from the sand. The whole interaction had come upon her and been over so quickly she didn't have time to react to it, and because she was drunk, she wasn't annoyed.

Her hair had come loose, and the tight yoga shirt she had been wearing with the intention of doing yoga had risen to just above her navel, revealing the smooth, toned stomach she had unwittingly developed at the gym out of her boredom.

She was looking at the tanned, well-chiseled muscles of a young guy, a guy with the lanky form of post-adolescence - utterly trim, coiled with energy, incredibly *hot* -

She stopped herself.

Above the sinewy muscles, bare chest with small dark nipples and blackish-blue tattoo spanning one sinewy bicep, was a square-jawed guy with dark brown eyes and beach-bleached longish hair, a laugh fading from his lips as he used his muscled arms to shove another (equally tanned, also quite attractive) guy to the side. "Shit," he said, frowning. "Shit, uh... sorry. So sorry about that."

Kim pushed her hair back from her face. She was aware of her tendency to gloom on to people now that she was so lonely and bored, and had mentally rehearsed *not* babbling like an idiot to every person she saw. She tugged at her shirt, because she was vaguely aware that it was in the wrong place, and shook her head slightly, while forming her lips in what she hoped was a friendly smile.

She had no way of knowing that because her hair had been knocked loose, and the sun was setting, and her eyelids were heavy from all the wine, and her lips were stained in the center and brushed by sand on the outside, that she was channeling her very best Megan Fox.

The guy elbowed his friend again violently, and the dark-haired guy emitted a sharp "Fuck!"

"I'm really sorry, we didn't even see you. Are you, uh..." he turned toward her house, and then back at her. "You live here?"

"Eh," Kim said, waving her bottle in the general direction of the house. "For now." She was realizing that she was quite drunk, but her mood had improved and her inhibitions had been turned off just enough for her to enjoy looking up at the very handsome guy standing in front of her. She let her eyes drift to his board shorts, where his abdomen was hairless and smooth, and her mind wandered to what lay beneath.

Her eyes jerked upward, and if she had been more sober she would have flushed with embarrassment and even guilt.

"We're neighbors, then, for a while," the guy said.

Kim felt a pang of disappointment, and then guilt for feeling disappointed, because the guy kept his eyes rigidly fixed on her forehead. He extended his hand, and she took it: it was warm, radiating strength and energy, and it would feel absolutely spectacular on her throat, moving down...

"I'm Hunter," he said.

"Kimberly," she said quickly. And then, almost as though a puppeteer had taken over her mouth, she heard herself saying: "But everyone calls me

Jade.”

And not only that, she felt herself move her left hand to her hip, turning her fingers backward, tucking her ring finger away behind her.

It was ridiculous, and the ridiculousness washed over her and made her cheeks flush, which she could feel, hot on her cheeks. She pressed her lips together. No one called her Jade. No one had ever called her Jade; it was her middle name and people said things like, “That’s sexy,” when they found out what it was.

But nobody *called* her that.

Hunter kept his dark eyes steadily on hers. “Okay. Well. Jade. Sorry about the.. uh...” his eyes dropped briefly, and swept around, and he brushed some sand hastily from her elbow. The touch of his hand sent a slow burn through her, which washed up right in the lowest part of her abdomen and made her cheeks flare more. “Sorry. This guy is leaving. Soon.”

“No problem,” she said. She hoped he didn’t notice how slurred her speech was.

Hunter’s eyes dropped to the wine bottle, so he must have. He grinned. “You drinkin’ alone?”

She shrugged. “I don’t have anyone to drink with.”

She could feel a finger of hot guilt move down her spine for the way she had proclaimed this as if it were *permanent*. For the things she had left unsaid, like that her husband was in Boston and drinking alone was a temporary situation, to be remedied by her *husband*.

There was a beat of silence, and her chest felt like it was imploding, because only in that beat of silence did the tone and the implication of her words – which had left her mouth curled up and coquettish – get to her mind. What the hell was she doing? What was she *saying*? This kid was at least ten years younger than her.

And she was married.

Hunter, oblivious to these backwaters in her mind, smiled. “*That’s* no fun,” he said.

His friend punched him on the arm, and the muscles clapped together, hard and firm. “Goin’ in for a swim,” the friend said.

And he ran into the water.

Lacking anything better to do, Kim-Jade lifted the wine bottle to her mouth and took a swig of it. She felt as though she were watching herself,

and she was actually impressed, because if you looked at it one way, she seemed sort of cool.

Reality crashed over her again. She slipped the screw-on cap on top of the wine bottle. “Well,” she said. “I was just going in.”

Hunter was still looking rigidly at her hairline. So much so, that she wondered if she had a spider in her hair. “Yeah,” he said. “Of course. Hey, sorry again,” he said.

“It’s cool,” she said.

And they turned and parted ways. Her back tingled as she walked away from him, and she was just starting to shake her head at what an idiot she had probably come across as, when she heard him shout:

“Hey, Jade!”

She turned around with exaggeration, because it took an extra beat for her to realize he was talking to her, so she wanted to make up for the delay by... what? Turning enthusiastically?

“If you don’t have anyone to drink with tomorrow, we’re having a party. Come on over.”

She gave him a thumbs-up, and turned quickly to walk back to the house, stumbling slightly in the sand. She resisted the urge to turn around until she closed the sliding door, from which she had a nice view of the two guys in the distance, wrestling each other into the light surf. “Jesus,” she said, expelling a sigh. Then she slid the bottle onto the counter, poured herself a glass of water, spit it out because it was from the foul-tasting tap, unsteadily retrieved some from the bottled dispenser, and trudged upstairs, her head swimming.

CHAPTER 3

His conversation with Kim nagged him all evening, even while he buried himself in the inventory reports and dredged up the problem that had been bothering him all along, a warehouse error he had seen twice now and was starting to suspect was more deliberate than mistake.

He knew Kim was unhappy, and it sometimes made his heart ache to think about it. But it oscillated between aching and hardening with resentment: hadn't she *wanted* to move back home to Boston, hadn't she done *nothing* but complain about Florida, hadn't he done *everything* to make her happy and start this business so that they could be not only financially secure, but *successful*? She hated being a contract instructor, she hated teaching, she wanted to do something else, and he had nearly made it possible for her to do whatever she wanted.

And yet she was still unhappy. It was infuriating.

He picked up his cellphone, which he'd kept looking at intermittently, his heart racing whenever someone called or the annoying "beep" of his text messages sounded: he hoped it was her, that she would send him one of her usual messages. *Sorry I was so cranky. I had la ot on my mind. Or, don't go to bed angry. I love you.*

None of the messages were from Kim, however.

He swiped through his contacts, an eye on the time in the corner of his screen. It was ten. Early for Len and Michelle, but still...

He skimmed through his contacts, and was annoyed to find that he didn't have Michelle's number. Though it made sense: why would he?

He sighed, and typed a message to Len. Even as he did it, he wasn't certain *why*. Len was an old buddy, but that's all he was: a buddy. A cool guy who seemed to have everything, including a great relationship with his wife. He and Michelle were also the only people they really *knew* in Florida.

And they were the only people Kim really knew well.

Hey buddy you up? Can I call you?

He waited, tapping the phone against his lips, stewing about Kim. He was going to Florida this weekend: this was part of the deal, weekend trips

that were more traveling than time with her, in truth mostly because he wanted to fuck her, wanted to feel her underneath him and know that she was still his, mostly because he felt that he deserved it, after busting his ass for the two of them. It wasn't the kind of thing he could articulate to her – it would have sent her temper flaring – but it was the way he felt, deep down inside.

His phone vibrated against his mouth.

Sure

But the phone was already ringing. Len hated texting. He was maybe the last person on earth who did.

“Hey buddy,” Len said, without waiting for a reply when the ring tone ceased. “What’s up?”

Len was the kind of guy who had practiced the art of sounding groggy and put-out no matter when you called or what about. Jessie could see him rubbing his face, another gesture he had refined to the point of caricature, in order to give the impression that he was a busy man, an alpha male, and you were lucky to be talking to him.

It was mostly an act, but Jessie could feel himself falling for it just the same. Len was raven-haired, a sprinkling of salt and pepper creeping away from his temples, giving him a very dignified look. He owned a yacht, he was trim in the way that expensive, adrenaline-pumping sports like kite surfing and extreme skiing made you trim, and he had a square-jawed, slightly unshaven masculinity about him that gave you the sense he had walked straight out of a Hemingway novel.

“Hey, uh...” Jessie hesitated. It now seemed like a mistake to be calling Len, but he had no way of backing out. “I was just wondering if, uh... I just got off the phone with Kim. A while back.” He paused. Len managed to sound impatient without making a sound. “You guys around this week? She seems a little... I don’t know. Overworked. Lonely. Something.”

He wasn’t sure what he was saying, or asking for. Maybe if he had peeled back a few layers he would have realized that he wanted his friends to keep an eye on Kim, because there was a part of him that had, all through their marriage, been acutely cognizant of the fact that he was hitting far above his weight. Kim might not have known it – Len had commented on this very fact a number of times, that Kim seemed utterly clueless about her

sexual appeal, and if she ever figured it out, Jessie would be out on his ass faster than he could say “boo” - but Jessie was, deep down inside, motivated to do most of the things he did by the raw reality of it. Kim wouldn't leave him if he could buy her beachfront property, or send their kids to a private school in Boston, or if he was just successful enough that she became a trophy wife.

“She's probably bored,” Len drawled. He sighed. “What do you want me to do?”

Jessie tapped his pen on the desk. “I don't know. Maybe you and Michelle could...”

Len said nothing to Jessie's pause, which was unusual for him. He was a get-to-the-point kind of guy, and the quickest in the world to finish unfinished sentences.

Then: “You want us to swing around there, buddy? Take her out or something?”

“Uh,” Jessie said. Was that what he wanted? “Well, I think it might be good for her...”

There was a long silence.

“You know what?” Len said. “This is perfect. I'm bored out of my fucking mind down here, to be honest, man. Not a problem. I'll take her out and get her drunk.”

Jessie's mouth fell open. “Uh...”

“Who knows what will happen?” Len added, delivering his usual line. It was an old joke, for Len to say something about Kim, like that he was going to get her alone and play Truth Or Dare, or, if they went skiing, that he would be her Abominable Snowman. Stuff like that. Benign, mostly truthless-seeming banter.

Usually he said this kind of thing when Michelle was in the room and everyone rolled their eyes about it.

Tonight, though, it had a foreboding feel to it.

Jessie rubbed his eyes. “Just don't shtup my wife,” he said, upholding his end of the joke.

“Course not, buddy,” Len said.

But, it seemed to Jessie, he said this a few seconds later than he normally did.

Len was an old friend from college. The kind of friend you make when you're thrust into a project with someone and you think they're cool, and then you just end up in their wake for years and years, with no time to consider if you're actually friends or not. Michelle and Kim got along okay, but Michelle had always seemed a little wilder than Kim wanted in a friend.

Friends, when you got older and out of college, became harder to make, and so, like everyone else, Jessie had just stuck to the ones he had. Uneasily at times, as he did with Len. He was the kind of guy who made Jessie uneasy when he was around, but had always followed through on the loyal friend bit – sometimes in magnanimous acts of generosity or helpfulness – so Jessie inevitably felt like a heel for doubting him.

He closed his eyes.

Len was a good friend, he reminded himself. He had a Barbie-doll blonde hottie of a wife, who performed (if you believed Len's telling of it) outrageous sex acts for the sheer thrill of it. Michelle was a hard-core skier with a bright smile and a sexy nasal voice, naturally white-blond hair and an Aryan appearance, a tight ass and perky tits. Evidently, she liked anal sex.

Kim was the kind of girl who ate with a knife and fork in small bites with a napkin on her lap.

Len *always* joked about Kim, he reminded himself.

Kim didn't especially like Len, he also reminded himself. She thought he was a boorish adrenaline junkie and only laughed at his jokes out of politeness.

Any uneasiness he felt about this last conversation with Len was, then, just silly. It was getting to him, being away from her. All their unfinished marital arguments, the false hope of therapy – also unfinished – and, above all, the distance that was keeping them from having sex or sharing their lives.

All this would be over soon. He just needed to bear down and get through it. And so did Kim.

He popped the lid of a Robax bottle and shook one into his hand. Then he found the Benadryl and took one as well. And, like he had on so many other nights, he closed the blinds on his office, dimmed the lights, and stretched out on the large Italian leather sofa to sleep.

This was all going to go away soon: the unease, the living apart, the unhappy Kim, the shakiness of the business, gaseous, unclear ideas like the

one he had now about Len “schtupping” his wife. Everything would go back to normal.

The Benadryl pulled him into a groggy state, and numbers and accounts swarmed over his eyelids, tied, through the weird logic of dreams, vaguely to his wife and Len, their hands exchanging balances over a candlelit table, entwining, adding up, blending one column with the other... until he fell into a jumbled sleep.

CHAPTER 4

His lips were warm and dry when she first kissed him, but it had steadily progressed to a wet, deep exploration of each other's mouths as he pushed her back against his friend's chest. They were wearing only board shorts, and her back stuck to the hot flesh of his chest, the contours of his muscles in relief against her spine, patches of sand slightly abrasive against her skin.

The friend breathed against the back of her neck, lifting her hair to get his lips close enough to brush against the fine hairs there, electrifying her. "We're going to fuck you until you can't walk," he told her, against her ear. One hand was snaking around her neck, hot against her throat, while the other moved along her side, over her ribs, tugging at a bikini that fell apart like a paper dressing gown and disappeared.

Her nipples were hard against Hunter's chest: he moved in on her and she was sandwiched between them. He bit her lip gently, and then drank from her mouth, suffocating a moan as his friend's hand somehow made its way to the back of her knees.

Hands were everywhere, in places it didn't seem possible, and she didn't know whose was whose anymore, only that they were smooth and strong, and touching her everywhere. She felt Hunter's fingers slip into her pussy, finding her clit, swirling his finger against the face of it.

His friend's cock was pressed against the small of her back, and Hunter's was against her pelvis, thick and solid as a rock.

"Have you ever been fucked by two guys at once?" he asked her.

But before she could answer, they had fallen into a bed, and she was facing him, his cock stretching her open, and his friend's fingers pushing her ass apart. "Just relax," the friend said. "We're going to get you all filled up."

It was only then that, like so many realistic dreams of hers, she realized somewhere in the back of her semi-conscious mind that she was dreaming. It didn't hurt when he entered her – it frustratingly felt like nothing, because she had never done that before. The ache between her legs could not be sated, and the dream began to disintegrate: she had realized it was a dream and she was fighting to stay in it, between their hot, hard muscles with their cocks swollen inside of her, sweat making her slip

between them frictionlessly... a vibration had begun in her abdomen, and she wondered what it could be, some kind of toy? It strengthened and faded, and the need inside of her abdomen grew but was never sated.

She looked at Hunter, but he began to fade...

She sat up.

The vibration disappeared, and light poured through the open window. It was bright, which meant it was mid-morning at least.

Her eye sockets hurt, and the lingering dissatisfaction of her dream pooled between her legs as an ache. Her eyelids were pleasantly heavy. She heard her phone – downstairs.

Suddenly hot, she shoved the covers off of her and flopped back on the pillows. The room was startlingly white, and her eyeballs ached a little, so she closed them.

The events of the preceding evening trickled into her consciousness, and her cheeks flared a little as she thought of herself, idiotically talking to the neighbor kid. Her eyes flew open as a pang of guilt stabbed her in the abdomen. And then embarrassment. God, he was half her age, she must have seemed like a cougar.

And then that dream...

She could feel that her dream had stirred up a real “emotion” in her, because her panties were damp.

How long had it been since something like *that* had happened?

God. It was so embarrassing.

She reminded herself that... what was his name? Hunter?... had no way of reading her mind, no way of knowing about the cougarish, almost illegal activity in her dream, and no one was home to witness any of this. But the embarrassment lingered. It was an aspect of her personality that she was starting to dislike, like a lot of women her age. What the hell did it matter if she had private thoughts like this? You could bet men had them all the time.

She swung her feet around to the highly polished wood floor that gleamed like glass, and plodded downstairs. She needed water, and she was not going to make the same drunken mistake as last night and swish that crappy tap water around in her mouth.

As she drank, she looked out the window to the fence that ran along the edge of the next-door property and disintegrated into the sand about twenty feet out to the beach. She pictured the house: not as new or large as

hers, sandstone-colored, lots of glass. It had a big pool made of dark stone with an infinity edge. The lights were almost always on in the same pattern, most likely timed lights – they wouldn't have helped anyone in the immense house.

It was all she could remember about the place. It seemed like the home of investors, not a family. She wondered what the guys were doing there.

Thinking of Hunter made her stomach uncomfortably cool, so she tied up her thick hair and hurried to the phone on the glass table, as if she could walk briskly away from her thoughts. A vibrating phone could send a minute vibration through the glass to the tile and up the sleek modern stucco walls, right to her bed. It had happened before.

She swept the screen unlocked and looked at the missed call: *The Sladester*.

Len had, with his usual infantile humor, changed his name and picture in her phone. "*The Sladester*" was a picture of a bare-chested Bruce Willis from the eighties.

Hardly any resemblance.

Whatever static the idea of Len caused her (Len was annoying and adolescent), she felt her mouth turning up in a smile. At least he was someone to talk to, and Michelle was probably making plans through him.

Or, more likely, he had some idiotic favor to ask her for, which had also been known to happen.

She started to call him back, and then changed her mind, clearing her throat and pushing her bangs out of her face. She didn't like to admit to herself, or even think about it, but she had a weird thing with Len. She despised him, she wasn't attracted to him, and she didn't have any real fond feelings for him, but something made her want to leave a very specific impression on him. She very *specifically* wanted Len to know that she didn't find him attractive, that she didn't care what he thought about anything, and that she didn't think about him at all, one way or the other.

She chalked it up to Len always acting really aloof around her, which she found irritating. She had decided long ago that he did it just to assert dominance over everyone, or because he was an asshole (one was kind of the same as the other).

"God," she muttered, setting her phone down. She felt terrible, she was having erotic menage dreams about young, young guys, and now she was having some kind of weird... "thing" about calling Len. Not only that, she

thought sadly, she was having some kind of weird “thing” with her own husband, who was so far away.

All because she had been childish. She could be in Boston right now, without any of these problems.

All she had to do was call Jessie and tell him that she wanted to go home.

Thinking of Jessie gave her a pang in the chest, and her mood went spiraling downward.

She opened the fridge and dug a half-used Gatorade out of the back. She chugged it with determination: she was going to shower, go to the gym, work the hangover out of her system, and then – and only then, hours later, would she call Len back.

Even if she would really love to talk to pretty much anyone right now.

*

Things were going fine at the gym for about half an hour. Electing to exercise hard, with the hopes of clearing her head, she had set herself up on a cross-country 60 minute program on a treadmill in a corner where people rarely exercised. There was an indoor track at her gym, which is really what she preferred, but she didn’t want anyone watching her. She needed to clear her head.

And for thirty minutes, it worked: she concentrated on her run and really got in the zone. Len, Hunter and his friend, her erotic dreams, and her marital distress, slowly faded to the back of her mind.

And then, almost as if the entire universe was contriving to drive her completely crazy in a very particular way, *he* showed up.

It wasn’t as if this was a completely new thing, but it certainly didn’t need to come at her right then.

The guy was obviously some kind of white-collar worker – she had seen him show up in a suit and stepping out of an expensive vehicle, and the suit, which she didn’t know anything about, certainly looked expensive. He often came with the same friend, an athletic and otherwise unmemorable man who also wore a suit. Maybe. She hadn’t paid much attention to that guy.

Because next to *this man*, his friend was actually so forgettable he might as well not have even been there.

He was easy to spot, her man, because he was so black he almost didn't look real. And he was at least a foot taller than any other man in the gym. His shoulders were broad, and his arms, while not particularly huge, were cut with a sinewy muscle that drew immediate attention. And, if you dared to look at his face – which most people, Kim noticed, didn't, for a reason that she sensed was so primal no one wanted to think about it – he was really, really, really good-looking.

And even though it was absolutely absurd – something she gave a particularly mindful note of to herself by twisting her wedding ring around her ring finger to feel the weighty reminder of it – she could not help the feelings that got stirred up inside of her.

She never fantasized about him sexually: he was actually too scary to her to even think about that sort of thing. When he was in the gym he sort of buzzed around her, and her skin tingled whenever he passed. It was actually really stupid: he made her feel the way she had felt in high school when she had had a crush on a senior.

Also, he was so *black*. She had never been with a black guy, and she didn't like the way her mind stubbornly went to the most racist, typical tropes out there.

And now, he was here. Jogging around the track, his big hands (and they were *huge*) spread wide for emphasis as he said something to his imminently forgettable buddy. He was so tall and so muscled that he didn't appear to be exerting himself any more than most people might do walking. And yet they were going at a good clip.

Kim stared at her cross country program with determination. Concentrate on *running*.

But her mind was slipping away again... back to the black man's arms, his dark eyes, the size of his hands.

Her stomach had yet another pang of cold-hot "something," and she wiped her forehead with the back of her hand. She could not believe it, but she was actually thinking about what she was wearing: her shorts, which were not all that short. Did she look good in them? Was her face all red, and her hair staticky?

A guy like that, she thought sullenly, probably had a really, really hot, young girlfriend. She was probably black and had huge pillow lips and a rock-hard, perfect ass. A guy like that, she reminded herself, would not even

look at some thirty-something, pale white girl with dark hair and a beet face, running like an idiot on a treadmill.

And why would she even be thinking about this anyway?

He was going around the track again, his ebony skin like a blip on a radar screen. She was sucking her stomach in – not that she needed to – and running with her head up high and her back straight.

She didn't like to admit it, but she was.

She turned the speed up on her course. The best thing for her right now, was to get so anaerobic that she couldn't think straight about any of this. Because no matter how much she hated it, she felt guilty for having thoughts like the ones she was having. Especially when Jessie was so far away – physically and mentally.

It's just a rough patch, she told herself, as she pounded on the treadmill. She set her breathing to it: *just – a- rough – patch*.

The man disappeared, and she felt relief stabbed with disappointment. She kept running at the absurd pace she had set for herself, because she wasn't the kind of girl to back down or slouch off a goal once it was set.

She had to walk an extra five minutes for cool down, and it was during that time that she looked over at a mirror reflecting the small corner of the gym where she liked to hide, and her heart almost jumped through her nostrils.

He was there, using some set of weights that she had never seen anyone use. His arm bulged as he lifted an enormous free weight repeatedly, his legs spread wide, his elbow on one knee, and his calm, beautiful face only slightly strained.

And his eyes?

Right on her.

Or, more specifically, her ass.

Her cheeks flared up and she looked hastily at the console. Luckily, her face was probably quite red, so he wouldn't be able to see the difference anyway. And what the hell was *she* getting all worked up about? *He* was the one staring at *her*, if he was even doing that.

She wondered if her ass looked good in the shorts she was wearing, briefly wished she had worn a different, high-cut black pair, dismissed the thought almost as quickly as she had it, and added a few minutes to her time.

She could just walk here until he left. She was almost positive that she was physically incapable of turning around and walking past him without making an ass of herself somehow.

He kept working out, and she desperately flung her eyes around the gym to avoid looking at him. But he was still there, and he was making her body feel like mush.

Oh God, she thought bitterly. This was so stupid.

He was just a man.

A hot man.

A very, very black man with huge hands and hard muscles.

But a man.

And there was no way he was paying any attention to her, and she needed to stop acting like a fucking idiot. She would just turn around, walk past him, and that would be that.

She stopped the treadmill.

She calmly wiped it off, glad that her hands were cooperating even though they felt detached from her body. She took a steadying breath, and turned, and, watching her feet, she stepped off the treadmill and tossed the towel in a basket. Just keep walking, she told herself, and kept her eyes on the door to the locker room.

He made a strained sound as he lifted a final rep, and then she heard the heavy thud of the weight settling into a cradle. He had stood up, she could feel him looming over her.

“That was a long run.”

It was undoubtedly his voice: there was no one else it could have come from, and it was a velvet baritone that could only have come from a man his size.

And color.

She was shot through the chest by a twang of panic, because she had not bargained on him speaking to her, and as the milliseconds passed, it was more obvious than ever, even though she was lifting her foot and keeping her eyes on the locker room, that he was talking to her.

She would have to do *something*.

She couldn't ignore him.

Her mind was moving quickly as her body seemed to be in slow-motion.

And then, to her mortification, she found herself whipping around (too fast, too eagerly, too shakily, too... much of everything) and saying what had to be the most white-bread, vanilla, suburban-soccer-mommy thing *ever*:

“What’s that?”

He was pulling a towel down against his neck with two hands. His expression floored her, though it was difficult to say why, but she forced herself to look right at him. Right at his surprisingly light-colored, greenish eyes, and their somehow menacing gaze.

His lips – large, but smooth, not outrageously puffy – slid over each other and his chin moved almost imperceptibly toward her, while sweat trickled down his arm, snaking over the arteries that she could almost feel pulsing under her fingertips. His gaze didn’t change, only his eyelids squeezed a little more around his eyes, which she was now thinking were gray-green, disturbingly pretty. A color she had never seen before, or maybe just noticeable because they were set against such dark skin.

One hand, still holding the towel, pointed at the treadmill.

“You ran a long time,” he said, and he had a tone in his voice that somehow conveyed that he knew that she had heard him perfectly fine the first time.

Her abdomen twisted and she understood, for the first time in her entire life, the expression “going weak at the knees.”

She looked over at the treadmill. “Oh,” she said. “Yeah. I like to. Run.”

He smiled. It was a smile she had never really seen before. She couldn’t tell if it was wolfish, or patronizing, or friendly, or dismissive. Perhaps he was amused by the very obvious power he held over women, and it was a smug smile.

“I know,” he said.

The words, for whatever reason, plucked something inside of her from abdomen to chest, almost as if a string had been connected to her clitoris and the place where crushes settle behind your sternum. She was grateful, then, that he brought the towel over his head, and started to rub the shaved crown of it vigorously, the towel hiding his face, before she blabbed:

“Okay, well... uh, see you around.”

She forced herself to turn, and start walking to the locker room.

She yanked the shower curtain closed and stepped under the still-too-cold water in order to hide even further from whatever weirdo thing she had just done.

I know.

What had he meant by that? Did he know because he watched her? Was he trying to say he had seen her before? The way he had said it had been so particular, with tone that seemed to say not only that he knew that, but he wanted her to know he approved it.

She threw open her eyes, to get herself back to reality, and the semi-salty shower water burned in her eyes, which she rubbed furiously.

She was really, really starting to act like a crazy person.

Black Guy had just been talking. Making conversation, which was a thing people do. He “knew” that she liked to run because she had just run for sixty minutes. She was acting like a fucking idiot.

Although.. it was interesting that he had talked to her.

It wasn’t a conversation that he had to have, like pass me that towel, or are you still using this machine?

She turned the water off and snatched her towel from a hook. She really was coming apart like a five-dollar watch.

*

Len had called again while she had been running. But more unusually, because Len never did this sort of thing, he had left a message.

“Shit,” she said aloud. What if there was some kind of emergency?

She fumbled with the phone and became annoyed when she couldn’t remember her password. No one left messages anymore. No one but Len, who was an avowed non-texter.

But as she did all of this, in the heat of her car, because she had closed the door without turning the key and getting the AC going, she became increasingly convinced it was an emergency. She dialed Len almost frantically, feeling guilty about every dumb thing she’d done since last night. God, please don’t let anything have happened to Jessie.

“Hey,” Len said casually.

“Hey,” she said breathlessly. She turned on the car and fumbled with the controls. “Is everything all right?”

“Are you okay?” Len asked. His voice was monotone, as always. “You sound like you’re running or something.”

“I just got out of the gym,” she said. “I just got your message. I mean, I didn’t actually get it, because I can’t check my.. anyway. I thought maybe something was wrong.”

It was becoming increasingly clear that nothing was wrong, and now she was annoyed at herself, because she was giving Len exactly what he wanted: attention. Breathless attention.

There was a silence. “Everything’s fine,” Len said. “I’m just calling you because, uh, we thought, hell, why not give Kimmy a call and go out to eat or something? Tonight.”

Kim blinked.

She hated when he called her “Kimmy,” though she couldn’t say exactly what aspect of it got under her skin. In fact, he was so smug in the way he was asking that she very much wanted to slap him, or say no, or hang up.

“Oh,” she said. “Why didn’t Michelle call?”

“She’s out of town right now,” Len said, as if he had been expecting the question all along.

Kim made a face, and looked at herself in the rearview mirror. Her face queried her own puzzled face.

He had answered the question evasively, and she knew that it was her responsibility to follow up on it now: was Len asking her to dinner with just him, or also with Michelle when she returned? Was Michelle not calling because she was on a plane at the moment, or was Len... she didn’t know...plotting something?

But something stopped her from clarifying.

She was lonely enough at this point, after so many nights alone, that she would do just about anything to at least have a conversation.

Hunter’s lean body – unrelated, intrusive - flashed in front of her eyes.

It was better, she quickly decided, if she was not home when that party got going. It was the sort of stupid thing she might actually do, and she already felt a little out of control as it was.

“Uh...” Kim said. “Okay. Well, where to?”

“There are about four hundred bars on your street, Kim.”

It was true, at the end of the street that ran in front of her house, there were probably at least fifty bars and clubs and restaurants. She was just too

chicken to go into any of them alone.

“How about I come by around eight,” Len said, almost as though he were bored.

“Yeah, okay,” she said vaguely.

Eight was late, wasn’t it? Late for dinner.

Whatever. It would be fun.

Never one to mince words, Len said, “K. See you then.”

And hung up.

The car was finally cooling down. No-Name Black Man was fading from her mind.

Suddenly, she sucked in her breath. She typed quickly.

What should I wear?

There was no response for quite a while, and she started to regret sending the text, especially “as-is,” because what she had really wanted to know was if it was casual or slightly upscale, but now that she thought about it she had just stuck her foot in her mouth again, in a way.

Why? Why was she having all these weird interactions with men today?

Why did she even think about this stuff?

She must have a guilty conscience or something. And that led her back to thinking about Jessie, who seemed so far away right now, while all of these... men... seemed so close.

Her phone dinged and she looked at the screen.

Black cocktail dress you wore at Jim Young’s wedding

Kim blinked.

She had expected a joke from Len – a vulgar one: “nothing at all,” “a hooker costume,” - something like that.

Or no reply, which was the response she would have put her money on.

This, though... this was...

So specific.

She had the feeling, deep inside, even if she had not allowed her consciousness to recognize it, that she had now officially crossed some line. It was easy enough to know if you’d done it, when you bothered to think

about it: pretend Jessie was looking over her shoulder, would see this exchange. Would Jessie approve of her going out with Len and Len alone? Would Jessie approve of her asking him what to wear, and then of Len telling her so specifically to put on what was easily her sexiest dress?

That was all an easy “no,” and so the snake of guilt writhed around inside of her as she held the phone in two hands and did nothing for several minutes.

She tossed the phone in the passenger seat, shaking her head, and put the car into gear. This was obviously just some weird thing that Len was doing, trying to rattle her or something. Or not. In all likelihood, she was reading too much into everything, all because she’d been unfaithful to Jessie in a dream.

And a little in her mind.

Len was an old friend. He was bored. He was also married. She couldn’t stand him, and she wouldn’t have had anything to do with him if not for the fact that he and Michelle were the only people she knew even halfway-well in this crazy town.

So *what* if they went out to dinner?

She could always, truthfully, claim that she had thought Michelle would be there.

She knew, though, that she would not.

And she could always claim, because no one could ever know this but her – she could claim that there was no flicker of excitement in her chest at the prospect of going out with Len and Len alone.

She backed out fast, and tore off onto the highway.

She felt very, very tired.

CHAPTER 5

“Mr. Young?”

Stew, a delicately-featured gay intern who had turned into Jessie’s personal assistant, was standing in the door. He was the sort of guy who made a perfect personal assistant because he had an aura of perpetual semi-displeasure, which he was bravely fighting off, and he seemed constantly harried. This gave everyone the impression that he was in a huge hurry and they needed to solve their own problems if at all possible.

“I have a visitor here for you,” he said, and then he cleared his throat. “She doesn’t have an appointment,” he added acidly, and then put on his face of heroic professionalism. “She said she’s a friend. A Miss... Michelle Slade?”

Jessie looked at him blankly.

“Should I tell her you’re busy, then?”

Stew did not like any hint of impropriety to surround him, especially when it came to ladies “visiting.” He seemed to be as protective of Kim and Jessie’s marriage as he would be if they were his own parents.

“Michelle *Slade*?” Jessie repeated. And then, sensing that Stew was becoming ever more disapproving, he waved toward himself. “Send her in, yeah... weird.”

For Stew’s benefit, he tried to act casual. “You don’t know Michelle? She and Kim are really good friends.”

Stew shot him a look to let him know that he would be the judge of that, but sauntered away to let Michelle in.

Michelle. What the hell?

He took out his phone, swiping through his calls to make sure he hadn’t lost his mind, or perhaps in the hope that his messages or call record would somehow explain to him why Michelle was in his office, when Len indeed seemed to be in Florida and planning to take Kim out to dinner.

Michelle appeared in the doorway, distracting him from his thoughts. She was a distracting woman. She was wearing a simple outfit of rust-colored suede pants and a cream blouse that dipped salaciously low, framing the rounded hills of her breasts. He made his eyes focus, with determination, on her forehead, because she seemed to be not wearing a bra, and each time she moved, the cream colored blouse was swaying over her

nipples, and he was almost 100% sure he had seen their hard, pink pebbles through the fabric.

“Uh, Michelle,” he said, standing up and sticking out his hand. “What, uh?”

Michele gave his hand a strange look, and walked around the desk to hug him. She smelled like a spa: her shampoo, like her clothes, was outrageously expensive, and the smell of them told you just that.

“Jessie,” she cooed. “I’m sorry I didn’t call first. I was up here to take care of some odds and ends with the bank, and then a friend stood me up, and I was right here so I thought, huh! I’ll come check out the new office.”

She stepped back, and gave the whole office an exaggerated appraisal. “It’s gorgeous,” she said, in a deep, full voice. “Wow, you really *must* be doing all right. Wow.”

Jessie was too surprised by her visit, still pondering what Len’s situation was with dinner, trying to figure out how to talk to Michelle about that very subject, to say anything intelligent. Michelle walked around, sliding her slender hands over the teak furniture, tipping her head back to take in the expensive art, dragging her hand over the fabric of the sofa for client meetings. She let out an appreciative whistle.

There was no denying that Jessie’s ego was soaking it up: a leggy blond with a pretty face stroking his hard-earned furniture. Why wouldn’t Kim do something like this once in a while?

“You’re Mr. Big-Time now, huh?” Michelle said, her eyes wide with excitement like she had just seen a huge whale in the sea. “So great for you.”

And it seemed like an afterthought, with a long pause between the sentences that was probably only a millisecond, when she added: “Two.”

He blinked. Oh, as in, “you two.”

Him and Kim.

She sat on the couch and bounced on it, and the cream blouse bounced with her, slightly staggered, that so on each down-bounce the valley between her breasts lengthened and the collar slipped to reveal more of her perfect tan. She was tan everywhere, with no lines, because Michelle was the kind of girl who suntanned naked, and frequently enough to give her a perfect color, no more. “This is like a psychiatrist’s couch,” she said, even though it wasn’t, at all. It was blue and hard and had two armrests on either side.

She stretched out and lay back, and the blouse spread open to her nipples, which didn't show but promised to, deliciously, like a pair of mischievous eyes behind a curtain. Jessie stared, still unable to speak, as Michelle's suede-covered thighs crossed and she lay her head back, spreading her golden hair behind her. "Are you super-busy?" she asked, once she had settled. "Or can you take me to lunch?"

Jessie's heart plummeted: he had a conference call in fifteen minutes. But he was also relieved, because Michelle was acting very strangely.

"I, uh... I can't *now*," he stuttered.

And that's where he should have stopped, but Michelle rolled her head on the couch, and was about to say it herself, anyway.

"But maybe tonight? Will you still be here?"

Michelle rolled up. The movement was sensual, and the blouse slipped over her skin, promising but never delivering a view of her breasts. "I'm leaving in the morning," she said, in her husky, nasal voice. "So that's perfect. Come and get me at like, eight, or something? I'm at the Victoria."

She gave him no time to say no, or probe further, or even think about Len and Kim. Her body was so alluring, especially with the shifting velour of the suede pants, that all Jessie could do was focus on her forehead and try not to look lecherous.

"I'll see you then," she said, and leaned over the desk to kiss him on the cheek. "You find us something to do," she said.

And then she left, but not before – and he was only half-sure of this because it seemed so surreal – not before trailing her fingers down his shirt.

CHAPTER 6

She stared into her closet.

If there was one thing she definitely could not do, it was wear the black dress from the wedding. Whether Len had said it as a joke, or genuinely, it would be somehow way over the line to wear it, just because he had requested it. That was definitely flirting. Somehow.

And, secretly, she wanted to refuse to do what Len had asked her to do. Even deeper inside, she knew that she wanted to do that to get *his* attention.

She held the black dress up to her body in front of the mirror. It *was* the best dress she owned: it conformed to her body in sultry curved cuts, revealing just enough flesh through thick interlocking straps to be hot, without being slutty.

Oh, fuck it, she thought. She pulled it on, just to try it out and admire her appearance in the mirror, because the dress made her feel -

“What the -?”

She pulled at the dress. She had actually lost enough weight that it was slightly baggy on her, and the material had some give. She squeezed it and pulled it away from her body.

“Huh,” she said.

She pulled the dress off and threw it on the bed. Then she looked at her body in the mirror.

She didn’t know exactly how it had escaped her notice until now, but all the working out at the gym had, in fact, trimmed off the very slight puffiness that had been gathering at her arms, her belly, and her hips. She turned sideways. She actually... looked better than she had in years.

She put her hands on her hips, glowing with the very specific kind of satisfaction that only a woman who has lost weight and toned up her muscles can have.

Then she chewed on her lip, and dipped into her closet.

She had to really wade back into it – it was a walk-in and there were still boxes of clothes she had never unpacked from their move *here*. She dug into them. In one of them, she knew, was the pair of jeans that all women keep and occasionally try on to see if they have ever gone back to the size they were in whatever year they liked that pair of jeans.

She never tried them on, because the result would always be disappointing.

But she did so now, and they slipped on easily and fastened, and when she turned to admire her ass in the mirror it actually looked... good.

Maybe great.

She had never exactly been sure what it was that attracted men to asses in the first place.

She felt a rush of that specific kind of shallow joy that weight loss or looking good give you. Or flirtation from the opposite sex.

She admired herself for a long time, before digging into her closet for a shirt that would flatter her as much as the jeans. She tried on several before settling for a clingy red one, with a low neckline and tight sleeves.

Casual. Sexy.

Plausibly deniable on that last note (well, nothing else *fit*.)

She admired herself for several turns. Behind her image in the mirror, in the reflected distance of the now-darkening outdoors, a light appeared in a black void.

Her heart stopped in her chest.

The neighbor's house. And now, a square of yellow reminding her that there were windows. And that her own window had been open all this time.

She willed herself to move as though she hadn't noticed. That would be the way someone dignified would act. She hoped no one had been watching. Mainly because she had been so vain, and because she had to strain to think about whether she had been talking to herself or posing stupidly, which she often did.

She did not feel bad, in particular, that one of those two boys had seen her.

But that was another dark secret that she did not allow to climb the ladders of her subconscious to where she would have to acknowledge it.

She had several glasses of wine before Len arrived. She wasn't sure why. She had jitters like she was going out on a date, though Len was not at the forefront of her mind. She stared through the partially-drawn curtains of the living room, over the edge of her wine glass, toward the house where the party would be. In predictable college-aged fashion, there were no signs of a party at all. It was five to eight. Her stomach was twisted in knots.

She should tell Jessie, she decided. The honest, loyal-wife thing to do was to text Jessie now and tell him that Len seemed to be picking her up without Michelle, and did that seem weird to him, and then... he would have to say no, and she would still be able to go out, with a clean conscience.

She picked up her phone and settled on talking to him. It seemed like the most honest thing to do, and maybe if she spoke to him she would be forced to mention that she thought she was going out with Len alone.

Give him the chance to tell her not to do that.

As the phone rang, the idea gathered steam inside of her: she could pawn the disapproval off on Jessie. Jessie said he thought it was a little weird, so I better not.

But when his answering service picked up, she lost the resolve entirely.

She hung up, realizing she was going to lie to him, not wanting the lie recorded in her voice.

It was only a small lie, she thought, and it was perfectly possible that she might not have known that Michelle wouldn't be there.

So: was it all that much of a lie?

She typed.

Hey... going out with Michelle and Len somewhere down the street

She frowned at the end of the message. How to end it? She typed "just so you know," but felt it implicated her in updating Jessie if Len showed up alone, which she was almost positive he was going to do.

She typed:

Love you, have a good night.

And then regretted sending it, because "love you," sounded like careless love, and "I love you," sounded more genuine.

But it was too late, the message was gone.

*

If Len noticed that she wasn't wearing the black dress, he gave nothing away at the outset. She opened the door for him, even though it was

unlocked.

He was dressed in a white shirt and jeans, stubbornly good-looking. He swept his eyes over her body, and she found herself stepping on the annoyance that bubbled up in her when he made the perusal quick and said nothing about it.

To keep up appearances, she craned her neck and looked behind him. “What about Michelle?” she asked innocently.

Len’s face betrayed an instantaneous interest, and Kim regretted the act she was putting on: he saw right through it, she thought miserably, which would only key him in to the fact that she felt guilty, or nervous, or *something* about Michelle not being here. Which would, of course, make his head get all big, which she hated.

“Out of town,” he said, the slightest grin turning up the corner of his mouth. “Remember?”

“Oh, I thought she might...” her voice trailed off. She didn’t much feel like finishing the sentence, mostly a lie.

Not caring that the sentence was unfinished, Len said:

“You got some vodka or something I could slam before we go?”

“Sure,” she said, pushing the door open. His grin was gone, he was being himself. She was imagining all of this, she told herself. Len was just Len, and he was just bored, and all the things she’d been imagining were just that – imaginings.

She was also pleased to note that she didn’t feel especially disappointed at this revelation. Her eyes wandered to the window, and her ears were pricked for what was happening next door.

She poured a whiskey for Len and another glass of wine for herself. “I don’t have vodka,” she told him, but he didn’t seem to notice or care. It was a good thing, she reasoned, that she was getting out of the house. She should try to make it late, so she was not tempted to go to the party.

Len’s attention was caught by a blast of bass, which boomed and then quieted, a test of sound no doubt.

“You get new neighbors?”

She shrugged, hoping she looked like she truly didn’t know or care. “Some college kids.”

Len raised his eyebrows. This was where he would ordinarily have made a joke about college girls, but he didn’t. He suspended his whiskey glass with two fingers clamped over the rim, as though handling a

dangerous chemical in a beaker, and tipped it into his throat, giving the effect of pouring boiling water from a Lilliputian cauldron onto his enemies.

“Must be loud.”

She shrugged again. “This is the first I’ve heard of them.”

He gave a satisfied exhale and set his whiskey on the counter. “Well,” he declared. “Where to?”

His eyes traveled up and down Kim’s body again.

“Uh... well, you said you had a place, but I... don’t know if I’m dressed for it...” She held her hands out and looked down at her attire, another warm finger of pleasure crawling along her neck as she took in her flat stomach.

Len stared at her. “Yeah, why you wearing that?” he asked. “I thought I said black dress. I was going to go to Murray’s.”

Her neck tingled. What the hell was wrong with her. She was pleased he had noticed her outfit, pleased it was wrong, pleased by... what, exactly?

“It didn’t fit,” she told him. “Looks pretty bad, but it’s, uh...wearable, if you want.”

Len’s eyes now traveled up and down her body, almost as if she had invited him to do so. “Yeah, you’re looking really fit, Kimmy,” he said.

He didn’t linger on the topic. Pushing himself up with a flamboyant slap on the table, he gathered his phone and keys, which he had tossed there upon sitting down. “Well, guess we’ll have to slum it tonight at some other place. Want to head?”

She lifted her wine to her lips and gulped it. “Sounds good.”

She had quite a buzz going by then, and so the next sequence was choppy: she had left her shoes on the porch, she suggested they go out the back. They were walking by the fence, and she could hear the voices of her neighbors – in particular, the one that belonged to Hunter. They were at the edge of the garage. Her feet – upon which she had never put the shoes to keep the sand out – were on the cement, still warm, radiating a day’s worth of sun. Len’s car was gleaming, a new white Audi.

He didn’t open the door for her, and she was pondering whether this was very, very good, or very, very bad, when she heard his voice. Hunter’s voice, and she was listening to it pleasantly for a moment, not recognizing that it was directed at her.

And then it crashed through her dreamy state.

“Jade! Hey!”

He was standing there, taking in the scene: his eyes moved over the Audi, over Len, back to her. Her mouth was open, her eyes rigidly affixed to Hunter, her lips trying desperately to smile while she tried to calculate what Len was thinking. She could see his head turning, his features changing, but not the direction of the turn or the expression he was making.

“Before you go,” Hunter said, and his eyes took another sweep of the scene. Kim could see that he had assessed it as a date, and she could also see that he had appraised Len and was now calculating himself. It gave her a flutter of pleasure, and she couldn’t help it: he was weighing his youth against Len’s Audi, the tough-guy look that Len had against his own just-grown athleticism.

“What’s up, Hunter?” Kim said awkwardly. Len had taken to leaning on his open door, cocking his head slightly, the way you would regard a teenage son who had just been mouthy.

And Kim, regrettably, guiltily, was thrilled by the entire, seconds-long exchange. Because it was about her, as married and as untenable as she was.

Hunter gave another look at Len, to meet his stare, and then back at her. “You mind if we put up disco lights on the porch?”

She tipped her head and shook it at the same time. Whyever would she?

Hunter smiled. It was a cocky, boyish smile, slightly embarrassed, friendly, and also – just a tad – flirtatious. “It’s just that, uh... you know, your window is right there. And the light goes right in.”

At the very end of this sentence, the right side of his mouth turned up. His eyes met hers. He was telling her he had seen her, and she knew it, and because she was drunk it did not wash over her like ice water and then across her cheeks as scarlet heat.

Len was reacting to this by turning back to Kim as if seeing her in a whole new light.

“Well,” Kim said. “Maybe I’ll just have to shut the blinds then.”

Hunter grinned. It was a half-wolfish, half-sheepish smile.

“Or pop by,” he said, his eyes darting to Len and back again.

She found her body moving coquettishly, found herself enjoying that the two of them were watching her do it. “You’re going all night, I’m guessing?” she said to Hunter.

What the hell was she saying? The cougary, whiskied voice she had been using on him the night before was back. He smiled again and pushed

his hands together, making no attempt to hide his pleasure. “Definitely,” he said. And then he nodded at Len, and turned back toward the fence that ran along half of his yard.

Len stared at her over the top of the car as she turned to get in. The expression on his face was priceless.

A breeze picked up her hair, and carried her spirits to a new, strange high along with it. She was not herself, not at all, as she used her whole body to open the car door. “Whu-ut?” she sang, her lips in a coy smile, as Len’s disbelief spread to his entire body and he began to shake his head.

His mouth was open when he dropped to his seat. The car started through some mysterious mechanism that did not involve an ignition, and Len gripped the steering wheel in both hands to turn his head and look over at her. “Did I just hear that little pupper call you ‘Jade’?”

Kim was high. She was enjoying this, she wasn’t sure why. Hunter flirting with her in front of Len had given her a very particular thrill. Len seeming a little jealous had made her even more thrilled.

She pulled her seatbelt over her lap. “I don’t have any idea what you’re talking about, Lenny,” she heard herself saying. She leaned on her elbow and enjoyed the wry smile that Len could not force from his mouth. She put a pinky finger between her teeth and looked straight ahead.

“Robbing the cradle,” Len commented. “Kimmy, Kim, Kim. Or should I say, ‘Jade?’”

She shrugged, and actually could not believe the coolness with which she did it. “He’s still in his cradle, I haven’t done a thing but look.”

This was the sort of thing Len might have said. She wondered where it came from.

Len, she could see in her periphery, was shaking his head slightly. And now he saw her in a new light.

And of course there was something inside of her that said this was all wrong – all of it, totally inappropriate, even if she could deny any of it being what it looked like at all. What would she do if Len told Jessie about this exchange?

Even that idea sort of thrilled her, and she couldn’t say why. Maybe it would finally get his attention.

But she also knew that Len was not going to say anything at all to Jessie.

They were still in the driveway. She turned to him. “Are we going to the bar, or what?”

Len faced the windshield. She could tell that her act had impressed him. She liked the feeling. “Yes, ma’am,” he said.

And the car, soundlessly, rolled out of the driveway.

CHAPTER 7

Jessie stared at the message for so long that his screen had gone to sleep, but it was as if he could still see the words.

*hey... going out with Michelle and Len somewhere down the street
Love you, have a good night*

There was a hollow place in his chest, where pain was filling him like a cold liquid. The sensation spread to his limbs, where it tingled. To his stomach, where it made him feel like he had been kicked in the balls. But most curiously, his cock was rock-hard.

He was parked down the street from the Victoria Inn. It was eight-fifteen: he had considered turning around, going home, making his excuses to Michelle some other day. He didn't have her number, he was sorry, he couldn't put himself in the compromising position of seeing her... he would probably never have to explain himself. He would probably not see Michelle again for a long, long time, and when he did, Len would most likely be there, and all of this would be forgotten. He had stood in front of the secret garden of temptation and stopped himself, because he didn't want to – he really didn't want to – cheat on his wife.

And then, the faint ding of a message from his wife, the only person with a special tone.

And this.

hey...going out with Michelle and Len somewhere down the street

This is what it feels like to be cheated on, he could hear himself thinking. The cool sickness, seeping from somewhere deep inside of him. But the feeling was something so much different than he had ever imagined. That it was sexually invigorating was unexpected.

He knew, as the world swirled around his car as though it were part of another universe, and the cold sickness only crashed through him in waves that were stronger with every passing moment, that the *rational* thing to do – the actions of a rational man – would be to text Kim back, no, call her now, and tell her that he knew full well she wasn't having dinner with

Michelle and Len, because Michelle, in all of her long-legged, modelesque, sexual glory, was here in Boston. Waiting, supposedly, for him. In the lobby of a hotel.

But instead – even while his mind pictured him doing just precisely that rational thing, picturing it so clearly that he could almost feel his fingers typing the message into the phone, his heart pounding as Kim’s phone rang and rang and went to voicemail – he did none of those things. He pocketed his phone, and the raging jealousy inside of him settled like sediment in a lake. He opened the car door and stepped onto the street, walked the two blocks to the posh Victoria Inn, and, tingling from head to toe and with his suit jacket folded over his arm to hide his erection, which was wild, he entered the lobby.

The bar at the Victoria Inn, like almost any bar at any hotel, was off the lobby and the disjointed cackle of its patrons ricocheted into the marble and glass and guided him, like a woman’s finger, toward where the usual business of hotels was taking place. Men and women, most of whom were so obviously the other halves of partnerships just like his and Kim’s, Len and Michelle’s, were adrift in the dark wood and green lights. A few of them had begun to gravitate toward each other, and Michelle was perched on a high barstool in a stunning blue sheath that left nothing to anyone’s imagination. Her legs were crossed, one blue-shoed foot making slow, seductive circles, and her long blond hair was draped over a shoulder. Everyone’s eyes were darting from wherever they were supposed to be planted to her, and it gave the impression of circling vultures. She was dipping a plastic sword of olives into a martini, and talking to the bartender.

Jessie was walking as if he were in a dream, Kim’s lie burning the front of his head as surely as if she had branded him with it. He stood next to Michelle, and she didn’t move, or turn to him. She bit into an olive with her perfect white teeth, and sucked it into her mouth as her lips turned up in a smile. She crushed it elegantly with a molar while she said, in a low voice, as though to herself: “I was beginning to think you’d stood me up.”

Jessie turned to face her as he plopped himself onto a stool. “I almost did.”

He found himself almost theatrical at this point, but possessed no way of stopping himself. The Jessie who was moving through physical time and space was just a vessel: his mind was in the ether somewhere, fixated on the

fact that his wife was doing something, somewhere in Florida, most likely with Len and Len alone. She had lied, and the ripe, vivid proof of her lie was encased in a blue dress and pursing her lips on an olive like a kiss.

Michelle turned to him, her teeth neatly biting into the flesh of the next olive and pulling it toward her mouth. She chewed it, her eyes drifting up and down Jessie, and smiled. “Why’s that, Jessie?” she asked. Her expression was all innocence but a feral mischief he had never seen before flashed behind her icy blue eyes.

The moment, Jessie thought, was utterly surreal. Sure, Michelle had always been attractive, but Michelle had never acted like this.

Maybe, though, he thought, it was because he had never been around Michelle alone.

While my wife lies to me about going out with Len alone.

The bartender, in no way hiding his annoyance that the gorgeous blond at his bar now had an appendage, came to a stiff stop in front of Jessie. “What can I get you?” he asked.

“Get him one of these martinis,” Michelle purred. Then she turned back to Jessie with the glass at her lips. “They’re so good.”

Jessie’s brain was on fire. He felt very much conspired against, and he didn’t like it one bit. He especially felt uneasy about the way that Michelle was using her sexual appeal to manipulate him.

But he didn’t resist the drink order, so the bartender drifted away.

Michelle stirred her last olive in the dwindling vodka in her glass. “I’m on my third, so you’ll have to catch up,” she said cheerfully.

Jessie still said nothing. She set her drink down. Her hand drifted to his knee, where it burned through his suit and added to the cacophony of feelings in his body. “What’s up with you? You look like you have the flu.”

It was true. His face was ashen. He had seen it in the mirror.

He took his phone out of his pocket and set it on the bar. Michelle looked at it, and when he did nothing with it, she swiveled her chair, and her legs, back toward the bar. “Johnny,” she called to the bartender. “I’m sorry, I need another one, too.”

Johnny nodded, giving the martini shaker a stranglehold and a ferocious jerk.

Michelle leaned on her elbows and placed the last olive on her tongue before using it to tug the olive off the sword. It was a blatant, filthy, sexual gesture, and Jessie felt his cock throb. Guilt washed through his veins, the

text from his wife surged into them like poison, and his cock reacted by simply aching more.

“So...?” Michelle said. “Seriously, Jessie, what’s wrong with you?”

She waited. She turned, as the new pair of martinis landed on the table, and put her hand on his knee again.

“What are you *doing*?” Jessie asked her. He was seething, and Michelle recoiled, her eyebrows raised. She was startled only for a moment. Her composure quickly resettled on her face.

“Jeez, Jessie,” she said. “We’re just having a drink here.” She began to play with one of her new olives. “What’s got *your* goat?”

Jessie brought up his messages, and set the phone on the table. “My wife just sent me this message.”

Michelle bit into an olive and she gave a feline, sexy stretch to read the screen.

“Oh,” she said.

The word left her mouth the way a child, interested in something else, might let go of a balloon. She pointed at the screen and chewed up her olive, smiling, as she looked up at Jessie. “Well, *I’m* obviously not there,” she said. “Is Len?”

“What do you know about this?” Jessie asked. He was shaking slightly, and hoped she couldn’t hear the emotion in his voice.

Michelle looked abashed. Theatrically so. “Nothing,” she said. She started to laugh, but seemed to think better of it suddenly. “Oh, I see. *You* think this is all... related.” She made a swirling motion between her and Jessie. “Yeah, so no... I mean, I’m pretty obviously hitting on you, but I made my plans all by myself.”

Jessie shook his head vigorously. “*What*?”

Michelle sipped her martini. “*I’m* hitting on you,” she repeated. “But it doesn’t have anything to do with whatever your wife is doing. You don’t think she’s cheating on you, do you?”

“With *Len*?” Jessie retorted, not really sure what he meant by the comment.

Michelle shrugged. “Jeez. It’s not outside the realm of possibilities. But actually, I was thinking she might be going out with someone else -”

“I asked Len to take her out,” Jessie interrupted. “I just, I assumed, I thought...”

Michelle's mouth curved into another mischievous smile. "Ah, I see. So you thought *we* were going out. And she let you think that was the case. But she had no way of knowing I was here. And so now you're left wondering...why would Kim go out with Len and say she was out with both of us?"

Michelle seemed thrilled. Jessie pulled on his collar. He was overheating.

"Hmm," Michelle said. "Look, I didn't conspire with Len, if that's what you're thinking. I mean, he knows *I'm* here."

"*What?*"

Michelle leaned her head on one hand and looked at him angelically. She was quite beautiful, but the principal feeling Jessie was having toward her was fear. "Don't tell me this is the first you've heard of it?"

"Heard of what?"

"Oh, my," Michelle said. She started to stir her olive in her martini, languidly and thoughtfully, a smile on her lips. Jessie was reaching an extreme of aggravation and lust, and the combination was making him queasy. He gulped half of his martini, which only made things worse.

"Len and I have an open relationship," Michelle said loudly. The bartender heard her from the end of the bar and made no effort to hide his interest, turning around sharply and looking right at them. Michelle winked in his direction, but turned her attention back to Jessie, leaning an elbow on the bar. "So he knows what *I'm* doing."

"What is *he* doing?"

Michelle tipped her head to one side. "I think you're not so worried about Len right now."

"Is he trying to have sex with my wife?" Jessie demanded.

Michelle lifted a plastic sword to her teeth and bit an olive off from the side of her mouth. "Seriously, Jessie," she purred, and twisted back to the center, eyes leading her as they rolled in the direction of the bartender. "Well, if you're not game," she said, "I think I'll see what I can work out with Johnny here."

Jessie shook his head again, unable to believe what he was seeing. "*What* are you doing?"

Michelle turned to him and said, with an air of comedy: "Jessie, sweetheart, *I* am having sex with a man other than my husband. *You* are making it hard."

She was drunk. This seemed to give her a thought, and her hand was between his legs before he could stop her. She felt around the contours of his cock, and by then it was too late to move her hand. She withdrew it slowly and put it up to her forehead. "So..." she murmured. "You seem a *little bit* interested."

Jessie shook his head again. "How did I not know you two were... like this?" he said. He swatted at Michelle's hand as she tried to move in again.

"You mean swingers?"

Jessie's eyes went wide. "Yes! Yes, how did I not know this about you? What the hell?"

She leaned very close to him and put her fingers on his shirt. "We have rules about friends who live in the same place as us," she said. "But you're back here, and we're down there..." Her fingers moved lower, the meat of her palm brushing over his cock again. She chewed on her lower lip. "Are you sure you don't want to take me up on the offer?" She lifted a leg, very slowly, with the control of a dancer. He tried to keep his eyes anywhere but between her legs, but she did it so slowly that the feat proved impossible, and he dropped his eyes to the space between her legs and saw that she was wearing no underwear.

The sweet, tangy scent of her pussy drifted beneath his nose.

Her hand was on his, taking it with her as she moved it closer to her knees. Jessie, transfixed, and lost completely by the strangeness of the situation and the thoughts of his wife lying to him, did not think to pull his hand away, even when she rested it on her thigh. Her leg was firm, her skin warm and smooth. His hand slid over it easily as she moved it closer to her pussy. Her body seemed hotter by degrees, each inch that his hand moved, and he could tell that the air between her legs was moist.

She leaned to put her mouth against his ear just as she pushed his fingers into her utterly bare labia, and the juices of her cunt kissed his fingertips and sent a shudder through his body. "I'm so wet," she whispered.

He jerked his hand away, stunned. Blood was pounding in his ears.

"Listen, Michelle, I am really... flattered, I am, but this is..."

Michelle stuck out her lower lip, and then shrugged.

"You and Len don't really... do this, do you?"

Michelle looked at him like he was a child she was babysitting, and he had a scraped knee. Then she snatched her phone and leaned in toward him

to take a selfie. Smiling, and looking right at Jessie, she shifted on her stool as she spread her legs, the phone between them. Jessie was immobilized by the entire scene, and only moved - to blink – when the flash erupted between them.

Michelle put the phone on the bar between them so he could see her type:

Surprise. He did show up after all.

to Len, and see her send the pictures – one a flash-bleached snapshot of her dripping cunt – to her husband.

“Wait, wait wait,” Jessie said, trying to grab the phone with two hands. Michelle laughed. “He’s not going to be upset,” she said.

“Yeah, but what if he shows it to Kim?” Jessie said, before he could think of the absurdity of his question.

Michelle laughed. “I guess that depends on what kind of game Kim is playing with you, J,” she said. She put the phone face-down after smiling at Len’s response, and looked at him pointedly.

“So this is for real,” Jessie said.

Michelle rolled her eyes.

“And so what... okay, look, so, Michelle, I am like, really flattered and you are... hot... but I can’t do that to Kim. We don’t have, uh...”

“No?” Michelle smiled. “What if you don’t, but Kim *does*?”

Jessie’s stomach went cold and his heart burned like a coal in his chest.

Michelle tipped her head back and opened her mouth in a wide smile. “Ooooooh,” she said, as if she had just realized something. “I see,” she said.

“See what?” Jessie asked.

Michelle looked at him archly, gave a glance at the bartender, and then leaned on an elbow toward him, dropping her chest so that her breasts hung in front of him. He tried to keep his eyes on hers, but it was hard. “Okay, I will tell you, but let’s make it quick, because if you really aren’t going to do me, then I want to get to work on this Johnny kid.”

Jessie looked at the bartender. “He’s like twel-” he hissed.

Michelle cut him off with a finger. “You have three minutes.”

Jessie was not sure when he had agreed to anything, or what he had agreed to, so he just looked at her with his mouth hanging open for a few minutes before snapping it shut.

Michelle smiled and put a long, slender finger playfully on his collar, dragging a well-manicured finger down the front of his chest to his waist. "You're a cuckold."

Jessie's temper flared. "Excuse me, I am no-"

"No. no," Michelle said calmly. "You *would like* to be a cuckold. Don't worry, it's a common fantasy."

Jessie said something about having a hard time understanding how that could be.

Michelle dropped her hand to his cock and massaged it, taking extra care to rub a small wet stain with the pad of her thumb. "Right," she said.

She brought her thumb to her mouth, closed her lips around it, and sucked it dry. "Sure you don't want to try something new?"

Jessie swallowed and shook his head.

"Even if your wife is being a slut and sucking my husband's cock right now? He likes it in the car." Michelle crossed her legs slowly and sucked on her forefinger.

Jessie felt like he had turned to stone. He stared at Michelle.

Michelle shrugged and lifted her phone, using her free hand to wave at the bartender. "Johnny, come here," she slurred. "I want to send a picture of you to my husband." She looked up at his confused face. "Before I fuck you," she added. "Don't worry. He likes it." She threw her free hand around Jessie. "This schmuck won't do me."

She indicated that Jessie was the schmuck while she took a photo of Johnny.

The bartender looked at Jessie as if he had two heads.

The phone flashed again as Michelle was putting it into her purse. "Oops," Michelle said. She set it flat on the table to send her message to Len. She showed it to Jessie with a flick of her wrist while she smiled at Johnny.

She typed primly, and then slid the message thread over to Jessie, who took it all in but mostly remained transfixed by the snapshot taken between Michelle's legs, where it was evident that she had no panties on.

I won't play ball so I'm doing this guy instead. Okay?

Jessie stared at the screen for a minute and then looked at Michelle. "You don't actually just... send him a message and then, you know...?"

Right?”

Michelle held the phone and let the message from Len materialize on her screen, smiling a little when it did.

Hot. Sounds good

Michelle cast an eye on Jessie. Her expression changed to one of pity. It was the kind of look an evil eighth-grade girl would give you in middle school: malice, suddenly overpowered by a motherly instinct. It was humiliating, infuriating. And it made his cock hard. She was typing.

She rotated the phone to show him:

Jessie wants to know if you're fucking his wife

not at the moment

Are you even trying?

*I'm always trying
Does Jessie care?*

Michelle's eyes floated back up to Jessie, and she arched them. Jessie said nothing.

She typed and showed him the message.

He's still undecided

“You *are*,” Michelle told him, before he could say anything.

She sipped her martini.

Jessie slammed the rest of his martini. “God, what the hell is going on?” he asked no one in particular.

Michelle turned to him. “Look, Jessie. I am pretty toasted, okay?”

Jessie felt drunk himself. Whatever was going on in this bar made very little sense to him, and he was pretty sure it was in his interests to get out of there before something bad happened. Spikes of guilt flared up inside of him – Michelle's touching his cock, seeing her bare cunt in a photograph,

the way she had licked his precum off her finger... it was all too much, but it wasn't the sort of thing that he really had to feel that bad about.

Yet.

He stood up, unsteadily. "I have to go," he croaked.

The bartender was wiping the counter a couple of feet away, and smiled. Michelle put her head in her hand and sighed. Her blue shoes gave another languid turn, and Jessie tried and failed not to look at her calf muscle rolling beneath her skin.

"Don't you want to see how this turns out?" she purred, holding her phone. "With your wife and Len, I mean."

Jessie shook his head, feeling a little sick. "I gotta go," he said. He walked briskly out of the lobby without looking back.

If he had stayed just a little bit longer, he would have heard Michelle laugh, and flip the phone for Johnny to see. "Oh look at this," she would say. "Kim's gone and left her wedding ring somewhere."

CHAPTER 8

Len didn't mention what had happened at the house, or "Jade," or much of anything again until they were settled and had ordered some drinks. The bar was just up the road, a noisy place that was squirming like a barrel of fish, flashes of metallic glimmering among the patrons like bait and then disappearing. It was tastefully and forgettably and predictably decorated, and the clientele were tastefully and forgettably and predictably drunk.

It was almost too loud to talk, so for a few queer moments they yelled at the waiter and then exchanged glances over the table.

She leaned on her arm and yelled at Len. "It's loud."

He screamed back: "Get drunk, you won't think so anymore."

So they did. He held up an authoritative finger and made a waiter stop to take his order, and perhaps because of Len's grisly, old-man aura, the waiter returned promptly with four shots of reddish liquid.

"What is this?" Kim screamed at him.

"Just drink it," he assured her.

They clinked glasses. The shots were terrible but she slammed them both, pushing thoughts of her eventual hangover to the side. The noise in the bar seemed to fold them into it: it was suddenly not so much loud as alive, and Kim laughed. Len touched his nose and pointed at her, then touched his nose again. They each looked out at the squirming, glittery crowd. Everyone seemed wildly attractive and young, even Len, and, she thought, even her.

The waiter came back with more drinks.

Kim was about to make a fuss of not drinking any more, but she took her drink and slid it closer to herself as she leaned over to talk to Len. She found herself aware of habits she had always had: folding her arm up and curling her fingers next to her ear, opening her mouth a bit more than needed to pronounce her words in a low, throaty voice that made Len have to lean closer to her.

Habits from long ago, when she used to flirt. Coming back to her like riding a bicycle, giving her the same thrilling sensation.

"So spill it," she said, and she was only somewhat shocked by how sexual her voice sounded, how slightly-too-close-of-old-friends-who-were-

married she was feigning to be, how *close* she was pretending to be with Len. “Where *is* Michelle, and why are you out without her?”

Len processed the question, and leaned back with his shot glass in his hand, suspended by the two fingers he had used to drink his whiskey back at the house. He tipped back his chair a little while shaking his head. It was a youthful motion, and he did it with youthful ease that was unexpectedly at ease with his older appearance.

He gave her a strange look – one that was, like her voice and her oddly conspiratorial nature with him right now, out of the ordinary. His mouth twitched in a smile. “Kim’s out-of-town, *Jade*, and that’s all you need to know about it.”

Their eyes met. For a few seconds the look they exchanged could have morphed into anything, anything at all. Later she would think about it, and it just as easily could have resulted in them stripping naked and fucking on the table, right then and there, as the way it actually did end up. She would never know what tipped it in the other direction, because she herself was feeling glorious, flirtatious, pretty, and much freer than she actually was.

She held up her shot glass and glanced it against his, leaning forward to do it. “To out-of-town spouses,” she said.

Len smiled again, and she felt another guilty thrill as he looked her up and down. She was piquing his interest, and even though Len was not the kind of attention she wanted, it felt great to have a man paying attention to her.

Two men, actually.

Possibly, she thought, in a drunken mirth, even three.

“What’s the deal with that?” Len yelled, after swigging his shot. He issued a glance to the side, as if to tell her that he wasn’t overly interested in the topic.

“Jessie being out of town?” she asked, as if there were any other topic “that” could refer to. She played with the liquid in her shot glass, looking at it intently. “It’s a long story,” she yelled without looking up.

They were still yelling because the bar was so loud, but it seemed like the most natural thing in the world, like their conversation was even more secret than if they had been whispering.

Then suddenly she felt like confessing to him. She looked up and drew her hands, palms up and open, to her sides in a gesture of extreme agitation, the kind of gesture mothers reserve for small children who have drawn in

purple on a white leather couch. “He’s just so... obsessed with work. And selfish. Moving down here was selfish, and then he just expects me to go back, and then I’m all the way down here. And I feel like *every* conversation is so dull... like we have nothing to say. And then I wonder...”

She stopped herself, unable to believe all the things coming out of her mouth. Feeling indiscreet, she shut herself up by slamming her shot.

She wiped her mouth.

“I think he’s having an affair,” she said flatly.

The admission escaped her, and realizing what she had said aloud gave her the sort of body-slamming chill you get when someone startles you by jumping out from a closet. Her fingers traveled to her mouth, as if she could take it back, and then she met Len’s eyes, waiting for the reaction: the usual; the denying.

Instead Len was rolling the shot glass between his thumb and forefinger, slowly. His eyes were there to meet hers. This final revelation had sparked something in him, as if he had been given an idea or a piece of a puzzle, and his mouth turned up in a knowing smile.

“If he is,” he yelled. “Then what about that bothers you?”

If Len had thrown a bucket of ice water on her she would have been less surprised. She had already been forming her reply to what she had expected him to say (“then he’s a fool”). Her mouth closed around the words, and she started half a dozen sentences with no end to them even imaginable. “Well...I mean...what...I guess...what kind of question is that?”

“Michelle has affairs,” Len said matter-of-factly, and it felt like a slap. “And...”

He leaned forward, twisting the shot glass in his fingers.

She was silent. Not just inaudible beneath the noise, but actually silent. The conversation had taken so many sharp turns she had whiplash.

“We have an agreement, me and Michelle,” Len said, leaning closely toward her just as the waiter dropped off a few more drinks.

Kim looked at him strangely, more about the shots than what he had said, because she couldn’t process it at that moment. Len waved his hand in the waiter’s general direction. “I tipped him a hundred and told him to keep them coming.”

Her mouth fell open. “What...? You mean *you* know she’s having an affair?” she asked.

“We have an agreement” Len repeated. Doggedly. She could see he had only been wanting her to ask him this question the entire time, and then she felt angry because he didn’t care about her feelings, or her husband’s affair, at all. She was drunk, teetering emotionally.

She shook her head, drank the shot, and shook her head vigorously again. “An agreement?” she said, and her voice was hoarse because the shot seemed stronger than before. “What the hell is that supposed to mean?”

Len pondered this for a moment, looking like an investigator across the table from her.

He slumped, and then recovered, puffing out his chest. “You haven’t answered my question,” he told her.

She frowned, unable to remember the question.

“Why does it bother you?” Len yelled.

She stared at him. “What do you mean, why does it bother me?” she yelled back.

In the back of her mind, she was still dealing with what Len was saying. She squeezed her eyes shut and shook her head. “What do you mean, she has affairs and you have an agreement?”

Len smiled and leaned back in his chair. He was amused, and Kim hated him for it, but her curiosity was getting the better of her.

“So Michelle and I have, I don’t know, sort of an implicit arrangement,” Len said.

Kim was drunk enough that she had to think really hard about whether or not Len had said, and meant, “implicit”, or “explicit.”

“Like, to have affairs?” Kim asked, feeling like a five-year-old learning about the birds and the bees for the first time.

Len nodded. “I fucked up a few times, she fucked up a few times, and then we decided, fuck it... why not just come to an agreement about it.” He grinned again. “I like watching her.”

Kim said nothing, her eyes opening wider and wider.

“I like watching her fuck other guys. God, Kim, were you born yesterday?”

Kim was stunned, and then she suddenly found the whole thing ridiculous. “Holy shit,” she said. “So you’re like, swingers?”

Len shook his head like she was an idiot. “Okay,” he said elusively.

And then, abruptly, he changed the subject. Sort of. “So. Mrs. Robinson. What about you? You boinking the neighbor kid?”

It took her a second to get the reference, because she had never even seen *The Graduate* and wasn't entirely sure she knew what the movie was about. She rubbed her nose, an affect she didn't realize she possessed, which manifested itself when she wanted to seem composed but wasn't.

Another sharp turn in the conversation had left her disoriented.

"I don't even think that kid's legal," she managed to say, catching sight of the topic through the blizzard of thoughts.

"So you *would*?" Len pressed.

Len had a very strange gleam in his eye now. Kim didn't know what to do with it: he almost seemed to be egging her on, suggesting that she fuck this guy... and he almost seemed to be hungry to watch her do it.

"What the hell, Len?" she said, to diffuse the situation. "I'm not going to fuck some eighteen-year-old kid."

She looked away, expecting a rush of humiliation to creep onto her cheeks, but instead she just had a lot of strings plucking inside of her, low in her abdomen.

"It'd be hot," Len said. New drinks appeared at their table and they both looked at them with wary smiles before touching them.

"What the hell is that supposed to mean?" she said, shaking her head. And now it was she who was veering off course. "Why do guys say everything is hot?" she asked.

She was drunk now. She should go home. She was talking like a maniac, there was an element of flirtatiousness and caprice in her voice and her gestures and she had no idea who it was for: Len? Herself? Jessie, who wasn't even here to see it? Or Hunter?

"Everything *is* hot when a hot chick does it," Len said.

Another string plucked and delivered a reverberation of guilty pleasures inside of her.

She was the "hot chick," and something about Len saying it was stirring her up.

"God," she muttered, unable to come up with anything else.

Len chuckled. "I'd be into it," he said.

"Shut up," she joked back. But really, she didn't want him to shut up, and her smile and batting roll of the eyes was saying so, and worse than that, she was very conscious of all of this. "That's so...."

"Hot," Len said. "Fucking hot."

There was a pause, while Kim's brain reeled, and then Len declared solemnly:

"I really like watching Michelle with other guys."

She was totally silenced by this, and at first she was sure it was a joke, but the tone was so confessional she was almost as quickly sure that it wasn't. He pointed his empty shot glass at her. "I'd like watching you, too," he slurred.

She gave him a look, tried to compose herself, and then gave her head a good shake. She was confused. "What?"

He leaned over. "I'd like... to watch you fuck... that hot guy. Or whoever," he annunciated clearly. He leaned back. "Of course, I'd also like to fuck you myself, but something tells me it isn't the best idea."

It was an artillery attack that had landed exactly where he had wanted, and she was totally incapacitated. She could feel her face falling to pieces, registering all the things she wanted to keep secret and none of the things she wanted to pretend, and her insides were now tightly coiled and ready to be strummed again.

She shook her head again and put her hands out, as if she could erase the whole conversation with the sweep of them. She closed her eyes, and she felt even dizzier. "What?"

This was obviously a dream, she thought, in the quiet of her own head, which, now that her eyes were closed, seemed miles away from the loud bar where their drunk friend Len, who she had gone out with alone, thousands of miles from her husband, was telling her he'd like to watch her fuck a young guy or even fuck her himself.

She opened her eyes.

Len was looking at her with a mischievous grin.

Two shots had appeared on the table.

She gave him a last, tremulous smile; a final volley at him to crack up, sweep it the whole thing under the table. Point a finger at her and say "Gotcha!" or "God, Kim, you really are full of yourself." Maybe he would hold his head and say he was too fucked up, and forget any of this had ever happened. One last attempt to get Len to pretend, at the very least, that he wasn't really saying that he wanted to fuck her.

It made everything so complicated. And Kim might have been out-of-her-mind-wasted right then (the table was spinning and the pattern of the weird parquet was boiling on the floor) but she wasn't ever going to be so

drunk that she couldn't think ahead to all the complications that would arise from this sort of stuff.

But Len was not going to let her off the hook, and she could see it in his face. He leaned closer.

"Oh come on, Kimmy. *Jade*. Don't tell me you've never thought of it."

She looked quickly away, out a window that was turning black except where a thin orange line separated sea and cloudy sky. She *had* thought of it, and now she felt too drunk to deny it, or lie about it, or find a pithy response to Len, or even to act appropriately and tell him it was high time they go home and forget any of this ever happened. What to do, then? she wondered, staring at the remnants of the sunset.

The music throbbed around her.

When she turned back to Len he was laughing. Or it seemed like he was laughing, but maybe he was just chuckling. He nudged the shot toward her. "Jesus, Kim, lighten up."

Was it a joke now? She felt a little relieved. She took the shot and brought it to her lips, certain she would end up puking in the ladies' bathroom. There was something that had happened in this conversation not so long ago that she wanted to go back to... and she couldn't find it. Sweat was breaking out on the back of her neck with the effort.

"You okay?" Len asked. He put his hand on hers. It was warm, slightly calloused as she had expected, because Len did all kinds of manly things with ropes -

Jesus, she warned herself.

"I'm just thinking..." she mumbled slightly. "This is some crazy stuff you're telling me," she added.

Len looked pleased.

She held up a finger. "Ah," she said, and her voice was syrupy and amusing to herself; her mood shifted wildly again and she was happy. "What was it you asked me... what did I think...?" She blinked. "You never answered my question," she interrupted herself. "Is he?"

Len looked perplexed.

"Having an affair? Jessie. Is he?" She spread her hands out and swept them over the table. "We don't have an 'agreement,'" she explained.

Len had a shot glass in his fingers again and she dropped her eyes to look at it. The same crane-like grip, like a claw, clamped on the rim, pointer finger, middle finger, and thumb. He twisted it counter-clockwise and then

back, several times, and when she looked back at his face he seemed to be thinking very deeply about something.

He leaned back again. "I really don't know, Kim."

She leaned back as well, a huff of resignation being punched out of her chest. It wasn't exactly the full-throttled denial she had been hoping for. It sounded, she analyzed, like Len believed he *could*. And she realized that she had been hoping – praying - that Len would say it wasn't possible. Not Jessie. Not on *her*.

"It doesn't seem like Jessie," Len said, and looked skyward, thinking about that same thought he had been taken with earlier. "But then, anything can happen."

If this was supposed to be a consolation, it was the worst one she'd ever heard. If your own good friend can't even say, "no, Jessie's definitely not having an affair," then it was basically as good as saying he was.

Or so it went in her own drunken logic.

For a moment she was sure she was going to cry.

She set the shot glass down. "I'm so drunk," she said. "I have to... I think we better go home."

"Let's walk it off. On the beach," Len said. He was grinning at her.

He was still in a good mood, she could see. Michelle's infidelity was something he'd digested, something he'd put up on a mantle somewhere and looked at over and over again.

Her pain was so fresh it didn't even seem real.

"I'm..." she croaked, shaking her head. "That's not a good idea, Len."

"It's a *great* idea," he persisted, and now he was starting to joke around again. Like old Len, the Len she had always known and detested-loved. He reached for her hand again but this was more in jest than seriously. "You, me, moonlight, goose-poop... two lonely spouses..." he crowed.

She was smiling back at him, pulling her hand away, doubts racing through her mind, alcohol sweeping behind her thoughts and turning them all to a shambles. "Len, Lenny, we are fucking *drunk*."

"We should keep going!" he shouted, raising his fist to the air.

"We should go home!" she volleyed jovially, doing the same. Her life was swirling around in her head but she'd managed to right herself enough to know: she was better off sobering up. Alone.

Their eyes met. It was a funny, familiarly hostile, unfamiliarly tender, drawn-out exchange, her blue eyes and his brown ones locked together.

“Stay,” he said, lips smiling.

In the center of her body, the chord that had been vibrating rang again. But now it felt like a warning.

“Home,” she said, breaking their gaze, and standing up, packing things she had somehow removed from her purse into it again and gathering her wits and good judgment from the thin air as she did so. Whatever spell the booze and Len had put her under, she was breaking out of it now. Her phone was in her hand. “I’m getting an Uber,” she told him, and she had her bossy, uptight Kim voice on. “I’m going to the bathroom,” she said, her fingers sweeping over the screen.

The hallway tipped like a ship in a storm as she made her way to the bathroom. The screen on her phone confused her. She was pretty sure she was going to throw up.

But she was okay, she concluded. She had stopped this whole thing in its tracks, and tomorrow it would all make more sense and she would never go out with Len alone again.

In the stall she plunged into another sad moment, and then she gathered herself and went to the mirror and had a good talking with her own face whenever there was no one else in the bathroom. She spilled the contents of her purse looking for some lipstick, and repacked things, laughing. A girl came in and they had a drunken chat about how men were pigs. Then she was somber again and tidied up a smear of mascara below her eye that must have come from almost, or possibly actually, crying in the toilet.

“Jesus, Kim,” she told her reflection.

But her reflection pleased her. Maybe she was in her late thirties, now, officially. But she had the kind of features that didn’t sag, the sort of cheekbones that didn’t let her face droop. And her body looked almost as good as it had ten years ago.

She turned to the side, pleased with the flatness of her stomach.

Out of the bathroom, the hallway less tippy but the screen still wild and untamable beneath her fingers. Much more time had passed than she had imagined. In the bar, Len was gone, and she swept over it with her gaze several times to be sure. On her phone, the Uber driver had called.

She stumbled out the door and hailed him just as he was pulling away. “I’m sorry,” she said. “So sorry... I just...”

He was annoyed, she climbed in. She gave a glance around the bar and the patio as she did. Len was nowhere in sight. For a moment she thought she should wait for him, like they were two foreigners and she couldn’t leave him behind, but the sentimental feeling evaporated suddenly when she remembered that he had tried to talk her – seriously or not – into fucking him that night.

Len was a big boy, she thought. He could call his own Uber from his very own phone.

She told the driver to go, slurred that she’d tip him extra, and tried to type a message to Len. *Couldn’t find you, sorry, took Uber home* was her intended message.

Vikdnr find you yom he home

She sent it anyway. “God,” she muttered, setting the phone on the seat. “Good enough.”

The drive home was short, and she found that she wished it was longer. She rolled the window down and watched the snippets of ocean through the houses – the small, run-down vacation rentals and then the big, new properties like hers. The air was warm and she was swinging back to good feelings again, almost forgetting everything that had bothered her at the bar, remnants of everything that had been said flitting out of her head with the passing breeze.

The driver had pulled into a driveway, and she was so embarrassed that she had spaced out for so long that she hastily paid him and got out of the car.

She was disoriented for a second, and swirled around to catch her driver before he pulled away: the house she was in front of was not her own. Music, like that in the bar she’d just left, poured haphazardly from windows and doors, all of which were open and emanating a different color of light: here flashing, here bright, here yellow, here blue.

But the Uber driver was gone. She checked frantically for her phone, found it in her hand, and swept the screen drunkenly for something – an app, anything, that would tell her where she was.

She spun around while she did this, and the sight of her own house, from the right and in the corner of her eye, dropped her as though from the sky right back into reality, almost at the same instant that Hunter's voice called from somewhere, nowhere, everywhere at once:

"Jade!"

It was the neighbor's house, and next to it, her own house. The neighbor place was teeming with younger, college-aged kids, and they were unexpectedly less loud and rowdy than she had pictured them being. She caught sight of someone her own age, having a beer in a red cup in the open gate of the fencing, a pretty girl teetering on long, youthful legs nodding at him through an impossible mane of shiny brown hair. Kim looked for the source of Hunter's voice, the name she had given him grating away at guilt in her mind and leaving a pile of it in her conscience.

"You made it."

He was breathless, shirtless, a streak of sand swept over his ribs and left pec, and she thought of a plate of food at upscale restaurants where they smeared things like saffron over the plate to serve it.

The whole evening collapsed in upon itself, folding up into one condensed emotion: Len, Michelle, Jessie, Hunter, her marriage, marriage in general, the hot Florida air, the orange strip of sunlight between the sky and the sea. The phone felt heavy in her hand. "My Uber driver..." she slurred, and when she heard her voice it was a lot like the voice from the restaurant: not really hers, but not exactly someone else's. The party glowed behind Hunter and his locks of beautiful hair, the muscles on his body seemed coiled beneath his skin and it seemed to her like the embodiment of all the things she had been missing for so long.

Hunter was waiting for the end of her sentence. She was going to say that the driver had mistaken the address, assumed she was going to the party, and laugh it off and clamber over an unkempt hedge between the houses to go home.

"You want a beer?" he asked her.

She dropped her phone in her purse. "Uh..."

The answer, of course, should have been no. And she should have just gone home.

But he never waited to hear what she had to say next, or if he did, and she said more, she had forgotten it. They were walking into the back yard by the time any of these thoughts made their way into her head, and the

music was too loud by then, the lights too much fun, and before she knew it she had a red cup of beer in her hand and Hunter's friend was telling her a joke that she found very funny, but would never remember, while her eyes wandered back from time to time to Hunter's face. Where she found him, with an expression that was ludicrous and almost dewy, looking right back at her with a smile.

From there until the moment Len arrived, her memory was pretty blurry. She may have had as many as two beers, even three: one cup was knocked out of her hand by some rambunctious dancers. Hunter abandoned her with his friend from the beach while he went to refill her cup, and the kid talked to her about surfing in what was either gloriously banal detail or unexpectedly philosophical terms: she was too drunk to notice. In the back of her mind she couldn't help but think how inappropriate it all was, couldn't help but dwell on snippets of her conversation with Len (which was, by then, falling apart in her mind like a cookie in a cup of coffee).

She stayed, more than anything, because it felt like revenge. Revenge for what, she had a harder time discerning: revenge on Jessie for possibly having an affair that Len couldn't deny one way or the other?

Once or twice she looked over at her own house, where she'd left the bedroom light on, and was shocked to see that her mirror was visible from the patio.

Which meant, undeniably, that she had been, too.

The thought gave her more of a thrill than seemed appropriate, but she blamed it on the booze.

Hunter returned. She stared more at his chest than she meant to, but no one had their eyes where they should be.

The friend asked her what she did for a living.

"Too boring," she said coyly. "What do you do?"

The guys exchanged a look. "Must be pretty good coin," the friend said. He pointed at her house.

Her thumb had gone to her ring finger. She had a habit of playing with her wedding ring, tied to nothing in particular, though at this moment it could have been subconscious.

The pad of her finger slid over her skin, bare, and on to her next finger. She smiled, as the floodgate of panic opened up inside of her.

This had happened before, she was telling herself calmly, smiling and twisting her hips, unable to think of anything to say or even to remember what they were talking about. She brought her cup to her lips and made a murmuring sound.

If she had not been obsessively seeking her wedding ring with her finger, she might have noticed the two boys exchange another look, or heard the friend say to Hunter “definitely up to *something* baller.” She didn’t notice that her mysterious withdrawal was more intriguing to them than anything, added to the fact that they had both looked at her ring finger – only very recently, because young guys are not quick to go looking for wedding rings and only think of it after they’ve already been laying some line – and seen she was not wearing one.

Or maybe they had seen the even whiter band framed by her only slightly tanned skin: a removed wedding ring said a great deal more than the ring itself.

None of this mattered to her, because she was trying, for reasons she could not explain, to maintain her composure as her thumb groped the webs of her ring finger down to her knuckle, finding nothing but skin.

She chilled inside, straight through her torso; her mind raced and her muscles writhed inside her stiff posture. She was pretty sure her heart would beat right through her throat and into her mouth if she said anything.

Gone.

Something about the ring itself missing gave her a jolt, an open window into a future where all of the things she had been toying with this evening – all the fantasies of flirtation, affairs, having a one-off on one of the mattresses on the floor of the neighbor’s house with a virile twenty-year-old, leading her black gym friend to the locker room by his cock – crashed into the inevitability of divorce and loneliness.

“You okay?” Hunter asked her.

She looked around haplessly at the sand at her feet. “I think I dropped something,” she said, her eyes unable to focus on anything in the flickering light of the Tiki torches and the disco ball. “Shit.”

Hunter’s friend did not seem to care, and why would he? Hunter shrugged. “What was it?”

“Some jewelry,” she said. She didn’t know why she didn’t tell him what kind, and yet she did know why. Maybe losing her ring had jolted her awake, but it hadn’t been enough to make her abandon -

What? This silly fantasy?

Her eyes were getting watery, and she was looking around frantically, then back at Hunter, then talking to the friend, who said they'd find it in the morning, and she was smiling as she overheard her problem being transferred, as if by a chain of non-native speakers, to the throng around them. "She lost her bracelet," a girl drawled, and one very young-looking girl put a hand on her shoulder. "You'll find it," she slurred.

The enormity of all her mistakes was compounding by the second: not going back to Boston, not confronting Jessie about whether or not he was having an affair, flirting with Hunter, thinking of the black guy at her gym, going out with Len....

She closed her eyes.

Someone handed her a cigarette, and she took it and brought it to her lips. She hadn't smoked in ten years, so she let the air billow in her mouth before sucking it in, which Hunter and his friend watched in appreciation.

"I think," she said, "I had better go home."

They made a big deal of saying that was a bad plan, the party had just started. Hunter fixed his eyes on her. "You're right there," he complained, pointing at her house.

"Don't be lame," his friend added.

She laughed. It was a sharp laugh, and in a way it was a bitter decree on life and how unfair it was, how much she wished she was their age again, when you lost jewelry in the sand and slept on the floor and didn't worry about any of it, when you hadn't had a relationship long enough to know that they could form into a soul-crushing addiction...

"God," she said, putting her hand to her head. "I'm not making any sense."

"That has weed in it," the girl who had patted her arm said reassuringly.

"Oh God," she said, laughing. She reached for Hunter's arm. His muscles were solid under her palm, and they moved, sending a burn through her hand to her belly. "I am definitely out of here," she said. "I've already lost my... bracelet..." She shook her head. "I better get out of here before I lose anything else."

The statement, she realized too late, had a slightly lewd quality to it, but their faces changed drastically and the two guys backed away from her as though she had just produced a head in a jar from her purse. She was just

starting to make a confused face when the very warm, solid shape of a human arm slid over her waist, and a familiar voice said:

“There you *are*.”

Stunned, ice water running through her veins as a solid back pushed against hers and the young guys stepped imperceptibly backward with their mouths starting to dangle oddly, Kim’s drunk mind tried to put everything together.

She turned, saw Len, saw the amused expression on his face, had only a second to think about it, before he said:

“Don’t you ever check your phone?”

She dipped her hand into her purse and pulled it from inside. Messages from *The Sladester*: 5. Beginning with:

Is this a hint?

And an attached photo whose thumbnail she could clearly see contained a picture of her ring.

Len grinned at her. Then he looked around at the party, and finally rested his eyes on the throng of young kids, all males of which had sensed a very terrible danger and were backing away as imperceptibly as they could.

Then he looked back down at Kim.

“Jade,” he said, in a tone of mock fatherliness. “You are *wasted!*”

Everyone stared at the two of them, and Hunter was straining to look apologetic.

“Don’t worry son, I’m not her husband.”

Hunter’s eyes remained skeptical even as his mouth and torso visibly relaxed.

“Just a friend. Slade.” Len extended his hand to Hunter.

“You have it?” Kim said, frantically, forgetting her cool act in her relief.

Len gave her an amazed look as he shook Hunter’s hand.

“So you already knew it was missing,” he said coyly, as the gathering awkwardly dispersed and left them standing together. “And yet here you are on the beach with the neighbors.”

He smiled.

Kim had a sudden, terrible feeling. Len’s smile was the kind that she hated: arrogant, and possessing in leverage. She held her hand out for the

ring while she contemplated why Len might have that smile. After all, she reasoned, she hadn't done anything wrong.

Not really.

Her stomach twisted. Going out with Len alone and getting wasted was in a gray area of acceptability, and she knew it because she wasn't about to tell Jessie about it unless he asked her directly. And if she did tell him about it, she could already hear the way she was going to downplay the drinks, possible phrase things so that it was never clear that Michelle wasn't there, and she certainly wasn't going to offer up the topics of conversation.

She also had been planning, she realized, to not mention this party at all. But now that Len was standing there, her wedding ring somewhere on his person, with this peculiar grin, Kim realized that there was one person standing in the way of hiding this gray-area activity (not to mention, she thought, with a drop in her chest, her use of her middle name, which wasn't infidelity, but it sure would sound bad and be hard to explain to Jessie).

Len was still looking at her, and the ring was not being produced for her empty hand.

"So is it?" Len asked.

She cocked her head. "Huh?"

"Some kind of hint?"

She looked at him, swamped by her guilty thoughts and feelings.

Len leaned closer to her, and his eyes swept around the party behind her. The Cheshire smile intensified, and with his eyes still taking in the party behind her, he murmured. "Or is this a regular game of yours, Kim? I mean, *Jade*."

His eyes locked on hers, and the cool, not entirely unpleasant feeling twisted again in her lower abdomen.

"I lost weight," she said, as flatly as possible, when she found her voice. "It just fell off. Give it to me."

Len stood back from her and looked her up and down. "Too bad," he said.

But he did not produce the ring.

"Are you trying to hook up with that guy?" he asked, jutting his chin in the direction of Hunter behind her.

His voice was low, but to Kim, it was deafening.

She spluttered. "No... Len... what? God."

“That is *hot*,” he said. His expression was overtly sexual, and a wave of discomfort washed over Kim.

Not to mention, that she actually got a weird rush of pleasure from it, for some reason she couldn’t possibly explain.

“Don’t let me stop you,” Len said, holding his hands up.

“*Nothing*,” she said icily, “is going on here. The cab, Uber, whatever, driver dropped me at the wrong house. Can I have my ring, please?”

“Don’t tell me things like that,” Len said, still using a queer voice. “I’d rather go to bed tonight believing that you’re actually the kind of woman who takes her wedding ring off and changes her name and goes fishing for new lovers -”

“Len!” she hissed. She put her hand to her face and gave a nervous laugh, which was as unexpected to her as the hot tears that formed behind her eyelids at the very same time. “God. Just give me the ring.”

She opened her eyes. Len took her falling hand and slipped the ring onto her finger. The touch of his fingers, sliding down the length of her own, sent an erotic shudder through her.

She felt the back of her neck get red.

And then, even more astoundingly, she turned unconsciously to see if Hunter was watching.

Len grinned at her, and his head nodded slightly, as if he understood the whole thing.

“I’m so drunk,” she said quietly, more to herself than to Len. “I have to go home.”

“I’ll walk you back,” Len said cheerfully.

This was, Kim knew, absolutely a situation in which she should say no. She should stake her position very firmly, and tell him to go home. Everything about this evening was going off the rails, and she felt very terrible about all the lies and omissions she would have to give to Jessie, and a bad feeling started to drag her down.

But she found herself doing the strangest thing instead: she turned away from Len and walked, shaking her backside in an appealing manner, to Hunter, slid her arms over his smooth chest and embraced him, with all of his very solid flesh against her, burning through her shirt. “I gotta go home,” she said, kissing him on the cheek.

As she was doing this, she thought of what Len would see as she did it, and something about the idea of him watching her made her pussy throb

with desire. She engaged in the same musing when she walked away from Hunter to Len, thinking about how Hunter was watching her, wishing she would stay, thinking about where she was going with Len.

Maybe even imagining her with him.

She wasn't going to sleep with him, and she knew that. But she *was* going to let Len walk her to her house. Not for any other reason than that she wanted Hunter to watch her do it.

They walked through the sand between the houses and onto the deck, past the glimmering pool. The party had quieted, but it still throbbed next to them in the night air. She tried the sliding door, but she had locked it. "Shit," she said. "Well, let's go around."

"It'd be too bad if you lost your keys," Len said, and he seemed to be only half-joking. "You might have to come home with me and spend the night."

She rolled her eyes, but for some reason she didn't say anything. Why *wasn't* she saying anything? "Len, shut the hell up," is what she would have said, ordinarily. Why not now?

He followed her and watched her dig through her purse for the key to the front door.

She found it with her fingers almost instantly, but she dug for a few moments more, enjoying that tension in the air between them, playing with the fire of the idea of going home with him because she couldn't find the key.

"Got it," she said, pulling it out of her bag. "Okay. I'm going to bed."

She looked at him. "You can't be good to drive," she said.

I'll call you an Uber was the next thing she should have said. She knew that. But her hand rested on the door handle and she said nothing, her heart beating quickly. She was edging closer and closer to the line, with no intention of going over it. She just wanted to see how close she could get.

It gave her a high.

"I might have to stay here," Len said. His hands were in his pockets and he was looking at her as though a plan of his was all coming together.

For a moment, she let it all hang up in the air. She wondered what she was finding appealing about Len at that moment, but the attraction was undeniable.

"Or," she forced herself to say, "you could call an Uber."

Another moment passed between them, so thick with sexual energy it really could have been sliced with a knife.

Then Len's hand moved in his pocket. He smiled at her as he took out his phone. It was a smile that an opponent gives to someone he plans to face off again.

"That's probably what I should do," he agreed affably, while his body language told her that he would rather do the thing he shouldn't.

Her stomach twisted again. Len called his Uber.

She leaned on the door and it opened, easing her body into the house. "You can wait in here," she said. It was a terrible idea, one that could lead to all kinds of problems, and she felt that she had stepped over the line as soon as she said it. She had the sensation of falling, wanting to take it back, suddenly afraid of the door she had opened.

Len contemplated her, and then tipped the phone resting in his palm near his hip toward his face. "Oh. Look at that," he said. "They're right here."

He motioned vaguely in the direction of the street.

"Oh," she said. She was relieved, but didn't want him to know that for some reason.

She dropped a step and reached for him to hug him.

They did that. They had always done that.

But this time the hug was too long, and they both knew it. She pulled away, horrified at her behavior this evening. She tucked a strand of hair over an ear. "Okay, well... thanks," she said. "I'm going to have a really, really fantastic hangover."

Len pointed a finger-gun at her, and clicked cheesily as he pulled the trigger. "I have a cure for that," he told her.

The lights of the Uber swept over him and the car ground on the tiny gravel on the driveway.

"I bet," she said, trying to joke back. Len now seemed like he was back to his old self – lecherous-sounding, not actually lecherous.

"Just give me a call if you want to know what it is."

"I won't," she sang, letting herself into the house again. "Bye..."

She closed the door on the image of Len, that same arrogant, infuriating, smile on his face.

She locked the door and pressed her forehead to the semi-cool metal.

Okay, she thought. The room was spinning and she had said a lot of regrettable things, and maybe flirted with disaster, but her ring was on and she was home and she hadn't *done* anything.

She took a face-dive onto the couch, and thought about sleeping there, but the room was spinning too much so she dragged herself upstairs. The party lights swung through her room from the patio next door, and she stood unsteadily in their wake, watching the figures down below.

She twisted her wedding ring, just to make sure it was there, and it slipped and fell to the floor.

She looked at the curtains, and thought about drawing them.

But then, instead, she crawled onto the bed, and closed her eyes, and imagined Hunter watching her get dressed the next day.

And then she felt whoreish, and dug her phone from her purse, and when she saw that Jessie had sent her a message, about half an hour before Len's messages about her ring. Her eyes welled up with hot tears.

*Hope you had fun tonight with Lenny and Michelle
I love you, Kim*

She typed a message, after trying out several messages of much deeper sentiment and confessional status. *I'm missing you so much tonight*, she began, but deleted. *I can't wait for you to come home*, she tried again, but felt too guilty to send. She settled at last on:

I love you too

Anything else just wasn't true enough to send to him. She'd already done enough half-true or untrue things. She knew she should have admitted to being out alone with Len long before then, but she was too intoxicated to figure out the best way to admit to it. She needed to sleep, sober up, and sort this out in the morning.

CHAPTER 9

Jessie had been unable to sleep. He stared at Kim's message until his eyes blurred, and then, in a fit of both jealousy and guilt, fueled by several whiskeys he had poured himself when he got back to the office, where he preferred to sleep, he had called her.

He had intended to tell her about Michelle, and as the phone rang he changed his mind. He decided to ask Kim how her evening was and see if she confessed to going out with Len alone. If she didn't, he reasoned drunkenly, then he was under no obligation to tell her about Michelle.

He became guilt-ridden again, and had a change of heart, but when she didn't answer, his anger flared again.

He called again, and again she didn't answer.

He struggled to type a message to her, but the first one was angry and the second try was incomprehensible. He deleted them both. He was infuriated, unable to sleep, and wasted.

He lay back on his office couch, and Michelle in her tight blue dress materialized in his mind, as clear as though she was actually there in front of him.

"You're a cuckold," she kept saying, sexily, through her pillowy lips. "Len is probably fucking your wife right now."

And then, as clear as day, he pictured that very scene: Kim, on her hands and knees, her ass thrust up in the air, crashing into Len's pelvis with the wet smack of sweaty skin and the splutter of soaked pussy, her hands entangled in her long black hair, her cheek against the mattress. "Oh Len," she was moaning, her eyes squeezing shut as he pummeled her from behind. "Oh, Len, you fuck me so much better than Jessie. Oh, God."

She squealed and moaned in his daydream, and Len stretched her pussy wide before filling her up with a load of his cum. And it was the idea, the image, of his wife's ass in the air, white cum from another man dripping from her engorged, swollen pussy, that was in his mind when he came, abruptly and wildly, spilling his cum uselessly on the brown leather couch in his office.

Two hours later, still unable to sleep, bleary-eyed and probably still drunk, he was modifying the tickets to Florida online as the inky blue light of dawn crept into the room. He wasn't sure what he was motivated by: a

desire to catch his wife doing something terrible, or the desire to stop her before she did. Part of him very much wanted one, and part of him wanted the other.

Maybe, ridiculously, he wanted both.

It didn't matter. He changed the flight, and called for a cab, because he had just enough time to get to the airport if he left almost immediately.

*

Her car was in the driveway, which filled him with relief.

Kim hadn't texted him all day, and he thought about starting the conversation, but found himself unable to do it. He wanted to sneak up on her, he wanted to surprise her, and he very much wanted to find her at home, doing nothing bad... but he wanted that to be the real way he found her.

Or maybe he did want to catch her in the act of something scandalous? His stomach had lurched and fluttered as the cab moved down their lengthy street, and the house came into view. What would he do, if Len's car were there? Would he creep into the house, walk up the stairs, and stand in the hallway looking into the bedroom, at Len's body sweating on top of his wife?

The closer he got to actually seeing Kim, though, the more confident he felt that he could *do* something about their marriage. There was a sea of worrying things out there, conflicts in his own mind, lingering doubts about Kim and why she hadn't answered her phone this morning or told him the truth about going out with Len alone, but they were all being pushed out of the way as he got closer to the house, and to her. Closer to running his fingers over the back of her neck and pulling her to him, beneath him, around him. He felt sure that she would tell him the truth if she was confronted with him in person.

And then... they would just put all of this behind them. He would tell her about Michelle, tell her that he was jealous and in a funk and that he wanted their marriage back the way it was before. He would tell her about Michelle, and she would tell him about Len, and they would laugh because they both had decided to resist temptation...

Or would Kim start to cry, and tell him, in halted sobs, that she had slipped up, and let Len fuck her all night long?

His cock was hard again, thinking about these terrible possibilities.

You're a cuckold and you like it, Michelle whispered in his ear.

His stomach lurched again, and the now-familiar cold of jealousy worked its erotic fingers through his body.

The door was open: another good sign. Kim didn't lock doors unless she left the house, and even then, her service record was spotty. This was not because she was some country bumpkin, either: Kim had grown up in a city. She was just nuts.

He stared at the door, unsure of whether or not he should walk right in.

Kim was unnerved by surprises. He considered ringing the doorbell, but Kim was known to ignore a doorbell entirely.

He changed his mind, and crept into the house like a cat burglar.

He stood on the tile and cocked his head, straining to hear anything at all. The air kicked in after a minute of breathless waiting. There was no other sound in the house.

He entered the kitchen. The table was cluttered with empty glasses, an Ibuprofen bottle, and three wine glasses, each with a different level of leftover wine in them. He inspected the wine glasses carefully, and noted that two were smeared with lipstick marks, but one was not. He reminded himself that this signified nothing (Kim often wore no lipstick, for example), but the gloss-free rim inflamed his jealousy anyway.

He capped a still-open bottle of wine and focused on the glasses. The scene had the makings of a party, but with whom?

Len, Michelle seemed to whisper in his ear, and his heart fell through his body like a lead weight.

"Honey," he said, inspecting what looked like a trail of ash on the floor. "You here?" He sniffed the air. Had Kim been smoking cigarettes in the house?

Or worse yet – not Kim. Someone else.

Len?

There was no answer, and he righted his head and listened until his head hurt. There was no sound from within the house, but he had a tingling sensation on the back of his neck, and a desire to search the house and uncover something. What he wanted to find was hard to say. He was overtaken by the disturbingly pleasant sensation of riding a roller coaster, a feeling that attacked his groin, stomach, and chest with a churning cold.

He walked slowly through the rooms, noting which had been used and which had not. The evidence of the things his wife did while home alone in Florida. His pulse raced when he came across a crumpled piece of black clothing on the floor, next to the couch in the living room. He stared at it, his imagination rocketing away to scenarios involving the item slipping from the naked curves of his wife before she climbed onto the bare lap of a lover. Then he picked it up and found it to be only a swimsuit cover.

Not damning, in and of itself.

A confusing flicker of disappointment licked at the base of his neck, pouring water on a fire inside of him. Seeing the clothing in a heap on the floor, and knowing she hadn't taken her clothes off in front of *him*, or for *him*, had given him a very particular kind of rush.

He moved upstairs, where he found everything in much greater disarray than he expected. Clothes were strewn all over the closet like a teenage girl had been through. The vanity in the master bathroom was covered in opened make-up containers, and a curling iron was still plugged in, though off, with the iron in the sink.

Kim, dressing up. Kim, dolling up.

And not for him.

The sliding door to the balcony was slightly open, and a cool breeze off the water picked up a curtain and made it billow into the room.

With it came the unmistakable laugh of his wife.

Turning toward the sound, he made his way toward the window.

The whole scene, utterly unexpected, unfolded before him, turning him suddenly to ice.

Up went the roller coaster. And his body tingled at the crest, expecting the ride down.

His wife was on the beach, lying on a red towel. The towel was plush and bright and although it was the sort of thing Jessie was unlikely as hell to notice, he knew immediately that it was not one of their towels. A black bikini bottom covered the very sculpted curve of her ass, though much less so than he would have liked. She was tanned, and her back was bare, the straps of her bikini untied and presumably lying on either side of her body. Her hair was spread out around her head in a gleaming pile of ebony silk, her face turned.

In all honesty, if it hadn't been for the laugh, he would have glanced outside and not recognized her. The bikini, the untied straps, the toned

muscle – they were all unfamiliarly familiar.

But not only that.

A very young guy – not Len, who Jessie had almost come to accept had fucked his wife, and almost expected to see - was sitting next to her. He was dark from the sun, and even at this distance it was plain to see the youthfulness of his muscles, the flatness of his abs and the lean strength everywhere in his body. Even the way he was sitting, propped up on one bulging arm and leaning forward (causing only the hardest of muscular creases in his abdomen) implied a youth that was long lost to Jessie. He was springy.

And his other hand was rubbing Jessie's wife's back. While she laughed.

Or more appropriately stated: she was squealing.

The sound was too young for his wife, but her voice was unmistakable as she shouted something in a high pitch – the words were not audible but her voice was. The muscle man continued, laughing, to rub her back and console her for whatever it was she squealing pleasantly about.

Jessie was falling, falling on the roller coaster, his chest as heavy as though an elephant was stepping on it.

Kim sat up suddenly, on her elbows, pressing her arms to her chest and giving her magnificent mane of hair a toss. The muscle-man squeezed something from a bottle and playfully tapped the sunscreen onto her face, his mouth wide in a grin from which new, young white teeth practically glinted like a toothpaste ad.

Anger flared inside of Jessie's chest – a simple emotion to recognize, jealousy. He could feel it making his fists tighten into balls. But curiously, that roller-coaster sensation was taking him up, up, up again, and he was sinking onto the edge of the bed to watch. To watch his wife being sunscreened by this...kid... and take another ride down.

And his cock was hard. Hard as a fucking rock. His stomach was cold and coiled up, and as he watched his wife throw her hair around again and lengthen her body in a feline stretch as she lay out on the towel again, he had a single, coherent thought in the soup of emotions in his head:

He was turned on by this.

His balls ached and his cock throbbed, as though to nod affirmatively to him about this conclusion.

He watched, and watched, and watched. The time ticked by slowly, and yet it also felt as though only seconds had passed, and the pair did almost nothing in that time: the kid got up and walked to the water, then dove into an oncoming wave. He was under for a long time, and appeared moments later, far out in the grayish water, shaking his mane of hair.

And Kim, his own wife Kim, had propped her chin on her folded arms to watch him. Her legs flicked up and she kicked her feet playfully in the air.

The guy returned, Kim watching him all the way.

Jessie's chest was on fire now. They looked like a couple: there was an air of familiarity between them, revealed in their conjoined towels, in the rubbing of sunscreen, in the way they watched each other, and it was making him so sick to his stomach he was sure he might throw up.

But also his cock was pulsing, his balls screaming. He stared at them, unable to take his eyes off, even as his world collapsed inside his mind somewhere: was this the end of them? Was Kim going to ask for a divorce? Was she actually some raging slut all this time, and he a witless cuckold? The humiliation of it poured slowly over him, but instead of wilting his desire it only made him hungrier. All the way to his teeth, a numbness set in, as he stared and stared and stared. The guy was lying on his back, and Kim was on her front, her head on her hands, her face turned away from him, but still.

It was too intimate.

Far, far too intimate.

It had started to get dark, and the couple stirred again. The guy, responding to Kim, reached over her ribcage, and made her body jerk and another loud laugh escape her as his fingers brushed over the very ticklish place between her second and third rib – on the left side only, such a curious feature of a woman's body. He then spent a long time tying the strings together, first at the center of her back, then at the nape of her neck after she sat up on her heels.

There was no mistaking that after tying the bikini at her neck, his hands traveled unnecessarily over her shoulders as he dropped them.

He was too numb to react as they stood up, and shook out the towels, and turned toward his house. *His house*. Beneath him, they crossed the patio and clunked into the house.

Jessie rose, his ears pricked for the sound of their voices, which were low and infrequent and indistinguishable.

A laugh.

The hiss of a can, the clink of ice in a glass.

More low voices as Jessie slowly walked out to the stairs.

Their voices came into focus as he made a zombie-like march down the stairs and toward the kitchen from the center hallway. She was standing on the opposite side of the counter, and the guy was sitting in a tall stool, facing her.

“.... not really hard to imagine,” his voice was saying, when they both saw him and jerked their heads in his direction.

Kim’s hair was wavy the way only salt and wind could make it, framing her sun-kissed face gloriously. How many hours, Jessie wondered, had she spent on the sand with this young guy, to turn her skin even the slightly tanned color it was now? Her cheeks were pink and flushed – the flush not the kind that comes from warm beaches, but rather an inner fire.

Her mouth fell open. “Jessie! Jesus! You scared the shit out of me!”

Nervousness, and confusion, sprinkled over the kid’s face, but he had the confident manner of a surfer and the cocksure steadiness of a rich kid who will probably be a banker someday. He held Jessie’s gaze as long as Jessie looked at him.

Kim had jumped when she saw him. She was never any good at containing her facial expressions when startled.

But she was recovering quickly.

“Jessie, this is Hunter. He lives next door. Hunter, this is Jessie.”

Hunter lifted his fingers in greeting. “Hey, man,” he said. His tone was not unfriendly. It was the tone of a man who is certain he’s got something in the bag, and that you pose no threat to him.

Almost, Jessie thought bitterly, as if the little shit felt sorry for him.

And then there was the other crushing weight that sank into his chest: “*this is Jessie.*”

Not: my husband.

Just: Jessie.

Jessie stood where he was, and looked plainly at Kim. He would let her extricate herself, he decided. He almost wanted to see her lie, to feel the naked pain of it, because she had to know that anything she said would sound like treachery, and so she would be doing it on purpose.

But it was Hunter who saved her, and all of them. He cleared his throat and set his beer bottle – half full – confidently on the table. “Yeah. Well. I’m off anyway, got some shit to do around the house.”

He stood up and shot a hand out in Jessie’s direction, walking toward him. Jessie gripped his hand firmly, and they glared at each other behind their smiles.

“Nice meeting you,” Hunter said plainly. “Later, J.”

“Same,” Jessie was saying, so the “later J,” only caught up to him well after Hunter had turned and started toward the door.

Jessie walked over to where Hunter had been sitting, while Kim took another long sip of her wine. “Wow,” she said, finishing in two gulps. “You scared the hell out of me, really.”

Jessie looked at her.

“You want something to drink?” she asked. She turned toward the fridge without waiting for his answer and the door rattled with beers. “Wait... what’s today? It’s Thursday. You’re... I thought you were coming on Friday. What are you – maybe I’m mixed up. I’ve been losing track of what day it is... is Miller okay? There’s nothing better, really. I don’t even know why I have this.”

She was babbling, her speech muddled and fast. She kept going as she opened the drawer next to her hip and fished out a bottle opener to open the screw-off cap.

“I thought I’d surprise you,” he said, and her voice fell silent.

He took a sip of his beer. His cock was mysteriously swelling, even harder than it had been in the bedroom, and he found himself wanting to solicit more lies from Kim, as many as he could. As much as he also didn’t want her to lie. It was weird.

“So,” he said. “Who’s the boy-toy?”

Kim made a good show – a spectacular show, really – of rolling her eyes and shrugging. “Yeah, him, he’s just the neighbor kid, I, uh, you know he’s around all day so I guess we’ve just all started hanging out, having some drinks around four, they’re young so they usually start at noon.”

She looked at him, and her eyes dashed away from his stare. “It’s also, like, not just him, but the guys who live with him, there are a whole bunch of them and we just started hanging out.”

Jessie was nodding, and it was making her nervous, so she flung out a final attempt to cover up her lewd behavior:

“I think I’m sort of a den mother character to them,” she whispered. And she smiled. *Just me, Kim, soooo much older than that guy. They just want me to bake cookies, is all. Nothing to see here.*

“Huh,” Jessie said, tilting his head back and swallowing some beer. “Funny. That’s not the impression I got from him.”

Kim turned quickly toward the refrigerator and opened it. “Don’t be -” She changed tack suddenly. “Oh yeah, what makes you think that?”

Jessie shrugged. Very suddenly he didn’t want to give all his cards away. In fact, as he sat there listening to his wife tell lies of perspective, lies of omission, he was formulating a plan of his own. Seeing her here with this...kid... on top of her not telling him about going out with Len alone, made his insides boil. But for some reason, he wanted to let it simmer for a while.

“I don’t know,” he said, standing up. “You’re looking pretty good in that suit. If he does think of you as a den mother, it’s a den MILF.”

He had come around the counter and was standing next to her, backing her into the counter, his hands on her hips. Her skin was soft, a little grainy from sand, and hot to the touch. He watched the feathery hairs on her neck raise as his fingers traveled up her ribs – she had piled her hair on the top of her head at some point, and tendrils of it cascaded about her face. “This a is a new suit,” he said. “When did you get it?”

His fingers were moving down her navel now, just at the edge of the bikini bottoms, as though he needed to clarify “which” suit he was talking about. Kim’s face was stunned. His lips were very close to her mouth, and he knew that she could feel his cock against her thigh.

Moving his right hand from her hip down the outside of her thigh, then inward, to catch his finger on the hem of the suit bottom, he moved his mouth toward her ear.

“Aren’t you even going to ask me what I’m doing here so early?”

At the end of the question several things happened all at once, and the fire of it consumed him: a ripple of goosebumps spread across the back of her neck, his fingers slipped downward and under the hem, grazing his knuckles over the baby-smooth flesh of her freshly waxed pussy and dipped into a hot, wet slurry of juices, the scent of which assailed his nose and filled his head with the tangy aroma of her cunt. His cock pulsed, and her body shuddered – or flinched, depending on how you wanted to look at it – and a very low, soft gasp escaped her parted lips.

Was she flinching because her suit was soaked, or because it gave her pleasure to feel her husband's fingers sinking into her pussy? Inside, she was so hot she felt feverish, and so wet that he glided into her like butter.

She had an expression of disbelief on her face: was it because she couldn't believe she was caught, or because she couldn't believe she was off the hook? Did she want him to fuck her because she was so wet and aching for the cock of the young man who had just left her, or was she longing for him, Jessie?

He didn't care. Her pussy was so velvety and wet and her body responding like it hadn't for years. He pushed her against the counter and up onto it, sending two of the wine glasses crashing into the sink, where they shattered loudly. Neither of them looked in their direction.

Kim's eyes were on his, and he could not read fear or desire in them: maybe both. Surprise, disbelief, fear, desire... it could have been anything. But importantly, it was an absorption.

He pushed the fabric to the side to delve further with his hand into her pussy, feeling the slickness carefully, inhaling her scent. What would he do if his nose encountered the scent of cum, if his fingers came to some slimier patch of juices that could not have come from her?

He pushed deep inside of her, probing for it, and her pussy spasmed around his fingers, her mouth emitted a puff of air. Her eyelids dropped as he clawed outward toward the root of her clit.

"You're so wet," he breathed next to her ear. His free hand traveled to her neck, running his thumb over her mouth, wondering if she had opened it for Hunter's cock, if he had peered inside to see his cum pooled in her throat after spilling it inside of her.

She mewled, and he bit her ear gently. "Why are you so wet, hmm? Are you up to something with your next-door friend there?"

She tried to lean back to look at him in surprise, but he grabbed the back of her head and pushed her toward his mouth, sucking her inside of him and swallowing whatever she was saying, or her moans. His fingers were deep inside of her, finger-fucking her hard, and her body was not resisting him. She was opening wildly to him, pushing against him.

He released her mouth and pulled away from her to look at her face. She was confused, afraid, hiding something, for sure.

He grabbed her and spun her around, pushing her down on the counter and unzipping his pants in frenzied motions. His cock sprang in front of

him, and he was inside of her in one hard thrust. He gripped her by the back of the neck, her black hair tumbled down over his arm. He stared at her very firm buttocks as he smashed into them, the column of his cock stickily thrusting into her pussy.

And as he fucked her, he pictured her bent over the counter just like she was now, another man fucking his cum into her.

The image, perhaps, was what sent him over the edge, and he tried to slow down so that he could stay longer in her heated pussy, but when he slowed, she thrust backward against him and squeezed him inside of her. There was no hope, but he felt her own orgasm throbbing around him and beneath the rush of blood in his ears heard her howling, so he drove in hard and exploded inside of her.

Their skin was slippery with sweat, and Kim lost her grip on the counter when he relaxed, sending her body sliding over the granite top with a squeak. She turned to look at him, pushing her hair out of the way, her mouth turned up in a smile, and his cock slipped from inside of her.

Then they both laughed.

Jessie's ears were ringing, his blood invigorated with the long-forgotten sensation of having had passionate sex. For a few moments, he was suspended in this solution, floating in a dream: Kim turned and leaned against the counter, the strings of her bikini loosened and askew, falling from one shoulder, her lips puffed from kissing, cheeks flushed. Her long tan legs crossed, and Jessie saw a rivulet of his cum snake down her inner thigh.

She brought her fingers to her lips, feeling them, almost as if they didn't belong to her. Her eyes were on his.

No one had to say it: this was the best sex they had had in a long, long time. Not only the most unusual, because sex had become more of a scheduled chore in the recent past, but also the best. Jessie and Kim did not fuck in the kitchen, in the afternoon, and not like *that*.

She looked as if she had something she wanted to ask him, but she didn't say it.

And all of his suspicions, momentarily, were pushed out of his mind. She poured him something to drink – he drank it, though he would be very hard-pressed to tell anyone what it was if someone had asked.

Finally, she looked around the kitchen, and seeing the wine glasses and the sunscreen bottle, Jessie could actually see guilt creep back into her

expression.

“You’re here early,” she said, giving her hair a shake. It seemed almost like a challenge, or an accusation the way she said it.

“I wanted to surprise you,” Jessie said, his voice equally challenging.

They looked at each other, and the air between them seemed to crackle.

She set her wine glass down. “Well,” she said. “What should we do?”

Jessie thought of saying that he could go for some more of what they had just done, because remarkably, he was feeling horny again, and even more strangely, it seemed to be fueled by the secretive way his wife was looking at him.

“Dinner?” he asked, blandly.

She seemed to be moving long before he actually spoke, already pointing down the hallway to the stairs, already saying: “I’ll just go change.”

Already, Jessie thought, in a hurry to get out of here. He had that feeling that there was something she was trying to hide.

She paused at the banister, her left hand on the knob, the fingers moving seductively.

Something wrong with the picture, and he didn’t know what, but the cold angst that had gripped him before was inching its way through his torso again. “You ready?” she asked.

“Huh?” Jessie said, his mind still seeking the answer: what was wrong with the picture in front of him?

“to go? Or do you need to change?”

Jessie picked up his glass. “I’ll be up in a second, I guess. You go first.”

He meant, taking a shower, because it was what they did, the only way it made sense: she would get ready while he showered...

She trotted up the stairs. Did she do it more quickly than usual?

Jessie closed his eyes as the numbing cold spread through his body.

Then they flew open.

An even colder pain shot through the center of his body.

The ring.

He moved as though he had no feet. Gliding, numb. Maybe this *was* a dream, he thought idly.

Maybe he had it all wrong. It was easy to see something that wasn't there, perhaps it was easy to not see something that was.

He was in the bedroom. The sheets were rumpled: he hadn't noticed this before. Each item in the room was cast in a new, nefarious light. Through the window, the sight of the beach and the neighbor's fence sent a wave of strangely pleasurable pain through his stomach.

The water cascaded to the floor in the shower, the sound of Kim wringing water from her thick hair.

He glided, still in a trance, toward the bathroom, headed there to look at her finger, to see if the ring was missing as he had suspected.

He swept the messy room with his eyes, finding everything he looked for and nothing amiss except the unusual disorganization.

The shower turned off, and just as the last splash of water turned to silence, his vision narrowed as though in a tunnel, and another terrible pang beat inside his chest.

Just time for the sick beast in his abdomen to writhe again, Kim appeared in the doorway to the bathroom. She was wrapped in a towel, her skin scrubbed clean and glowing, her black hair slicked down her back. Her eyes seemed especially blue, and she looked at him curiously.

His eyes fell to her left hand, which was holding the towel up. The sight of her ringless finger didn't shock him as much as he might have suspected.

"Where's your ring?" His cock throbbed.

When she looked down at her fingers, it happened in slow-motion to him. She turned the fingers upward, palm flat and down, and the towel began to slip from her body. Her thumb rolled on the underside of her finger.

This was it, he was thinking: he had caught her.

"Oh," she said. Her voice was unsurprised. "I need to get some of those silicone thingies, what are they called? You put them around the band? It keeps falling off."

She dropped the towel, and gave him a look of invitation.

"What?" Jessie said, stupidly, half of his brain now shifting to the curves of her body, the tan lines from her skimpy bikini, the buttery folds of her pussy, and her bare finger.

"You're talking about my wedding ring, right?" she said casually, turning to go into the closet. Her round bottom was sensual and firmer than

before, and Jessie stared at it, trying to bring his mind back to all the thoughts he wanted to follow: the ring, the sunscreen... but she looked so good, and the scent of her pussy was still on his fingers...

"It's on the dresser," she said, selecting a shirt from the rack. "It keeps falling off."

Jessie blinked.

She put a hand on her hip and leaned on the doorframe. "Because I've lost so much weight," she said, half-joking, half indignant.

There was a long pause, and Jessie just looked back at her, drinking in the vision of her body.

"You're supposed to say, 'you look hot,'" Kim told him, rolling her eyes and walking to the dresser.

She stood in front of the mirror and lifted some earrings to her ears. She had pulled the shirt she selected over her head. No bra, just the upturned mounds of her breasts and the faint outline of her nipples against the fabric, promising to enlarge at the slightest sea breeze. She still had no panties on, and the shirt hugged her waist and framed her ass and long legs.

The window was still open, the view of the neighbor's yard still visible from where he stood. He doubted that someone outside could see so far into the dim bedroom, but it was still brazen.

"You sure that's the only reason?" Jessie said, suddenly indignant.

She set the earrings down and looked at him in the mirror. "The only reason what?" she asked, pulling a drawer open and taking out a pair of black panties.

"Your ring. That's the only reason you're not wearing it?"

Jessie looked down at the underwear and stepped into it, her lips pressing tightly together. She shimmied the silky black fabric up the length of her legs, her gaze traveling slowly back to meet his. "What's that supposed to mean?"

Jessie shrugged. "I dunno," he said. "But you have to admit, it's a little suspicious coming home to you and the hot stud next door--"

He stopped himself. He wasn't exactly sure why, just again had the feeling that he didn't want to put all his cards on the table. For some reason, he didn't want to tell Kim he'd seen her on the beach, Hunter's hands rubbing the lotion all over her body.

Kim was shaking her head. "God," she was saying. "I already told you _."

“And then your ring is missing?” Jessie said. “A little bit of a coincidence don’t you think?”

Kim stood up straight, pulling a pair of jean shorts up along with the straightening of her back. She looked at him archly. “Are you accusing me,” she asked him, “of having an affair?”

She could have caused less pain had she tossed a dart right into his chest.

“Well, Kim,” he spluttered, waving his hand around the room, as though it all served as evidence of just such an accusation.

Kim’s eyes followed his hand, and her own hands came back to her hips.

Defiantly.

“You caught me,” she said, jutting one hip to the side. She gave her wet hair a light toss and it slapped against her back. Her features were.... What were they? Defiant? Sexy? Hungry, in some way he had never seen before. Her eyes glinted.

“You’re fucking the neighbor?” Jessie said. His voice surprised him. This was a game, and he was cheerful, and it was partly fantasy and dangerously close to being true, and his cock was so hard it pulsed painfully with each serrated word his wife flung at him.

She was walking toward him. Was this a game, still, or was she serious? “Not just him,” she said, and Jessie’s cock throbbed while his heart seized painfully in his chest.

“Who else?” he asked, as his gorgeous wife climbed onto his lap and his hands traveled along her thighs and beneath the flimsy shirt she was wearing, taking the fabric with them and up and over her head.

Her wet hair fell to her back, and water snaked along her collarbone and over her breasts, still bouncing as they were loosed from the shirt. She pushed him back, so he was laying on the bed. He caught them in his palms and felt her nipples swell and harden beneath his touch. He could smell her pussy, beneath the layers of fresh soap and shampoo, and her panties were still on so she must have been soaked. She rose up on her knees, and her breasts dangled just out of his reach.

He busied his hands getting himself freed from his pants, staring at his wife, who seemed like someone else entirely.

“You wouldn’t know him,” she said, her eyes on his hands and his cock as he pulled himself out of his pants and wriggled to be more free. She

dropped her hand to his dick and trailed her fingers lightly along his shaft. "He's a guy from the gym."

Jessie sat up and grasped her by the small of her back, pushing her down onto his lap. Her soaked panties dripped onto his cock. "Oh yeah?" he growled.

She gave him an infuriatingly mysterious smile, not answering.

"Is that why you're so wet?" he asked her, dipping his hand into her panties. Her bare pussy was soft, slightly squeaky from the shower, but as soon as he touched her folds they ripened, bursting open into a hot, sticky mess like a split fruit.

She moaned as an answer, or maybe because he thrust three fingers into her pussy at once and curled his hand toward her clit. Her mouth fell open and she looked down at him with wide eyes as he lifted her, mostly with the hand buried in her cunt, and then made her body roll on his fist as he fucked her with his hand.

What if this wasn't a game, what if she really had let some guy at the gym fill this same pussy he was fist-fucking with his big huge cock? What if someone else had felt all the silky folds of her with his dick?

He pushed her off his lap and onto the bed. "Get on your hands and knees," he whispered, as he stood and turned, shaking his pants down to his ankles.

His wife, meanwhile, leaned forward onto her elbows and kicked her feet up playfully, stretching out and thrusting her ass toward him. He reached for her panties and pulled them down to mid-thigh. She looked back at him, a grin on her face.

"Do you act like a little slut with him?" Jessie said, although he could barely believe he was saying it. He could also barely believe that his wife's pussy was so wet, that her response to this question was to draw a strand of wet hair across her lips, her mouth open, her eyes batting sexily at him. She grinned, and pushed her ass up higher for him, but gave him no answer.

"Show me how you fuck him, you cheating little slut."

His cock throbbed as he said the words. His wife backed toward him, and pushed her pussy over the length of his shaft as he stood there, holding it until she had consumed him halfway. And then she began to buck against him, slapping her ass into his thighs.

He dropped a hand to the small of her back to steady himself, as his wife rocked on her hands and knees, milking his cock of cum for the second

time in less than an hour. She was facing the headboard now: was she thinking of another lover? Did she actually fuck some other man like this?

She tipped her head back, and her thrusting went wild until she froze, her entire body momentarily rigid. Her pussy seemed to seep juices around his cock as she squeezed him tightly. Then she dropped her chest to the bed, panting.

He started to fuck her, her pussy sloshing around him, squelching with each thrust. He absent-mindedly dropped his thumb to her ass, drawing her juices from her engorged pussy and up to her pink eyelet, swirling the pad of his thumb over the rubbery surface.

“Does he have a big thick cock?”

She pushed her hair up and over her head with both hands, leaving her cheek on the bed to be dragged back and forth with each of his thrusts. “It’s so big,” she said hoarsely. “My pussy is so sore...”

Jessie could feel himself get tipped over the edge as she wriggled her ass, her pussy clearly a little sore just from coming so much, with him still fucking her.

He slowed his thrusts, trying to keep going long enough for her to come again, but the way she was moaning, playing with her hair, lying on the sheets and letting him fuck her raised ass, he didn’t stand a chance.

He grabbed her hips and started to impale her with his cock, which made her squeal in delight and wriggle her feet.

He was seeing stars when his orgasm gripped him and his cum exploded into Kim’s pussy. He shoved each jolt of cum as deep inside of her as he could go, picturing, with each thrust, a thicker cock stretching his wife out as she clawed at the sheets, moaning in ecstasy.

He looked down at her, breathing heavily from the exertion, for a few minutes, his cock slowly wilting in her soaked pussy. She was still except for the rise and fall of her chest.

His cock flopped out of her and he stood up, but found himself unsteady, so he flopped onto the bed next to her as she rolled her ass to one side, folding onto the bed, facing him.

Now that it was over, they each looked a little sheepish. He could feel it in his own features, and see it in hers. He extended his hand and played with a strand of hair clinging to her face.

It was all just a game, wasn’t it? He wanted to ask her, to confirm it with her, but something stopped him. Perhaps it was the fear that she would

say it wasn't. Perhaps it was a desire not to break the spell. Partly he didn't want her to rise up, accusingly, and shoot him a look of disbelief: who the hell did he think she was?

All three reasons made him say nothing as he played with her hair and she caressed his hand. More than anything, he didn't want the spell to break. This was the closest he had felt to her in a long, long time. It was certainly the best sex they'd had in a long time, and he couldn't even remember the last time they'd had sex twice on the same day, let alone within only half an hour.

Her face clouded over after a bit, and she sat up, looking behind her for the shirt or the panties, both of which had disappeared. She sifted through the strewn sheets for a moment and then gave up, rising next to the bed and stretching her arms up.

He rolled onto his back, which is when the fading sun caught his eye and he realized that the curtains were wide open, as was the window. "Uh oh," he said, looking back at her as he propped himself up on his elbows.

Kim walked lazily to the bathroom. "That's okay," she said. "He likes to watch."

Jessie heard her turn on the water again, the image of her lean naked body stretching burned into his retina, the light catching the dribble of cum snaking down her thigh.

His heart squeezed again, though. Because no matter how much of this was make-believe, the curtains were, very truly, open wide, and the neighbor probably had at least heard, if not just watched, everything that had transpired.

And Kim really, truly, did not care.

And just then, he realized that he didn't *want* Kim to be having an affair.

As much as it turned him on.

He rubbed his face and sat up.

Kim came out of the bathroom again, rubbing herself dry with a new towel. "About that dinner..." she said. "I'm definitely hungry now."

She dropped the towel on the floor and stood in front of the mirror, fully naked.

She leaned over the counter and began to apply mascara to her eyelashes.

Dinner.

The unanswered questions flooded his mind. He scratched the back of his head.

“So how was dinner with Len and Michelle?” he asked.

She pushed the mascara brush into the tube, looking at it as though it were a complex bomb diffusion. Then she looked back up at her reflection in the mirror.

Eyes back to him, finger rubbing the top of her eyelid. “What’s that?”

“How was dinner?”

She looked down at her lipstick tube. “Uh, yeah. Good. Really good... just, uh...”

There was a long pause, and she looked at him in the mirror, weighing something. Her eyes moved back and forth, the way people search for something.

Jessie watched her. Was she going to admit to going out to dinner with Len alone? Or was this going to be just one more thing she would “omit” telling him?

She was very carefully putting her mascara on, making surgical movements repeatedly over her eyelashes. She closed the tube, watching it screw closed as though she had a heavy heart. “Those guys seem to have a lot of problems lately,” she finally said.

She met his eyes in the mirror, and they exchanged a look for a moment.

It wasn’t an outright lie, he thought. But it wasn’t the truth, it wasn’t honest.

An honest wife would have said: Only Len was there.

Or have her wedding ring on her finger instead of the dresser.

Or had she just been honest, and he was just being a foolish cuckold? Maybe the game they had just played was no game at all.

Why couldn’t they just *talk* to each other? Jessie wondered. At moments like this one, it seemed like Kim wanted to open up about *them*, say something about their own problems and their own marriage.

She returned her gaze to her mascara application, seemingly having forgotten she had already applied it. “What’s new in Boston?” she asked. Her voice had a tone of cheerful subject-changing.

Jessie looked at her in the mirror. Now he was in the hot seat: did he tell Kim that Michelle had met him in Boston? And how much of that story did he tell her? Did he *want* to catch her in this lie, or did he want to see

how long she would go? Had Kim and Len gotten as close to the line of inappropriate behavior as he and Michelle had gotten?

His heart felt like it had a cramp in it.

He didn't answer, and after a while, Kim looked quietly at her hands as she put her makeup away. She seemed sad – her expression, in fact, captured the way that he felt about her not telling him she had gone to dinner with Len alone.

But then... had Len told Kim that Michelle was in Boston? Was Kim fishing for this the way he was fishing for her to tell him the truth?

"I know Michelle wasn't at dinner with you and Len," Jessie said flatly.

The sentence escaped his mouth and landed with a thud in the space between them. It was almost as if it possessed a physical body, and they were both staring at it as it writhed on the floor.

Kim had turned around. She snatched a t-shirt and pulled it over her head, which made it possible to see that she was shaking slightly.

"Michelle was in Boston," Jessie said, making sure that he came clean first. The game was less fun now, now it felt more like a marital argument. Even before Kim spoke.

Kim pushed her hair impatiently behind her neck with two hands. "I didn't tell you," she said, and Jessie believed it was the beginning of a comment, until almost a full minute passed without her adding to it and he realized that was all she had to say.

"Yeah, and why not?" he asked her.

Kim shrugged. "And what do you mean, Michelle was in Boston? How'd you know that?"

He looked away. "I saw her."

There was a silence.

"Are you having an affair?" Kim yelled at him suddenly. He could tell she hadn't meant to let her voice crack or for her fury to be revealed to him, and he was as surprised by the anger as he was by the question.

"What?" he protested. "No, Kim. *I'm* not having an affair." Then his eyes narrowed. "Are you?"

"That was all a joke," she said, and it took him a second to realize she was talking about their dirty talk. She added: "But *you* certainly seemed to like it."

She seemed bitter about that. Jessie had no idea what to say, because it was pretty hard to deny that he had enjoyed that game. He felt guilty, and then defensive.

He looked around the room. The snippets of bad behavior on Kim's part came to the aid of his defense. "Okay, a joke, huh? The open curtains, the wedding ring -"

"I told you, I lost weight and -"

"I saw you out there, while Huntsville or whatever his name rubbed lotion all over your body," he said accusingly.

This stopped her in mid-sentence. Her mouth hung open for a moment, and then snapped closed.

She folded her arms over her chest.

Kim's eyes were wet and her voice cracked when she said: "You know, this is the first time, in however long, that you've taken any interest in me?"

Jessie was taken aback. "What?" he asked. "What... what is that supposed to mean?"

"It means," Kim said, storming to the dresser and jerking it open, "that you've been pretty much not there, when I talk to you or we have sex or... or.... Or anything. And now, all the sudden, we're having this hot sex and it's all because *you*," she had a pair of underwear in her hand as she turned to point a finger at him accusingly, "think that *I'm* having an affair?!" She let out a haughty laugh at the end.

This last part sounded like a question, like he was supposed to confirm or deny it, and yet he didn't feel like he could do either without somehow stepping in it.

She clumsily pulled the underwear on, first one leg than the other. "Sounds like projection to me," she snapped.

"Kim, I'm not having an affair," he repeated, not sure at all what else to say.

She folded her arms again and kicked something on the floor out of the way. "No? So what were you doing with Michelle, then? Just hanging out? And here's a question for you: why didn't you just say that you'd seen Michelle? Huh?" She pauses to take a breath, shaking her head like she was almost too furious to continue. "Do you know Len told me some very, *very* interesting things about their relationship?"

This was not a curiosity question: she threw it at him like boiling tar.

Jessie held his hands out and dropped them to his sides, unable to think of anything better to do. His mind was reeling.

They faced each other, each of them breathing heavily with the sort of tight, angry breaths one takes while arguing. The back of his neck felt hot.

“You know what?” he said, and a well of anger sprang up inside of him. “Who the hell are you to accuse me of something? You want the truth? Michelle *did* show up in Boston, uninvited, and she looked fucking hot, and she was putting the moves on me hard, and you know what else? There are a lot of women who do that to me. But I turn them all down, because I am married to *you*.”

“Len told me,” Kim continued, as if she hadn’t even heard him, “that he and Michelle have an open relationship. That he likes watching Michelle fuck other guys. And I was like, ‘what the hell is this?’ I was thinking. What the fuck? But you know what, now I’m starting to think... I don’t know. Maybe that’s what *you* want.” Her head shook again with quiet fury. “Maybe you’re the guy Len likes watching Michelle fuck. For all I know.”

She stomped into the closet and started pulling clothes from the shelves.

The problem with arguments like this one, Jessie thought, was that they had built up over a long period of time, and now they were just an explosion. An explosion of unrelated ideas and feelings.

“What exactly are you trying to say, Kim?” he said, and he sounded angrier than he wanted to. He realized, somewhere inside, that he was mad at her. Mad at her for taking him for granted, mad at her for telling him he had no interest in her, mad at her for thinking he was having an affair when he had so diligently avoided it, mad at her for having no appreciation of all the hard work he did and all the sacrifices he made to keep her happy.

And buried somewhere even deeper, even more lost to his conscious thoughts than all of that, he was perplexed by himself, by the fact that what she was saying was true, and it surprised no one as much as it surprised him: he *had* enjoyed the thought of her fucking the neighbor, the gym guy, hell, even cheating on him with Len. He had hated it and loved it, and there was no way to deny that he hadn’t been physically enthralled by it.

Kim was struggling with a pair of jeans, because she was so angry that her coordination had fallen apart. She threw them at the floor in frustration and pushed her hair from her face, where it had fallen in now-drying waves and clung to her damp skin. “I don’t know what I’m saying,” she said,

glaring at the jeans as if she were talking to them. "I just want... I just want...I want everything back like it used to be," she huffed, blowing her bangs from her head and taking the jeans back up in her hands, trying to straighten them out. "I want you to give a shit, you know, what I'm doing, and be... I don't know... excited about me, like we used to be. I want..." she looked up, and past him, at the wall or maybe the window, and her eyes went blank, as though she were imagining something and had to squint to see it.

Jessie had a profound feeling that he needed to bring this whole conversation back under control, but he had no idea how to do it.

And even though he knew it was the wrong thing to say, it was the first thing that came to his mind, because it was the only real thing he could think of at that moment, and the memory of it was like a barb in his heart. "So what *were* you doing with the neighbor out there, Kim? What *are* you doing with him? Why *didn't* you tell me that Len took you out? Alone?"

Her eyes returned to his, and came into focus. She opened her mouth, and it seemed like she was ready to yell at him, but then her shoulders slumped and she dropped her hands at her sides, the jeans angrily bunched in one hand. "I don't know," she admitted. She wiped her cheek, where a tear had spilled, impatiently with her free hand. "I didn't *fuck* him, if that's what you're asking."

Jessie had folded his own arms and looked out the window, as if he could see the truth out there on the beach. "Right. You just needed someone to rub sunscreen all over you. You two just hang out and drink wine together while your husband's away," he said snarkily.

Kim shook the jeans out and inserted a foot with surprising ease considering how much trouble she'd been having. "Actually," she said, "Yes."

"And that was going nowhere, am I right?" Jessie said. He was angry, this was an argument, and it was very, very real, and very much about his wife flirting with a young, hot guy almost to the point of no return... but he was also, he could feel, getting aroused by it. He took a few steps toward Kim, his erection inexplicable to himself. "He's like eighteen, Kim."

She glared at him, sliding the jeans up to her waist and zipping them harshly. "I didn't fuck him," she snapped.

"Eighteen-year-old guys -"

"He's twenty...one, twenty-two," she interjected.

“ - do not just ‘hang out’ with hot older women to have conversations, Kim. You know that.”

She jutted her chin at him. “Well,” she retorted, “men who are not having affairs don’t leave their wives in Florida for months at a time and send their ‘friends’ to take them out to dinner while their friends’ wives come over for drinks, do they? Or am I wrong? Maybe I’m wrong. Maybe that’s totally normal, totally normal not to mention it, either.” She pushed past him and went to the dresser.

Jessie tipped his head back in frustration. “Kim...” Ugh. He had no idea what to say because the argument had long ago ceased to make any sense to him. “I did not know that Michelle was going to be in Boston when I asked those guys to check up on you. You sounded... sad, or something, over the phone, and so I called Lenny and asked him – not *him*, but *them* – to come and get you and take you out. Okay?”

And then he added: “I had no idea that Len and Michelle were up to this shit!”

Kim had some earrings up to her ears. Her features were sharp like they were set in stone. And then, suddenly, she laughed.

The laugh had taken her by surprise, so she brought her hand to her face to cover it up.

Jessie laughed nervously; the moment was still tense and he wasn’t completely sure why she was laughing.

Kim set her face back in a glower. “You really had no idea?” she said, her voice dull. She sounded like she was giving up on something.

Jessie opened his arms again and let them fall. No, he hadn’t.

Kim picked up an earring. Now she was dressed in a blue shirt of thin fabric, again no bra, and her nipples were hard and round and perfectly outlined against the taut fabric. The jeans were slightly loose on her, but her ass had firmed up to a perfectly rounded and delectable sphere. Her hair was wild, drying into salty, sea-breeze waves. Jessie’s stomach clenched and his chest felt heavy. She was so beautiful, and he had been neglectful of her, and now he wanted to apologize for that but the conversation had taken too many wrong turns and there was no way to get it back to where he wanted it to go now.

“No,” he said, his voice also resigned.

Kim attached a second earring and gave herself a pouty look in the mirror.

She looked at him in the mirror. "I knew Len was coming alone before he got here," she said, her eyes getting wet again. "I don't know why I went out with him anyway. I think I'm mad at you. I thought you were having an affair. I don't know... maybe I still think that you are. And this neighbor guy, he's..." she waved a hand in the direction of the window, "I know he's attracted to me. I'm just flirting with him. I'm not *doing* anything." She sighed. "And I know it's wrong, it's all wrong, but..."

Her voice trailed off.

She turned around and scooped a light jacket off the back of a chair. "It was just nice to be noticed," she said.

Jessie shook his head. "Kim..."

What are you talking about? He wanted to yell. Of course he noticed her.

"Kim.... Kim. Look. This is all... crazy. I'm back here now because I don't want... I also want everything back like it was. Really."

They were silent, staring at each other for a moment. The heat between them was like an electrical charge: Jessie was infused with the same kind of passion he'd had for her the first time he looked at her. The moment he realized she was looking back at him the same way, like they were thinking the same thing. *This might be the one*, he remembered thinking. The cold excitement in his body felt almost exactly the same. The feeling of not knowing if he had her or not, if she might slip away.

Jessie stepped toward her, his chest fluttering because she continued to look at him, held by his gaze. He touched her lips. His cock was pulsing wildly in his pants as he used the fingertips of his right hand to very gently push her back against the wall. "But this is the first time I feel like it's possible." He whispered, very close to her mouth: "What about you?"

The seconds that it took for Kim to answer were painfully enjoyable. And maybe it was in that space of time that he had time to consider what he liked about the moment: the pain, feeling it, letting it linger in the air while Kim looked at him afraid and guilty, forced into a corner where she had to tell him a painful truth.

He moved his hand up to her neck, and brushed his thumb over the soft hollow of her throat. He brushed his lips over hers, and her body responded, melting into his. He knew she could feel his erection against her thigh. He leaned against her, trapping her against the wall, her body hot against his skin, as he unbuttoned the jeans she had worked so hard to get on.

Kim's palms were flat against the wall, and she didn't try to move them. He found her pussy with his fingertips, and it was wet. Not leftover wet: new, fresh arousal that had come from the very same source as his own.

"Hmmm?" he said, into her mouth, teasing her lips with his own. He barely knew what the question was anymore.

"I don't know," she breathed, her chest falling with the words, letting him sink further against her.

He bit gently into her lip and dipped his fingers into her pussy. She was so very hot and so very wet. He pushed as deep inside of her as he could and gently tightened his grip on her neck, not enough to choke her, or hurt her, just enough to let her know he meant business. Her pussy pulsed around his fingers.

She gasped as he curled his fingers deep inside of her, against the rough patch he knew to be her g-spot. Her thighs were starting to shake.

"Did you think about fucking Lenny? You can tell me."

Her pupils went wide, turning her eyes from glacial to navy blue as she gasped.

"Maybe," she breathed.

He smiled and pinched her clit against her own body with his thumb. Her eyelids grew heavy and her body began to shake: just with this simple suggestion and the lightest touch, he was going to get her to come all over his hand. Again. "Maybe," he growled, sliding his hand back to her hair and pulling on it until her face was tipped up at him. "Maybe not Lenny... then who else?"

She gasped loudly, and a small scream escaped her mouth just as her whole body shook violently. Her pussy spasmed around his fingers and her legs gave out, sending her sliding to the floor, leaning against the wall, her mouth open and her eyes squeezed shut. His hand slipped from inside of her as she fell, but he remained standing, unbuckling his pants, knowing where this was headed even though he couldn't believe it.

He had his cock – hard, dripping with precum, almost unbelievably given that they had already fucked twice what seemed like minutes earlier – in his hand and directed at her mouth. She fell forward onto her knees and took his shaft in her hand in one smooth motion. Her lips were still trembling with her orgasm as she brought the crown of his cock to her lips and smeared the precum over them.

Her eyes were on his, and he shuddered.

“Who would you fuck, Kim, if I said you could?” he repeated, watching in half-disbelief as his cock moved over her lips, as he felt her tongue roll over his cumhole and then dip into it. Her lips brushed over the ridge of his crown, and her hand tightened around his shaft, squeezing a pearly drop of cum from him that she licked up, eyes burning right into him the whole time.

“The guy from the gym,” she said. “Maybe him.”

So this was a real guy, Jessie thought, and his abdomen seized up in pain as his cock throbbed and Kim closed her hot mouth over him. He tipped his head back and looked at the ceiling as her mouth enclosed even more of him.

She stopped halfway down his shaft and released him slowly, letting go with a wet slurp. He looked down at her, and she stroked him languidly as she spoke, her hot breath on the tip of his cock and her lips brushing over him as she spoke. “If you told me I could, that’s who I’d fuck.”

Jessie made an incomprehensible sound.

“Why?”

She licked his cock before answering, turning her head to drag her tongue along the underside of him and then back up, making a lazy circle around the ridge before lapping up another drop of precum. Her eyes, which had been on his dick hungrily, floated back up to meet his gaze. “Because he’s a big,” she said, punctuation each pause with a wet lick against his shaft, “hot....muscly.... *black man*.” She blinked, her hand wrapped around his shaft. “And I’ve never had a black guy before.”

Her mouth was open, so it was no feat to grab her by the hair and push himself inside of her. He pushed his hips forward and pulled her head toward himself, expecting the usual resistance from her, but getting none. His cock slid all the way in, to the back of her throat. He felt her muscles spasm as she gagged, and he pulled his hips back slightly, but she grasped his buttocks and pushed him into her face.

From there, it was a quick affair: her mouth was hot and his cock was deep inside of it, he could feel her chin against his balls and hardly believe it was his own wife sucking his dick like this. From there, he had only to hear her voice in his head and picture her lips wrapped not around his own shaft, but a large purple-black cock, to send him violently over the edge.

He didn't have time to warn her, though he feebly tapped her head as the cum boiled from balls to his shaft.

But she responded not by jerking her head away: instead she dove in deep, sucking his cum from inside of him, and lifted her watering eyes to look at him as three spurts of his jizz crashed against the back of her throat and swirled around his cock between his shaft and her cheeks.

"Oh God," he said involuntarily, as his whole body jerked with the force of his orgasm. He had let go of her head, and his hand dropped to touch her, if only to steady himself.

Kim's tongue swirled around as she slowly backed away from his pelvis, and then finally released him – every drop of his cum licked clean and, evidently, swallowed.

He half-stumbled in a step backward, his hand reaching for his over-sensitive cock so it didn't flop and jar him into a coma.

"Holy shit," he said.

Kim was staring at him, and the mischievous expression in her eyes began to fade, diluted by a spaced-out expression of confusion.

She brought a hand to her lips, and touched them, as if she wasn't sure whose mouth had just sucked cum out of his cock, and swallowed it, after talking such filthy, unfaithful trash to her husband.

They looked at each other.

Jessie eventually pulled himself together, and stuffed his half-hard dick into his pants. Then he stepped back until he collapsed on the bed, still looking at Kim, who was touching her lips and looking at him.

"I think," he said breathlessly. "We need to talk."

CHAPTER 10

Kim poured them each a glass of wine, and set them on the counter, where they stayed, each of them looking at their own glass and neither moving to take a drink.

This felt like marriage therapy, she thought, except there was no arbitrator to break up the uneasy silence.

Jessie sighed, and rubbed his face. “This feels like therapy again,” he said.

Kim exhaled. There had been a lot of tension in her chest, and it felt good to let it out. She smiled at him. “Right? I was just thinking the same thing.”

Jessie seemed relieved that she was smiling, but there was a long silence and neither one of them seemed to know how to start.

“Okay,” he said. “I’ll go first.”

But he took a deep breath and then said nothing.

Kim picked up her glass.

She knew that she needed to just jump in, to tell Jessie the truth about everything – Len, their relationship, Hunter, the gym, her feelings, the fact that she had lied about her class, how much she wanted to go home... but it all seemed like too much to get out. Every time she tried to talk to him the conversation went in some awful direction, not where she intended it to go.

“What do we want?” Jessie said, his fingers spinning the wine glass lazily.

Kim set her glass down. Her mouth fell open slightly to indicate that she didn’t understand.

“That’s where we should start. Right?” Jessie said. “What do we want?”

Her stomach felt like he had put a knife through it. It was true, and she knew it, but she had been too afraid to confront it.

“You start with outcomes and you work backward from there,” Jessie began, as if he were giving a business school lecture. “You do the things you need to do to get to those outcomes and you don’t worry about anything _.”

Kim sighed. “It’s always business with you-”

“But it’s true,” Jessie said. He said it definitively, as though he had finally had enough of her complaints that he approached everything as though it were business.

Kim was mollified into silence.

“What do you want, Kim?” Jessie said quietly.

It was a simple enough question, and why *did* she have to shoot it down all the time? Their marriage therapist hadn’t really put it that way, that succinctly, but wasn’t it fair enough to ask?

She shook her head. “I’ve -” her voice was hoarse and she had to clear her throat. She was getting choked up by tears. “I’ve been too scared to ask *you* that,” she said.

Jessie was looking at her, his mouth thin and drawn. He narrowed his eyes. “What do *you* want?”

She shrugged. “I thought I knew,” she said. “I thought I wanted everything back the way it was... before we moved here. But now it seems... like we can’t get back there. And I think I have to decide what I want instead of that.”

Jessie leaned on his elbows and looked at the counter. “I want... something like what we had today. I want you to be interested in me again. I want to feel like you *want* me. I felt like that today.”

Kim blew at her hair. “Yeah, but...” she began. She was about to say something along the lines of: but you can’t have that at any cost, and it wasn’t real or honest. But she found that she didn’t feel like saying any of that. She wanted something like what she had today. She wanted to feel wanted again, to feel like her husband was actually paying attention to her. And that is what had happened. They were talking to each other, for once, about their marriage and what they wanted out of it. Wasn’t that a step in the right direction?

“Len and Michelle are swingers,” Kim found herself saying. “Did you know that?”

Jessie looked up at her. “I didn’t know it, before. But Michelle made it pretty clear.”

She played with her wine glass but didn’t drink from it.

“You know what I’ve wanted all this time?” she asked Jessie quietly, just as the idea formed in her own mind. “I wanted something like this, where we actually talked to each other about what we want. I just didn’t know that.”

Jessie nodded, smiling strangely and looking at his wine glass.

“Does it matter that we achieved it in a slightly unconventional way?” she continued.

Jessie looked at her sharply. “Are you saying... what *are* you saying?”

Kim shrugged, backpedaling a little bit. Maybe she had read Jessie wrong. “Just that... I don’t know. Maybe trying something different isn’t the worst idea. If, you know...oh, I don’t know!” She put her hands on her face.

That was a crazy suggestion, she realized. It was going to start an argument, and it was not going to work. “Forget I said anything,” she mumbled into her fingers, shaking her head.

She felt Jessie’s fingertips on her own, pulling at her hands. “Wait a minute,” he was saying. “I wasn’t trying to shut you down. I just...”

Her hands were off her face and she could tell that her cheeks had flushed. She looked at Jessie sheepishly. He looked... sincere.

“So, I’m not going to lie to you,” he said. “When Michelle came to see me, she was... I don’t know. Pretty... flirty. *Very* flirty.”

Kim felt a new heat spreading over her neck, and her mouth started to open when Jessie put up a finger to stop her. “But! But, but, but,” he preemptively interrupted her, “I didn’t bite. And I realize now, I don’t even want to. But Michelle got to talking, after she saw she wasn’t going to seduce me, and we had a pretty frank conversation about those guys, and their relationship. And I think I get it now.”

Kim had no response to this. Jessie was looking up at the ceiling, thinking of a way to formulate his thoughts.

Kim’s stomach was in knots. “Is it that you-”

Jessie held up a finger. Then he thought some more. Then, finally, he brought his eyes to meet hers. “Okay, so... I don’t know how to explain, it okay? But I just remembered... You know how Len was telling you one time about why he gets tattoos?”

Kim was surprised, because Jessie typically had the episodic memory of a fruit fly. She remembered things very well, especially conversations, and especially conversations with someone like Len. She scrunched her eyes up anyway, and said, “I think so.”

“You remember how he said he hates pain, and we all thought that was surprising because, you know – he’s Len. But he gets his tattoos to face pain, in a situation where he can control it. Sort of. And the same thing for

his crazy sports and stuff like that. He's just doing all of that stuff to face his fears."

For a moment, Kim couldn't put it together, and she stared at Jessie blankly.

Then it started to make sense. Kind of.

"Uh-huh," she said slowly.

Then she opened her eyes wide and looked at Jessie. "So what, exactly, are we talking about here?"

Jessie took her hands in his. "Look. I don't know. It seems crazy, I know. But today, when I saw you with that neighbor guy, and when I saw your missing wedding ring, it was terrifying, right? And I felt terrible. But I also felt... not *good*, you know, but thrilled. And... that may seem weird to you, but you can't lie about being very, very turned on by it. Whatever it was."

She was shaking her head, turning to the side, contorting her features into a face of denial. "No, no, no," she said. "That can't lead to anything good. That *can't* be it."

Jessie brought her hands to his mouth. "Really? Why not?"

She faced him again. He was kissing her fingers, distracting her. She felt a flutter in her stomach, excitement in her lower abdomen. She would have denied it outright, but she was getting turned on. She expelled a sigh of impatience, as though Jessie were playing dirty.

But was he?

"Because that's just not -!" she began.

"Not what? Not what's normal? Not what your parents tell you to do?" Jessie prompted. He kissed her pinkie sensually along the side. "But it *worked*..." he breathed. "We're here talking, we just had really hot sex three times in a row, I'm going to take you out to dinner..."

Kim shook her head, but she was smiling. She needed to mount some kind of defense. "It was all just fake, though," she said, finally. "None of that ever really... you know. Got to the point where..."

She didn't want to finish the sentence. Jessie was kissing her hands now, and he pulled one away from his grasp to guide it to his hard cock. The feel of his dick, steely and ready, sent a jolt of excitement through her.

"It could be real," he said. "Come on. Think about it... you wouldn't mind having a free pass, to let that hot chunk of man-meat fuck you on the beach, would you? You could even let him work for it, let him think you're

just a hot married woman whose husband doesn't appreciate what he has, but you're so faithful..." he stroked her lower lip with his thumb, "that you would never, ever do anything naughty like that. And then, when you finally gave in, it turns out you're a *really, really* naughty girl."

Kim was going to resist him, but halfway through his speech, the desire to play along overtook her. She stood up, sliding the panties she'd put on under her black sundress down to her feet and stepping out of them.

It was a game, she told herself.

CHAPTER 11

Kim looked down at the neighbor's house, where Hunter was stretched out on the deck in a lounger, shirt off, skin glistening.

She thought about snapping a picture of him and sending it to Jessie: should I, or shouldn't I?

But it seemed strange as soon as she thought of it. She laughed lightly into the curtain. Is that what Jessie wanted, really?

What she couldn't understand about it was that *she* didn't want Jessie to do anything like that. It made it hard to envision how Jessie would actually want her to sleep with another guy. And yet... she regarded the bumpy flesh of Hunter's abdomen, remembered the thrill of flirting with him, considered her daydreams of crossing the line with him. It was all thrilling *because* it was wrong.

No Len.

That was *her* rule, she reminded herself. No Len, and no Michelle. No friends they had any intention of seeing ever again. It just seemed too... real... that way.

They had hashed out their rules at the restaurant: slowly at first, then more quickly as they got drunk. Kim had never been sure if Jessie was serious. She asked him again and again, and he said, "I think so," or "Yes, if you are."

But that never really made her sure of anything. And so she had decided that she would test the waters by pretending to sleep with Hunter. Maybe flirting, getting closer, even crossing some kind of line. But nothing permanent, nothing real... nothing intractable.

In case Jessie wasn't as serious as he thought, or he said he was.

She stared at Hunter.

Why was she thinking of Len?

She walked to the part of the wall where she couldn't be seen from outside, not in the mirror or through the window, no matter what the lighting was. She wanted to talk to Len, and she was doing a pretty good job of telling herself it was only because she wanted to pick his brain about this arrangement. She wanted to hear from him personally how it worked for him. All in the name of making sure it was the right thing to do.

She typed a message to him and deleted it, and retyped it again, over and over, hating the vibe each message was sending. Her abdomen felt like it was full of butterflies, but instead of hating the feeling, she tried to embrace it.

*Hey. I need to pick your brain about something.
Want to do dinner tonight? I have to ask you a question
Can you come over I want to run something by you?*

She laughed at herself as she typed:

I'm thinking of fucking that neighbor boy and need your advice.

She deleted it. Then she typed it again, just to see how silly it looked on a screen.

And then, although she could never be sure what part accident and what part devious purposefulness occurred – her thumb slipped as she waved the screen thoughtfully, and the message was sent.

That message.

I'm thinking of fucking that neighbor boy and need your advice.

The cold feeling spread out to her limbs, and she was sure her heart stopped.

But now, she looked at it a different way. It was almost *fun* to feel like that. It made her feel a little bit high.

She set the phone on the dresser and stepped out into the part of the room where she knew, if the lighting was right and the onlooker were in the exact right place, she could be seen changing her clothes. Without worrying about whether these things were true or not, or looking back at Hunter, or even thinking much more about it, she pulled off her nightie and stood in front of the mirror, admiring herself.

And then, very slowly, she walked into the closet, and brought out several choices of clothes.

She didn't look out the window to see if she had caught his attention – it didn't matter if she had or not. It was as if she could feel him looking at her. Her bold text to Len had made her pulse race and now doing this:

standing – posing, really – at the foot of her bed, swaying slightly as the sea breezes caressed her skin – this was making her feel ecstatic. Her nipples hardened, and it wasn't so much the breeze that had done it – it was the feeling that Hunter's gaze was on her body, unable to look away, sneaking a peek at her lithe, pretty figure.

And thinking about how much he'd like to bury his cock inside of her.

The phone buzzed with a new message. She languidly walked to pick it up from the dresser, and read Len's message.

bored again? Okay, I can take you out.

She smiled. He thought it was a joke.

Was it? Was she actually going to do something like that?

And why was she muddying the waters with a text to Len?

She held the phone up and posed for a selfie. She was standing where she could be seen from below, and she angled the phone so that, if a person were looking for him, they could see Hunter in the background. She turned the phone and twisted around until she managed to get the open window, a sliver of her bare bottom in a reflection from the mirror in the corner where the two sets of windows met, and her bare skin down to just above her nipples. This had only her mouth in the frame, but that was fine. She snapped the picture and inspected it in her gallery.

Then she sent it to Jessie.

She waited.

No message.

And as she stood there, heart racing, wondering if Jessie would see all the details in the photo – the blur in the sand that was Hunter, the reflection that proved she was naked – if he would piece it all together – she got another, fun, naughty idea.

It would probably be a long time, anyway, until Jessie got back to her. Jessie, always busy, Jessie, who had to return as early as he had come because of business, as usual...

So why not?

She sent the picture to Len.

But as she was doing that, to her surprise and delight, Jessie had gotten back to her.

Jessie *never* got back to her within a minute. She always had to wait. She stretched out on the bed, taking her time to crawl onto it, just in case Hunter was watching, and opened her husband's message.

this is hot

She tapped the phone against her lower lip, smiling. Her phone buzzed again.

I'm in a board meeting

She smiled again, picturing Jessie tapping on his phone, looking at pictures from her, instead of having his attention fixed on the dreary meeting.

She felt a tantalizing, foreign thrill inside of her, right in the center of her body. If she had ever had more of it, she would have recognized that she was feeling powerful. Already having forgotten that she had sent a photo to Len – almost having forgotten Len entirely – she rose up onto her knees and rested on her heels.

Her back, and her bare ass perched on her heels, was about three feet from the open sliding door to the small balcony. If the curtains had blown in at that moment the curtains could have reached her, like an opaque tentacle. But if Hunter's eyes were open behind those sunglasses, he could not miss her, even if she had dimmed in the interior light of the room.

She stretched her torso, lifted her breasts, and adjusted the phone so that most of her body – her hard nipples, a hint of her neatly trimmed pussy, her thighs spread slightly apart – and in the background, Hunter on his lounge chair, status of eyes unknown, were visible in the picture.

Smiling, she tipped forward again, onto her elbows, leaving her ass in the air, her back arched down. She had just been doing a little dance for Hunter's benefit, if he was there – but as she plopped down, she held the phone and liked the view – sky in the background, the two rounded hills of her ass behind her head, Hunter's view implied.

She took another one. And she sent it to Jessie as well.

His message came back almost instantaneously – maybe it was only in response to the second photo.

you've got to stop

And then:

oh god

She chewed on her finger and smiled, imagining her husband in the board room, his cock getting harder and harder, his mind on her instead of business. Jessie, distracted. Jessie, thinking of her.

Her phone buzzed in her hand again.

It's a date

She was confused for a moment, and then her eyes traveled up to the conversation preceding the text.

Len's conversation.

Len.

Not Jessie.

Almost as suddenly as she had spiraled up to a high, everything came crashing down around her. Hard. Her hands shook as she sat against the headboard of the bed, pulling a sheet up around the nakedness she was as acutely aware of as she had been blissfully enjoying just a moment before.

It's a date.

Her heart was pounding.

Had she really meant to do that? Was that really what she wanted? What *had* she been thinking when she sent those photos to Len?

Her mind swirled with thoughts of Len arriving at her house, expecting that she would actually go through with it. It went beyond teasing, now it was real.

She racked her brains thinking of what exactly she had said to Jessie. No Michelle? That she didn't really want to involve Len and Michelle? Had she specified, "No Len or Michelle" for sex, or had it been, "no Len and Michelle in our business?"

Was this over the line she herself had drawn?

"Shit," she said aloud.

Just moments ago it had all seemed like fun, something she could pull back from at the last minute. She realized she hadn't made up her mind to

do anything, she hadn't even really thought about the consequences.

And why not? What had she thought would happen, if she teased Hunter, if she baited Len? She had been envisioning flirting with her black friend at the gym... but had she ever really imagined going all the way?

Her stomach felt cold. She wanted to take it back, but it was too late.

She re-read her messages to Len. It was clear, wasn't it, that she had meant the 'neighbor boy' and not him? But what if he thought something else? What if he saw this as an invite to sleep with him?

She felt, very suddenly, in way over her head.

And she had no one but herself to blame for that.

She started to type a message to Len, and had the words

I only need advice, just so we're clear

typed on her phone, when she stopped and deleted her message.

She chewed on her lip, and stared at the wall.

What had she done?

CHAPTER 12

It was a bad way to start something that was supposed to be fun, and she was already breaking the rules about honesty. Kim paced in the kitchen, covered up by a silky black robe and nothing else. Her stomach was in knots, and she didn't want to admit to herself that they were tantalizing pangs of desire. Her chest felt like something was standing on it, she felt mildly nauseous, and she felt guilty about what she'd done.

But not guilty enough to come clean about it.

After the cold that had gripped her from head to foot had worn off, she had hastily typed a message to Jessie.

A lie, which she felt terrible about.

But it was a white lie, wasn't it? It was a lie in the sense that it didn't reveal her intentions, but not a lie in the sense that it *could have been* what actually happened.

Shit. I accidentally sent that photo to Len

Jessie had taken a long time to reply to that one. Was it because he was angry? Or because he was busy? What had he felt when he received her text? She waited, and waited, and finally went to the kitchen to get herself a glass of wine.

Hunter had gone inside, so she could only guess about whether or not he had seen her. It was always possible, she thought from time to time, that he hadn't seen anything, and all of this could be undone with a simple string of lies: Len, I didn't mean to send you that photo.

Shit. Len. If she was going to lie, she had to lie properly, which meant Len had to think it was an accident, too. Angry with herself for completely ignoring this detail, she typed a message to him, and stared at it accusingly before she sent it.

If that had really been a mistake, she would have said so half an hour ago, right when she got Len's text. Len was not going to believe any of this, which meant Jessie wouldn't either.

She sipped her wine, and held down the delete button.

Her stomach felt like it did when she was on a roller coaster. Even more horribly, she almost liked the feeling.

One lie. One lie led to another.

Or did it? She had to get this all back under control. She was really fucking this up, and she was only a baby step into it. This was not for her.

It felt like an out-of-body experience, then, as she leaned on the counter in her silk robe, the folds open and showing her bare chest to anyone who might have wandered by her window cutting out to the beach, and typed:

are you getting my texts?

To Len.

It was sent before she could take it back.

What was the plan? The plan was to pretend that she had sent him a message, telling him that the photo was an accident. Hope you enjoyed it, but that's not what I intended. And then wait for Jessie to acknowledge her mistake, and tell her what to do about it.

She grimaced and rubbed her forehead. It was a convoluted plan, and she had a sense that something about it wouldn't work, and an even deeper sense that she should probably extract herself from this entire situation before it got out of hand. It was a terrible idea, and it was stuff like this, precisely, that made it a terrible idea. She wasn't even committed to any of it, and she was going to be in over her head.

The idea had been to pretend, she reminded herself. She had been planning to pretend that she'd slept with Hunter, and see how Jessie reacted. Somehow, in the space of a few minutes, she had gone way over the line – her own line – and she felt out of control.

The worst part, she thought, as she stared at her silent phone and slammed some more wine, was that she knew she could just shut the whole thing down if she wanted to. Tell Jessie she couldn't go through with it, pack a suitcase, go to Boston tonight.

That's all she had to do.

But something made her stay there in the kitchen, waiting for her husband and Len to write back to her.

Len was first.

????? I got the one. Are there more?

Kim inhaled. Good. According to plan.

Did you get the one about how I did that by mistake?

She looked at her text and added a second one.

the photo

She set the phone down and rolled her eyes. They were in one of the most densely populated places on earth. Text messages did not just get lost in 2019. It was a trope from the turn of the century, for fuck's sake – about as believable as saying a dog ate your homework.

But she was in it now, and she couldn't back out.

I see. You should be more careful Kim

Kim's stomach flipped. Len obviously couldn't possibly believe her, but he had done a very tidy trick of keeping the door open. She was now in limbo, wondering if he was still coming over to "give advice." Did the mistake of the photo negate their "date?"

Did she want it to?

She crouched on a stool, drinking, feeling like a teenager. She had one eye on the fence between Hunter's yard and hers, as though she would see through it whether or not he had seen her, if his interest had been piqued, and by how much...

She pushed her hair from her face. This was already crazy.

The phone buzzed with a text alert, distracting her. She grabbed it, giddy. It was Jessie.

How did that happen?

Kim set the phone down. One lie, so far. She had told Jessie one lie that no one could ever, ever *prove* was a lie. If she wrote to him now, did it make it another lie, or was this just part of the same thing?

It *could* be true, she thought. In a way, it was true, because she had realized it was a mistake as soon as she sent it. In fact, she reassured

herself, picking up steam for making excuses as only the very guilty can do, calling it a “mistake” was not entirely untruthful. If Jessie thought it meant one thing, and she had actually meant it in a different sense... well, that couldn't be helped, could it?

He didn't have to know that she had sent it to Len on purpose, but then decided it was a mistake afterward.

She was the only one who actually knew that.

She typed.

just got mixed up

How?

Kim rubbed her head. She hadn't really expected Jessie to grill her on it, though now that seemed naive. How *had* she gotten mixed up?

I have no idea.

She had started to type more – I have no idea, you know how sometimes you have a recent call and you text one person and then you hit the wrong name, etc., etc..

But she remembered something from a movie, some action film she had watched a long time ago with Jessie, about spies: don't explain too much or it's obvious you're lying.

She sent the simple text.

And waited.

I thought we said no friends

We did, that's why I'm telling you, it was a mistake

What should I do

And waited.

What was his reaction?

Kim stared at the screen. She bit her thumbnail. What should she write? The truth? If she did, she would have to explain why Len was

(possibly) coming over tonight, why she hadn't sorted that particular detail...

If she didn't, she was digging herself into even more lies.

Nothing. He didn't say anything and then I sent him a text saying it was a mistake and he didn't answer, and so I was like, are you getting my texts, and he said I should be more careful

There was a really long pause, while her stomach twisted and cramped, and her heart felt like it was soaring and then crashing into the ground. Could Jessie see between the line of her texts? Did he know that she was lying? Was he staring at his phone and hating her?

She felt, very suddenly, absolutely terrible about lying to Jessie. What a stupid lie, and why? Why had she sent a photo to Len? She couldn't even answer that question for herself.

When her phone buzzed and gave a faint ping, her heart leaped and she almost shook as she opened Jessie's message.

Be more careful. Did it seem seedy how he said it?

Kim found herself smiling. Maybe she was relieved: Jessie was not mad, at least.

She forwarded a screenshot to him.

There was another very long pause, and her heart was racing as she sat there, still as stone, waiting for his next text.

Len's not that good of a friend. Just so you know.

Kim had an overwhelming feeling, probably a lot like someone who is let go by their tandem skydiving instructor for the first time. She was exhilarated, but very suddenly totally terrified.

She was pretty sure that she didn't want this.

The freedom of it – if this was what Jessie was saying, was too much.

But even as she felt the wild fright of freedom, she found herself smiling, and typing.

are you telling me you wouldn't mind if I slept with Len?

Was it a joke? Was it just teasing? She was sure that it was, and sure that it wasn't.

*I'm telling you the rule I stand firm on
is the one about you telling me everything
which you seem to be doing*

Kim stared at the words, uncertain of her true feelings.

Meh. She wasn't going to actually sleep with Len.

If anything, she could pretend, just like she had planned to pretend with Hunter.

Suddenly she had a wave of guilt, about her little half-lie.

Still... a lie was a lie.

It wasn't the way to start something like this, something that was about trust. She stared at Jessie's words: *Which you seem to be doing*.

She rolled onto her back and held the phone above her.

There was no way for anyone, anyone but her, to know that she had sent her picture to Len on purpose. It would be silly to tell on herself, because there was no way for the truth to ever come out. Ever. It wasn't like she had lied about an action – just about her own private thoughts.

Her fingers hovered over her screen, her stomach twisting in knots.

Everyone is entitled to their own private thoughts, she thought. She had promised to tell Jessie everything, but everything was only applicable to what she *did*.

And she *had* told him that she had sent the photo.

But *everything* included *everything*, didn't it?

The sensation in her abdomen was wrenching, and it took her a while to realize what it was.

It was a thrill – the kind of naughty, hand-shaking inducing thrill she had felt the one time she had stolen something in a department store. The thrill of doing something just a little bit wrong.

She'd pocketed a cheap piece of jewelry some years ago, and to this day she couldn't explain why she'd done it. And just like now, she'd told Jessie about it, and just like now, she'd left out an important detail. The jewelry had, just as she'd told Jessie, fallen into her bag accidentally. No

one but her could have known that she saw it fall, and that she had decided to just walk out of the store without saying anything.

Just like with the jewelry, what difference did it make? The piece had been stolen, and whether she had done it accidentally or on purpose, the result was the same. She could have returned it, and she didn't, because Jessie had told her not to bother.

And so then – as in now, she reasoned – her intent had no effect on what had actually happened. She was the only one who knew about it, and the end result was the same.

She rolled over on the bed, flat on her stomach.

Really? She typed.

It was a long wait, while her heart raced and her abdomen went hot and cold.

Jessie's answer materialized on her screen.

*Just let it play out however it plays out. Just
tell me about it when it does.*

CHAPTER 13

Letting things “play out” was harder to do than she initially imagined. She had a high, and she wanted to keep it going.

She decided to go to the gym, to work off her wild energy. She hoped to see her Mystery Black Man there, if she was being honest – but, she thought smiling, she didn’t have to be entirely honest about that. What was she supposed to do? Sit inside all day and wait for Hunter to come home so she could throw herself shamelessly at him on the beach? Or stare at her phone, hoping Len would get in touch with her again?

“Anyway,” she said to herself solemnly, gripping the steering wheel. “I don’t plan to actually *do* any of this.”

It was all just teasing.

No one had to know that she had stopped by an expensive sports store to buy a new workout outfit. That she had tried on a ton of them and settled on a sports bra and running shorts set that was blue, tiny, clingy, and just the sort of thing she’d made fun of other women for wearing because it was so obviously designed for appearances and not comfort.

She did not need to tell anyone that she had been extra careful to shave her legs and trim her bush, because she had intended to buy something just like that and she wanted to look good in it.

And she didn’t have to tell anyone that she had carefully arranged her hair in a sort of cascading loose bun (as opposed to a sensible pony-tail) because it looked much more appealing. Or that, going against the very professed moral fiber of her being, she had applied just a tad of makeup – a sweep of foundation, some lip stain, a hint of reflecting blush on her cheekbones, nothing slutty – in order to look un-made-up but fabulous as she ran on the treadmill.

All in the hope of... what? Seeing Mystery Man and asking him if he wanted to fuck?

She dressed in the locker room and waited for the two much younger girls in the room to clear out so that she could admire herself in peace, and unobserved. She caught herself making a pouty-lipped face at the mirror and started laughing.

Man.

She was really losing it.

She headed to the treadmill with her skin tingling, though, and the topsy-turvy sensation in her stomach fiercer than ever.

She ran for about a mile and he hadn't appeared. She thought of excuses for a while, and then, as her run wore her down into a trance-like state, decided it was for the best that he wasn't there and even started to laugh inwardly at herself for being so foolish. Around mile two, everything seemed incredibly foolish and she was shaking her head at herself slightly and running faster than usual. She wasn't going to do any of these things, anyway. Jessie had given her permission to flirt, but that was all she planned to do, and now that she had permission for it, flirting seemed like a low-grade, uninteresting thing to do.

She had settled into her run, with the intention of running five miles, and her eyes were focused on the program on the screen. She was running on a "hilly course" and the hills had become steep and long, so she was focused on dividing the run into manageable goals to pass the time. So she didn't notice him come in.

When she looked up, it was on a flat stretch in her program, and she was already so deep in the workout that she could look up and space out in front of her while running at a good clip.

He was seated on a bench behind her, lifting an enormous weight with his usual friend, who was talking to him. Kim could see that by the movement of his head.

But Mystery Black Man was not looking at his friend as he spoke. His strangely light eyes were very clearly, very unwaveringly, focused on *her*.

His stare sent an electric shudder through her. She was grateful, as the wave of heat that radiated from her core and overtook her limbs, that she didn't trip. She was too far into the run for a shock like that to make her feet stumble, but it was a close call.

The knife of searing cold sliced through her abdomen.

She had a heart rate monitor on and it spiked, the little gray heart on the screen blinking rapidly, telling her she was way, way, outside her goal of 150 beats per minute.

Her face felt hot, but she was already sweaty and reddish from the workout, which was another thing to be grateful for. She looked down at the program, and turned up the intensity, focusing all of her attention on the run, and the monitors.

Her face got even hotter. He had seen her look down and away. He would know that he had unnerved her, and with a guy like that, it was hard to believe he didn't know why.

When she looked up again, he was gone, and she felt relief but also intense disappointment. She had worked herself up to facing him, had even daydreamed that she spoke to him and he turned out to be married, or gay, or unappealing somehow. The daydreams relaxed her, taking him down to a level that she felt she could handle.

And now he was gone.

She tossed her towel over her shoulder. She had run right to the end of the program and then twenty minutes longer to avoid speaking to Mystery Man, and now she was tired *and* disappointed.

She headed to the locker room, wiping sweat from her neck and thinking about how silly she was, looking down at the floor, lost in her own thoughts. A weight machine slammed and she turned to look at the sound...

and walked right into him.

She knew it was him, as surprised as she was, because of his size. Because that was the kind of brutal luck she would have, because it just seemed preordained, now that it had happened. His chest was solid and his muscles curved against her cheeks, like warm polished stone. She collided gently against his chest because he had encircled her forearms with his hands and slowed her, and her cheek just brushed his chest and then he drew her back. The force of his arms was gentle, but inescapable.

"Oh my God!" she stammered, and was about to say something else but was silenced by his calm, dominating gaze, and the slight smile of his mouth.

His hands were still around her forearms, and he released them, slowly, and seconds later than anyone would have done if they only meant to stop someone running into them. It was a deliberate, erotic move, and Kim felt herself turned upside down again.

"I'm so sorry," she said.

"This ain't no treadmill," he said warmly. "Gotta look where you're goin'."

Kim was out of practice, she realized suddenly, with flirting. In fact, she was out of practice and out of her league, and hadn't ever been good at it anyway.

This, she decided, was stupid. She brushed a strand of her hair from her face and blew on her bangs at the same time. Then, giving up entirely on her plans to entice Mystery Man, she shook her head and laughed. "Classic," she muttered. "I really am sorry."

It was not something, she was telling herself, she was ever seriously going to do anyway. With each passing second it seemed more ridiculous. Had she actually been thinking of seducing a total stranger and fucking him, and then telling her husband about it? And a huge, stacked *black* guy?

"You could make up for it," he said.

She was stunned, again, into a liquid, erotic turmoil.

"Buy me a drink."

Kim's eyes went wide, her imagination went crazy.

He pointed at the vending machine, full of Gatorade and other sports drinks.

Kim laughed. Stupidly, she thought. She had no way of knowing that she was glistening with sweat, her cheeks flushed, her eyes lit up, or that she looked a bit like her mystery man enjoyed seeing women after he fucked them. "Uh, I'll have to take a raincheck on that," she said. "I don't have any cash."

"You're running into people and you don't have any cash," he said seriously, and her heart plunged until she realized he was joking. He smiled. "Raincheck it is," he said. "Friday?"

The question lingered in the air for a few moments, and Kim's chest felt hollowed out, like her heart was racing through the air alone. Her eyes went everywhere she didn't want them to: to his biceps, his mouth, his chest, and then his startlingly light eyes. Friday.

"Okay," she said, smiling, impressed even with herself by her beguiling expression. "Friday it is. I'll be ready."

They smiled at each other. She stepped around him. He leaned toward her, and his hand traveled to her forearm again and brushed over her skin until he caught her right hand. "I'm Jay," he said.

She shook her head and wiped her brow with her left hand. "God. Sorry. Where are my manners...? Kim."

His fingers closed a little tighter around hers, and the sensation was as erotic as anything she'd felt in a long, long time. "You don't look like a Kim," he said.

The conversation had shifted suddenly, from innocuous to implicitly sexual, and Kim had no idea how it had happened. She surprised herself, though, by slipping into the persona she had brought out, occasionally, for Hunter, for Len, for her husband, and now for Jay.

“Some people call me Jade.”

“Some people, huh? Which people?”

She shrugged, and let her eyes drop slightly. “Some people,” she said mysteriously.

“Mmm,” he said.

She felt slightly out of control. She took her hand back, and he released it with the same deliberate, slow, sexuality that he had her forearms.

“See you Friday, then?” she said, as cutely as possible.

“Suits you better. Jade. Can I call you that?”

She lifted her chin and cocked her head, scarcely able to believe herself. “Maybe.”

This amused him, and interested him, and she could see it.

And she liked it.

She spun quickly, before she ruined the moment by saying something stupid, and sauntered away to the bathroom.

She saw him again when she was in her car, wondering what to type to Jessie.

And so, pretending to take a selfie, she snapped a picture of him getting into his truck.

She sent it to Jessie.

I finally flirted with him.

She would drag this out a little.

Of course, she wasn't going to actually *do* anything with him.

She'd see how Jessie reacted. Maybe give him a wild ride, tell him a story.

See how he took it. It was a good plan, just to make sure this was what he actually wanted.

She brought her thumb to her mouth and gently bit her nail, fantasizing about what it would be like to do more than tease. Jay's hands still felt like they burned on her forearms.

CHAPTER 14

Friday.

She had gotten dressed-up again to go to the gym, and made sure to put cash in her bag to make sure she could buy Jay a “drink.” She had talked to Jessie on Wednesday, telling him about her encounter with Jay, down to almost every last detail, including her use of her middle name.

Jessie had been breathless on the phone, asking for more and more detail, encouraging her to go to the gym and tell him everything.

“You really want me to do this?” she had asked him.

“If it’s what you want to do,” he had replied, his voice shaking.

She drove halfway there, her intentions being to flirt with Jay and nothing more. Excitement had built up inside of her until she was shaking.

And then... it just seemed all too real. Anything could happen with a man like Jay, a man with that kind of raw, brute strength. A man who seemed to be the same age as her, over whom she really didn’t have any... well, leverage. He wasn’t like Hunter, who was young and seemed almost scared of her.

A bad feeling started to shake her in a different way. It was too dangerous, too preposterous, too unconventional to even think about. She turned around and went home, feeling regret but better and better about her decision as she neared her house.

If she was going to do anything with anyone, it needed to be a softball. Someone like Hunter, someone less... frightening. Someone she had more control over.

She sat in her car with the air conditioning on, not wanting to really decide one way or the other. She didn’t want Jay to lose interest in her, and maybe she was missing her chance with him.

But she didn’t really want to go there. Not yet.

It was all too much – too many possibilities, too many confusing conversations with her husband and Hunter and Len and Jay. She was overwhelmed.

She decided on a way to keep Jessie on the hook, to delay everything and fulfill her plans to test the waters with him. She typed him a message,

her mind whirling, and then decided that the best thing for her to do was lock herself up in her house and wait to see how Jessie reacted.

That's it. Test the waters, send Jessie cryptic texts, tell him a story, and see how he reacted to his wife telling him she had slept with a stranger.

After that, when she knew what he really thought, she would see whether it was something she would really do.

She would send it to him later, just a teaser. Something simple, that would lead him on but not actually be a lie. *Tonight's the night*, she would write.

And wait.

Jessie, mysteriously, didn't get back to her.

She poured herself a few wines and paced the house, checking her phone, peering at Hunter's house, where it seemed quiet. She thought of Len and Michelle, and began to harvest some paranoid thoughts about those two. Hours passed, and no word from Jessie.

She supposed, in a drunken haze around six or so, that this settled it: if Jessie had nothing to say to her after a text like that, if it didn't get him jumping to pay attention to her, then it was probably because he didn't want this after all.

She had made the right decision. Disappointment and relief, now two sides of the same coin in this strange new era of her life, twisted inside of her. "Oh well," she said, pouring herself another drink and ruminating on how silly all of this had been.

You could bet, she thought sullenly, that Michelle and Len were actually ruining their marriage with these shenanigans. She wished she had never found out about this, wished she could make it all go away. Then, feeling pretty drunk, looking morosely over at Hunter's house, she wished she'd had the balls to go to the gym.

Jessie, after all, was the one who had pushed all of this. It had been his idea.

Or Len's. Or Michelle's. She didn't know anymore. Was it her idea? What was she doing?

In the midst of these bleak thoughts, the doorbell rang, startling her to freeze with her drink in mid-air.

It rang again.

She walked to the door and opened it, expecting maybe Jessie, who had come to rescue her or put an end to her plans. Or a delivery man, even though it was late. Maybe Hunter, asking her if she wanted to come over.

Nothing prepared her to open the door and see Len standing on the porch.

He was wearing a gray t-shirt and a pair of jeans. His usual attire, but for some reason it looked more sinister than usual. His tattoos were particularly prominent. He had a smattering of day-old stubble on his jaw, and Kim stared at it as a completely inappropriate thought went through her mind. Before she even had time to wonder what Len was doing on her porch, she thought about how stubble like that would feel against the spread lips of her pussy as his tongue went in for her clit.

Len did not give her time to do much except register surprise on her face. He had two bottles grasped in one of his hands, and he started to walk into the house in such a way that Kim was moving out of his way before he even said hello.

He walked into the foyer and took a look around.

“Uh... Len,” Kim said, trying hard not to let her breath shake with the tremble that suddenly overtook her chest. Len’s shoulders were broad and the shirt clung to his back, showing off the defined muscles near his shoulder blade. “I didn’t know -”

“You didn’t know I was coming over,” Len said, in an almost sing-song voice. He turned and looked at her. “Another mistake?” he said, waving his phone from side to side in his hand. The screen was facing her, but it was off.

Kim made a face and shook her head as she leaned away from the phone. “What are you talking about?” she asked him, genuinely confused.

Len smiled. “Tonight’s the night, Kimmy, that’s what I’m talking about. He flipped the phone back to face him by giving it a very precise toss, like an omelet, that left it face-up in his hand. “I think tonight is the night,” he read off in a girlish voice.

He flipped the phone again. She folded her arms, which seemed to make Len amused.

A cold, horrible feeling was sliding down her spine as the realization of what she’d done entered her consciousness, bit by bit. She had not sent her cryptic text to Jessie after all, but to Len.

To Len.

Why? How could she have possibly been so stupid? Was she this careless, or did something in her subconscious make her do it? You could bet, she thought bitterly, that's what Len thought.

It's what she would think, too, if the tables were turned.

Her eyes were getting hot and wet. What had she done that for? Was it a mistake? Really? Or had she done it on some semi-conscious level? It at least explained why Jessie hadn't gotten back to her, which changed and ruined everything, infused everything with a new light... her head spun.

Len took one of the bottles from his right hand with his left, and spread his arms out, indicating the entire scene before him. "This?" he said incredulously. "This is *it*?"

Kim snatched the bottle nearest her, annoyed to see that it was tequila. Then she marched into the kitchen without looking behind her. Her cheeks burned as Len followed her, saying, "I have to tell you, Kim, it's getting harder and harder to believe that you're so bad at using a smartphone."

She set the tequila down. The heat of embarrassment that had been creeping up her neck made a sudden change: she felt, instead, the sinister thrill she had been feeling lately.

She looked at the tequila, frowned, and started to open it before she looked at Len. She shrugged. "So what brings you by, Len?"

Len dropped into a stool by stepping over it and dropping down with his legs apart. He was rubbing his hands together. "You know, Kim, I really didn't think you'd turn into one of *these* kinds."

It was fun, she realized just then. Playing a part, acting like this. She pursed her lips. "This kind of *what*, Len?"

She wasn't going to let Len get the better of her, be this condescending toward her. She would play it off, and he could fuck off. She couldn't have him thinking that he occupied even the tiniest bit of her imagination. Because he *didn't*.

He just smiled. "Can I have a glass, please?"

Kim bristled, but tried to suppress her reaction. It was pretty clear that Len was getting off on driving her nuts, and she didn't feel like giving him the upper hand. She strode to the cupboard and took out two glasses.

Len poured himself some of the clear bottle he'd brought, and Kim did the same. He drank it before speaking. "So," he said, rubbing his hands together. "Tonight's the night, huh? With the boy-child? What's the plan, Kim? You're changing outfits, I assume?"

Kim raised her eyebrows. She felt a deep disgust at Len right then, but she was also weirdly attracted to him. It was an intensification of the way she'd always felt about him, she realized. Only now, she really did stand a chance of bringing it back under her own control.

She took a sip of the clear liquid – a strangely flavored vodka. “Who says I’m wearing an outfit?” she retorted. Then she squinted at the vodka. “God. What is this?”

“Some hipster flavor,” Len said without missing a beat, his eyes still on hers like a hungry wolf. “It’s not very good. That’s why I brought some tequila. I thought maybe I’d make you one of my specialty margaritas.”

She swirled a finger in the glass and brought it to her mouth. She was pleased to see how Len watched her, his attention captured completely. She sucked the cold vodka from her fingertip and made sure to make a sucking noise. “But I have a date,” she cooed innocently.

Len brought the glass to his lips. “No shit,” he said, as though she had just confided an unbelievable secret to him. “Well, in that case, I’ll make myself some margaritas.”

She smiled at him, trying to exude confidence, but feeling like she might be failing.

“You can’t.. *stay* here, Len,” she said finally.

“No?” Len asked. He swiveled in the chair and looked out the window. “So what have you got planned, really?” he asked.

“Uh, that’s...” she stammered. “I don’t know, just, he’s coming over and the rest is... you know. History.”

Len was smiling a very arrogant smile when he turned around. He looked at her for a long time, his eyes lit up. “Not really,” he said in disbelief. He helped himself to another glass. “You know what I think, Kimmy? I think you’re planning on doing *no. Such. Thing.*”

Kim narrowed her eyes. She didn’t have a good retort. Len was really pissing her off.

She could see it in his face: he was egging her on. Daring her to take up the challenge. It was either that – that he knew she was planning to tell Jessie she had done it when she hadn’t – or he actually just thought she was too chicken to do it.

Either way he was irritating her in a very special way.

He crunched an ice cube.

Either way, he made her furious. How dare he tell her that she wasn't brave enough to do something?

"Well," she said airily. "Either way. You have to go."

He pointed a finger at himself. "Moi?" he asked in mocking tone of innocence. "Oh come on, Kimmy. You know you aren't having Hunter over."

"No?" she said, quietly furious, and quietly triumphant that he didn't know nearly as much as he thought he did.

He shook his head, his eyes on hers.

She folded her arms and inadvertently shifted her jaw in a grinding motion. Exasperated because she couldn't think of anything to say to him, she threw her hands in the air. "Whatever!" she exclaimed. "You have to go, either way."

"That's a waste of a perfectly good Friday."

He was so calm, so infuriatingly cocky, that she wanted to punch him.

If she had delved a little further into her feelings, she would have uncovered the truth that she also found him alluring when he was like this.

"Tell you what," Len said, reaching for the bottle of tequila. "I'll make myself a drink here, and just watch this unfold. And if it is true that you run off to seduce your little friend, then I'll make myself scarce. Promise."

Kim's face was outraged. "Wait a -"

"Is he coming over here?" Len asked. He brought his drink to his mouth. "If he is, then I'll just slip out when he gets here. Or maybe I'll let him see me, help you out a bit. I don't think Hunter would be too disappointed to think you're a big slut." He sipped his drink. "I know I wouldn't be."

Kim threw her hands up in the air. "What the -"

Len caught her wrist and pulled her toward him. The motion was so smooth, and his eyes so wolf-like as he did it, that she simply stopped talking and sucked in her breath. "Kim," he purred. His mouth was very close to hers. She had a ripple of goosebumps flash down her arm as her mind wandered to his stubbly jaw and how it would feel on her inner thigh. "We both know you're too much of a goody-two-shoes to be this much of a slut right off the bat. So why don't you drop the act, and have one of my amazing margaritas, and then... we'll just see how it goes. From there. Don't act like you didn't send me your naked photo for a reason. And then this message. Come on."

Her mouth fell open. She *wanted* to object, and she wanted to tell him he was a stupid dick, but his fingers were now trailing up her forearm in a sensual massage, and she knew that her eyes had probably flashed to dilation and revealed that he was right. So she said nothing, spellbound.

“What was the reason, Kim?”

His fingers were stroking her skin in a way that made her insides feel like the plucked strings of a guitar. One peg of which was right inside her pussy.

She needed to get this under control.

She slid her arm from his hand and smiled. “It was a mistake,” she said coyly. Then, feeling mischievous, she shrugged. “Or it wasn’t. Either way... I *do* have a date.”

Len leaned back. “I-don’t-believe-you.”

As she did it, she actually couldn’t believe that she was doing it. It was as though she watched it from outside her own body, like a movie. Her hands moved to her hips, and the running shorts were gone. She tugged at the zipper of the shirt she was wearing, a sexy, sports bra and shirt combo, and it yawned open, while Len’s eyes hungrily absorbed the slowly expanding inches of bare skin until she felt the plastic zipper on her nipple, rough, tantalizing. She knew that her legs were wet at the very center of her thighs, but she didn’t care.

The high she felt as she crossed the living room, slipping the vest away from her body and dropping it on the floor, was like nothing she’d ever felt before. It was terrifying, but it was thrilling, and all of the terror and the thrill nestled themselves right in her lower abdomen.

She had no idea, she realized, if Hunter would even be there. There was no retreat from this act, if she went out and lay down naked on the beach and Hunter wasn’t there – she would have to find a way to make a joke of it. But there was also no retreat if Hunter *was* there, because Len was watching, and she wanted Len to see the lie she was telling him as real:

She was not only brave enough, she was wild enough. She was not only going to sleep with Hunter, her plan to do it was to walk out onto the beach naked and wait for him to come, and then boldly lead him someplace private.

And if she did *that*, then she couldn’t just tell Hunter she didn’t want to go through with it.

It was surreal: she slipped a towel from the back of a chair where it had been drying, and she walked like a queen out onto the beach.

At that moment, it was more important she win this power struggle with Len, than that she was going to actually fuck Hunter to do it.

She stretched out on the towel and leaned back on her elbows. She gave her hair a toss and hoped it was particularly glossy in the fading light. She raised her right hand and gave Len the bird, without looking back at him.

And then, pulse racing, mind completely blank, thighs shiny with excitement, she waited.

CHAPTER 15

Kim had sent him a blurry picture of a massive black man and the short, mysterious message:

I flirted with him finally!

The text had vibrated against his thigh like any other notification he received, but somehow he had known that the message was from her. The vibration had traveled up his thigh and into his testicles as a mildly painful ache, until at last he could close himself in the office and look at it.

At first it felt like being slammed into a wall, and then he felt a steep descent into disappointment: the text, after all, barely said anything. He could barely see what the man even looked like.

But an ascent into a euphoric kind of pain followed almost immediately. He couldn't see what he looked like, but then he didn't really need to: he was real, this black man that his wife claimed to be attracted to, and now had flirted with. The man she had spontaneously worked into her dirty talk with him.

Very real. Very large. Very black.

He felt sick almost as suddenly as he felt his cock throb with desire, almost the moment he imagined Kim with her legs spread open for this dark stranger to penetrate. It was as if he could hear her moan, hear her soaked pussy squelch and strain as he shoved himself inside of her.

He didn't really want that, did he? Kim filled up with another man's cock? Especially *this* man?

And again, he went tumbling to a disappointed low: all she had done was flirt with him.

That meant nothing. It was possible it hadn't even happened.

And so it went on, like that, rising to erotic highs and falling to disappointed or disgusted lows, each of them becoming more intense the longer he stared at the words and no further messages came through to him. Should he have said something in response to her text? He hadn't even thought to do that. He *had* thought of jerking off in his private bathroom while thinking of his wife on her knees, swallowing an enormous black cock.

In reality, she had seemed less gung-ho than he wanted her to be. She would buy him a “drink” at the gym on Friday, and see where things went from there.

Jessie had made her recount every second of her interaction with Jay, hoping to find within her words some irrefutable slice of evidence that there was no going back, that she was hopelessly attracted to him and she was going to fling herself at him on Friday. But Kim sounded more hesitant, more like a girl who had a crush in seventh grade than a woman who was going to fuck another guy to satisfy her husband’s kink.

And it *was* a kink, and he very much couldn’t put it out of his mind. He was embarrassed to tell her how much it consumed him, how the thought of Jay touching her and lying on top of her and filling her with his cock made him painfully hard, sick to the stomach, wildly excited, and completely obsessed. He was ashamed to tell her that he wanted her to act like a filthy slut, afraid she would think he didn’t love her, afraid she would misunderstand what was at the heart of his desire.

He didn’t understand it all that well himself.

So he let Kim take the lead.

“You really want me to do this?” she had asked. Hesitation tinged her voice.

“If it’s what you want,” he had managed to say.

It was better anyway, that Kim was the one to control it. There was something alluring to her being so far away, to her having his permission to do terrible things, and to him having only the slightest control over it.

But time went on and he heard nothing from her.

Instead of calling her, though, or texting her, or finding out what his wife was doing, he sank into a very dark fantasy, one in which Kim had thrown herself at Jay’s feet and let him have his way with her. Right now, he liked to think, in every spare moment of his time and even in time that was not free – in a meeting, while on the phone with an important client – right now my wife is lying on her back and taking inch after inch of another man’s cock inside of her, loving every minute of it, too high on the way this hot black stud is using her body to think straight. Too exhausted from fucking him again and again and again to even call me, or text me, and tell me it’s over, once you go black, you never go back...

And so he waited, drinking more than usual, letting his imagination run wild, his cock hard and his balls aching until he jerked off and sat in the

semi-darkness, disgusted with himself until he was riled up again. Paralyzed by his conflicts, unable to do anything but stare at the phone, waiting for whatever Kim sent him next. Friday had been an unusually un-busy day, leaving him extra time to torment himself.

He at last dozed off in the early hours of the morning on Saturday. He was not a man who used alarms; he just woke up, every day, at six am. So nothing woke him up until the phone began to vibrate repeatedly: Mark was looking for him, he had a meeting at nine, what was he doing?!!!! And a Zip file from Len, - which made him pause but there were too many things nagging him suddenly.

Not the least of which was that there had been nothing from Kim.

He jumped up and hurried through the motions of showering and getting dressed. His head was swimming. He was tired, his insides felt like they were being churned constantly, and he had had more to drink than he had realized, giving his every thought a lag, like it was being pulled through water behind him.

Why did he suddenly go back to the Zip file? It was hard to say – he had overlooked it in his absent-minded semi-drunkenness. Len had once been a business partner; he had perhaps lumped the file in with the memory of Len working with him, and all the work emails that had come in an onslaught.

But it was Len's phone, and Len did not work for him.

Len wasn't the type to send anything, not so much as a text, let alone a whole file.

Everything he had been gathering together into piles of coherent thoughts were blown away, as if they were piles of leaves in a wild storm. His mind went blank, and he felt as if everything inside of him had been hollowed out, leaving only the rapid, unsteady muscle of his heart, beating like a dying animal in his empty chest. Cold sank over him and then that sensation, too, went away.

He had the phone in his hand, and he sank onto the couch, staring at it as if the phone was already telling him something he didn't want to know. There was no comment attached, only the file. And yet he knew what it would contain, somehow.

And then it was all there, playing on the screen of his phone. Grainy in segments, shaky in others. Hard to see, the sound muffled here and tinny there. The amateur, cell-phone quality of it gave it such a dreamlike

character that he seemed to float out of his body. A tightness in his chest became incrementally more unbearable, so at the end he was almost not able to breathe.

It began in the kitchen of the Dillon Beach house. It was dusk outside, and the lights were on in the house, so he could make out the reflection of Len's body in the sliding doors, which were open to the porch and the beach beyond. Len's voice said something, but it didn't matter what it was and Jessie wasn't about to go backward and repeat it: he moved closer to the doors, the lights turned off, a grainy blue grayishness washed over the screen and then slowly reconstituted itself as a view of the beach, and on it a red beach towel with a pale woman sitting on it. Black hair, gleaming in what light was left. White skin, bare.

And to the left, a figure walking toward her.

The scene was sucked away, and again they were inside the house, looking out. The figures on the beach merged – the man, who Jessie could now see was the neighbor from the evening he had surprised Kim, and the pale woman who he didn't want to be, but could only be, his wife.

Hunter's body dropped to the sand next to her.

"Not sure what they're up to," Len's voice said, in a low rumble, amused.

And that was all. Jessie strained his eyes looking at the blurry, darkening beach, at the two figures clumped together. They seemed to be sitting next to each other, talking... but so *close*.

Notifications swarmed the upper margins of his screen and he ignored them, his breath trapped in his chest, his eyes on the two figures, their shifting movements, barely distinguishable on the small screen in the semi-darkness.

Kim wasn't *naked*, he told himself, as his eyes sought in vain the straps of her swimsuit or the black streak of the bottoms over her hip. Kim wasn't the kind of girl who sat on the beach naked. It wasn't as if the beach was all that private. Anyone could have walked by. No one actually did, but they could have.

And Hunter was just close to her. No closer than he had been in the kitchen.

It seemed like an eternity before the figures moved in earnest. Jessie's eyes were tired from staring at their figures, trying to make out just how close, and how clothed, they were.

They stood up.

There was a way to deny that Kim was naked: when she stood up, her hair fell over her breasts. The resolution was terrible. There was a tiny black bikini on her, and it was only because of the bad lighting that it couldn't be seen.

She was putting a towel around her.

The two figures were close but not touching.

Moving toward the house.

Len – because it was impossible to deny that it was Len holding the phone – was retreating into the now-dark house. Blackish gray filled the screen, faint outlines of the white walls and gold shadows seeping from a lights source somewhere in the dark smeared across the screen as Len moved. The sliding door could be heard shutting.

Kim's laughter.

He heard her voice saying, "wait, wait, wait."

A light clicked on. Then off again.

Hunter mumbled something, and the screen was blurred again as Len was in motion.

Abruptly, the clip cut to a room bathed in a dim golden glow. The phone was steady now, no more shaking.

The living room, again.

No, the bedroom. The bedroom, the white square of the bed gray-blue in the light.

From the left, shadows moved, blocking the lights for a moment and then moving away from the phone, entangled. Hunter's hands in Kim's hair, their mouths working greedily at each other, lips and tongues fighting to claim each other. Hunter pushed her to the bed and got onto it, naked, on his knees. His arms contracted as he pulled Kim's legs toward him. For a moment that seemed to last forever, he was in front of her, moving toward her – and then he was on top of her, and Kim moaned as his body covered hers.

Jessie stared at the form of Hunter's muscled, hard body on top. Beneath him, unmistakably, the spread white legs of his wife. Their panting was the only noise, steady and synchronized.

He stared at his wife's leg as it rose along the length of Hunter's thigh and her heel came to rest in the small of his back. She had done this to him hundreds of times, he could almost feel her heel dragging over his thigh

now. When she did this, her body shifted around his cock, and her hot flesh pressed against one side of him more than the other. A subtle, sensual accident, making the velvet of her cunt lap on the left of his dick where he didn't stroke himself masturbating. The feeling was disquieting and erotic. And now Hunter would feel it, too.

But Hunter seemed to have plans of his own, and Kim's leg did not stop there – it continued until Hunter rested it on his shoulder, and in the dimness Jessie saw that he was lifting her other leg as well. Her feet bobbed lightly as he rocked back and forth inside of her, her ankles resting on his shoulders.

Hunter shifted her left leg to his right, placing it together with her right and then, grasping her ankles roughly in one hand, he shifted her legs to his left and let them plop to the side. He continued to fuck her as he did this, and Kim threw her hands over his neck and moaned deeply.

Hunter was fucking her hard now, wet slaps against her ass as her moaning became more guttural, and then animal-like and high-pitched. Her legs flopped to the side as though she were a rag doll he was fucking brutally. The squeals escalated until her legs went rigid and straight and she lifted her head to let out a low, sloppy exhale and scream.

Hunter slowed his assault on her, and then backed away from her contorted legs, his cock leaving her pussy without even bouncing slightly. It was average-sized, Jessie noticed with satisfaction. But so hard that it pointed in front of him like steel, no need for the support of his hand.

There was a brief second when the sloppy wet mess of Kim's pussy was visible, and the image seared itself into Jessie's mind so thoroughly he knew he would see it forever when he closed his eyes to go to bed. The engorged, split-open darkness of his wife's pussy, her white legs tossed to one side, Hunter's cock hovering over the scene menacingly.

Hunter swing his right hand down and slapped Kim on the ass. "Turn over," he panted. His chest was still rising and falling with a different kind of need than Kim's.

She rolled over obediently for him, and he pulled her by her hips onto her knees, turned away from him. Her legs were together and between his, Kim's split, dripping pussy just inches from the tip of his cock, which he now held in his hand.

He reached forward at the same time that he placed one hand on her ass and pushed his hips toward her. His cock disappeared behind her leg –

there was little reason to think it had gone anywhere but into her pussy, but the pain of it stabbed Jessie in the chest, and somewhere in his mind he tried to fantasize it away and pretend that this was all fake. He was actually on the other side of her right leg, maybe his cock was rubbing along her thigh... but he wasn't *inside of his wife*, enjoying the way her orgasm had squeezed her sweet juices out of her flesh and coated his cock with the sweetness of her pussy.

He was sinking into the couch, the numbness in his body in stark contrast to the overwhelming turgidness of his cock: he was going to burst without even touching it.

Hunter drove into her and grasped her hips, and Kim's legs kicked behind him and her chest fell to the bed. "Don't move," Hunter urged her, his torso rising up and rigid, his hand on the small of her back. But Kim bucked against him and squealed like an animal, her ass pumping against him. Her words were incomprehensible, swallowed by her panting, animal gasps.

Hunter's cock slid from inside of her as she came, a splurge of her soaked pussy as it contracted drowning out the sounds of their breathing. It was too dark and grainy to see it clearly, but he didn't need to: Hunter held his cock in one hand and pushed Kim's ass forward and up as he shot his cum onto her lower back, groaning and flexing every muscle on his body as he did.

They remained like that, panting, Kim's trembling legs collapsing. Hunter pulled her by the hair to bring her torso up to him, and she was against his chest with his left arm snaking over her front. A mewl came from her mouth, and then the screen froze in the terrible picture.

At first he waited as though it would continue or change, but it was over. He slid from the couch and hastily went back a few minutes, his hand fumbling with his pants as he tried to hold the phone with the other, the whole scene replaying for him from when he flipped her over. He dropped the phone and steadied himself on the coffee table as his wife's voice mewled from the dropped phone, and he burst messily onto his pants and the floor, the orgasm squeezing out of him violently, shaking him from head to toe.

He was frozen like that, leaning on his coffee table, his sticky cum spilled on his hand and his clothing, snaking down his thigh. An urge to vomit snaked through him as the final gasps of the video played from

somewhere on the floor. He was so lightheaded he was seeing stars at the edges of his vision.

And then it was over again.

CHAPTER 16

Len answered the phone with a light chuckle. When Jessie didn't respond, he sighed. "Way to go buddy," he said cheerfully. "I really didn't have Kim down as the type. Ever."

Jessie's voice rattled up from somewhere deep inside of him, and it sounded nothing like his own voice when it left his mouth. "What did you *do*?" he breathed.

Len paused, and his arrogant pause was so infuriating to Jessie that he would have punched him if they had been in the same room together. "Me? I didn't do anything, I'm just a cinematographer. But boy was that the last thing I expected to see when I -"

"How did you get this?" Jessie demanded. His voice was icy and ragged. "Were you there?"

Len chuckled. "Alas, I was not. But we can always arrange it so that -"

"What happened?" Jessie snarled.

"Whoa, whoa, whoa buddy," Len said. His jovial tone sent a flash of blinding heat through Jessie's temple. "I thought this was on the level with you guys. Kim's the one who -"

"Who what? Did she tell you to film it?"

Jessie could almost hear Len smiling through the phone. "Jessie, buddy. Kim was all set to go. All I did was give her a gentle nudge in the right direction. And then, things just happened to work out after that."

"Did you fuck her?"

"Did you tell your wife she couldn't fuck her friends?"

Jessie's mouth hung open in indignant rage. "That's..." he began.

What? Too personal? He wanted to strangle Len right now.

"Listen to me, man," Len said. "Do you have any idea how much of my life I wasted 'being good' and keeping secrets from my wife, even myself, when all along we had compatible interests? Too long. You've got a nice, pretty wife here, who is highly suggestible. Now, I don't have any idea what her game is, or what yours is, but I do know this: nobody sends two accidental texts to somebody about stuff like this."

Jessie was flummoxed. "What?"

Len chuckled again. God, that was getting annoying. "You know what I would do if I were you, Jessie? I'd talk to my wife. You two obviously

have some sort of deal, and hats off to you, my friend. Welcome to the club _.”

“What do you mean about the messages?”

Len chuckled again.

“Did you fuck her?”

“No man. No, I did not. But if anybody wants me to...”

Len’s voice trailed off.

“Look, J-Bomb. I sent you the video because... well, the opportunity came up and I figured you’d want to see it. Now I see that you haven’t talked to your wife yet. Let me just give you a piece of advice though... sometimes honesty is overrated.”

Jessie shook his head, unable to think of anything to say.

“Talk to your wife. Keep an open mind.”

And then, somewhere in the next few minutes, the call was disconnected, and Len was not a voice in his ear anymore.

*

Why had he called Len first?

His phone was almost exploding now. His assistant, frantic, had called him several times while he was talking to Len, and his last text message said he was going to call the police.

A calm fell over Jessie, like snow. He made a call to Stew, telling him he felt terrible and must have come down with the flu: he had been sleeping all this time. His voice sounded sick without him having to fake it. He was sorry. Please help him juggle appointments.

And so it was done.

And while he was on the phone, feeling actually ill, lying to his assistant, Kim had messaged him. He had known it, even if the phone hadn’t pulsed for the incoming message, even if there was no way for him to have known it. He was unsurprised when he looked at the screen and saw her messages there, so many of them colliding.

Was she texting him because Len had told her to? Because Len was right there, his naked body against hers in their bed, his cum between her thighs, his mouth next to her ear, a smile on his face as he told her to text her husband and smooth things over? To pave the way for more treachery?

I have to talk to you

Jessie stared at the message, unable to think of what to do. Another message materialized on his phone as he was thinking.

Jessie please call me. I have to talk to you.

He typed.

What did you do?

And then he waited.

What had their agreement been? She just had to tell him about it. But no Len, no friends. That's what she had told him.

How in the hell had Len gotten the video? It went beyond anything they had agreed upon, beyond anything he would have imagined that Kim would do. Why Hunter, and not her black stud? Why was Len there at all, in his house, while his wife fucked the neighbor?

His chest was broiling with ice and fire when she called.

"Jessie?" she asked, when he said nothing. "Are you there? Can you hear me?"

He paused, his thoughts racing.

Honesty is overrated, Len growled in his ear.

Kim's voice was faltering.

And he...

He was enjoying it.

He enjoyed that she sounded guilty, that she had called him with a mind to confess to something.

That was the truth: he was enjoying it.

"I'm here," he said.

"I did it," she said. Her voice was weak, almost a whisper.

He waited, and she began to speak to fill the silence. "I did it last night, with Hunter. The guy next door. You remember him, right? I know I texted you about that other guy, the one at the gym... Jessie," she said, and her voice was bordering on frantic. She took a breath in and it was like a sob. "I actually didn't mean to do it, it just... things got out of control..."

"You slept with Hunter?"

“I did.”

“Where?”

“Upstairs.”

He paused, savoring her honesty and at the same time the promise of her betrayal. His head hurt, He was a mad, mad man, and this was madness.

“In our bed?” he breathed.

There was a long pause, and the texture of it was divine: was she thinking of a lie? Did she know what Len had done, or not? Was Len coaching her, training her, priming her, using her like a puppet?

“Well... yeah, it was... it started on the beach, and then... Jessie, are you mad at me?”

He knew she was asking about the bed, but he wasn't mad about that: the bed had always seemed like the bed of someone else, anyway.

“No,” he said flatly. “What did you do?”

“We had sex,” she said, and her voice broke apart at the end.

“Was it good?” His voice was robotic now, seeking out the truth and the betrayal, like a mechanical killer.

She gave a little sob of exasperation. “Jessie, I thought you said...”

“I'm not mad, sweetie,” Jessie said, and the sentiment was real. “Just... you have to tell me everything, remember?”

“Okay,” she said, and her voice was soft. “It was good. It was... fun.”

“Did you come?”

Jessie was surprised that his cock was getting harder, not so much because he was savoring her telling him everything he already knew, not because he could see it in detail, but because he was waiting for her to lie, almost hoping that she would, as much as he wanted her not to.

“Yes,” Kim was saying. “It was... I feel silly telling you all this over the phone. It's not the same as pretending. I want to tell you when you're here.”

He felt his stomach lurch, his blood rush.

“But that's not what... it's not what I'm calling to tell you,” she said quietly.

Jessie's stomach lurched. “What, then?”

“I have to tell you this just to get it off my chest, okay? I don't know why I did it, and it wasn't even... I didn't even do it on purpose -”

Kim cut herself off. “I *did* do it on purpose,” she said, in the same frantic whisper. “It wasn't anything, nothing came of it, but, just...”

“Just tell me, Kim.”

His voice was steadier now, and the thrill of her potential lie had been replaced by the even more sweet potential that his wife was going to tell him the truth. Hanging in the moments between these two possibilities was like snorting cocaine.

“Remember I told you I sent Len that picture on accident? Before, the one from... you know.”

He murmured an assent.

“I don’t know why. I did it, though. I did it, I mean I did it on purpose. And then... I sent him this other message.” She stopped herself again, with another whispery sob. “I don’t even know why. I really don’t. I don’t even remember doing it. I thought I sent it to you, I swear.”

“What did you do?”

“I sent Len a text saying something like, *tonight’s the night*. It was a text I sent, I meant to send, I really thought I sent it – it was to you. I don’t even know how. I was planning the whole time to just tease *you*, it wasn’t even a thing, I didn’t even go to the gym, you know, I chickened out. And him, maybe, I don’t know. I really don’t know how it happened...”

Her voice trailed off, like she was thinking. Jessie waited.

He wondered how much of this was true. Her story was so disjointed, so frantic, so utterly nonsensical, it had the ring of truth to it.

“So, that was the plan,” she said suddenly, with renewed purpose. “I was going to tell you I slept with Jay, but not really do it. I wanted to see how you really felt, if you really thought I did it, before I actually did it. Because... Anyway. Len showed up last night at the house.”

There was a silence that was so deep Jessie was worried he had maybe gone dead. It hit the entire world around him at once, and it took him a moment to realize it was the force of his blood pressure, crowding the capillaries of his ears until there was silence. He could feel his heart in his chest.

“And he... God, Jessie. I have no idea. I told him to leave, he started like, egging me on or something. He was like, ‘you’ll never do this,’ and he was so fucking smug, and then something just came over me, you know? Like I wanted to show him he was wrong or something. And then I just... did it. I walked out onto the beach and sat there naked and then Hunter came out and it was all happening...”

“I thought you were going to say you slept with Jay -”

“I *was!*” she snapped impatiently. “That’s what...God, this is all messed up. That’s what I meant when I sent you the message that I actually sent to Len. You see? And then Len came over, and he could see I was like, in my gym clothes and drinking by myself and I didn’t have any plans to do anything, and he just... I don’t know. He like, tricked me into doing it, or goaded me, or whatever. I just went for it, I went out and seduced Hunter.”

“Not Jay,” Jessie said. He wasn’t so stupid he didn’t understand what had happened, he was just playing dumb because... what? He wanted to hear more, or make her feel more guilty. It was a slightly demented game.

“No, not Jay. Not... I never was going to actually do it. But I did. And Len left like he said he would and then...”

“Where?” Jessie prodded.

“Where what?”

“Where did you fuck him?”

“I told you,” she said, gasping again. “In the house.”

Silence.

“Len wasn’t there,” she said quickly. “That’s why I went back, Jessie, that’s what I have to tell you. He was there and he was the one who egged me on and I wanted to flaunt it. I think I wanted him to watch. But he wasn’t there.”

“And you fucked him anyway. Hunter.”

Jessie couldn’t have explained the tone in his voice to anyone, least of all Kim, if she had asked.

Kim gave a soft sob. “Jessie please don’t be mad at me. I thought this was what we agreed on. I knew you would be -”

“I’m not mad,” Jessie said. “Honey, no, I’m not mad.” He could almost see her crying, and the image of it, as much as he knew it was fucked-up to think that, was turning him on. “It’s hot, Kim, it’s so hot, I wanted you to do it. Tell me what you did.”

Kim sniffed. “You’re not mad?”

“I’m not mad, just -”

“Not even about Len?”

Jessie paused, causing Kim to sniffle again. “Jessie?”

“I’m not mad about Len,” he said. “You’ve told me everything, right?”

“Yes,” she said.

“Except the details.”

Kim sniffed again. "Will you come here? Or I can come there? Please? I just..." she laughed lightly. "I don't want to tell you over the phone."

"Did you come?"

Kim paused. The silence was excruciating. "Yes."

"How many times?"

"Twice."

"Did he come inside of you, Kim?"

She paused. "No. No, he pulled out and came all over my back."

"Was that it?"

A pause. "No."

"What else did you do? Tell me Kim," he breathed. "It's so hot."

She paused, and he could hear that she was breathing almost as raggedly as he was. Her voice was a whisper again when she said: "I sucked his cock."

Jessie inhaled sharply.

"Well..." she added, "it was more like... he fucked me in the mouth."

"How?"

Jessie wasn't even thinking that this part was somehow not on the video; he wasn't even thinking at all. He just wanted the details, he had leaned back onto the couch and had his cock in his hand; the only thing in the world was Kim's voice.

"How long was this after he fucked you?" he prompted, when Kim was silent.

"A little bit. Not much. We went downstairs, we got some wine... then I was sitting on the couch and he seemed like he was going to go home... he came over maybe to just kiss me or something, and I started it. I pulled him out -"

"Why?"

"Why what?"

"Why did you start it?"

Kim was into it now, her whispery voice was gone and the Kim who had talked so dirtily to him before was speaking in her place, growling from her throat. "I wanted to see what he tasted like," she said.

Jessie inhaled again.

"I wanted to see if I could get his whole cock in my throat."

His hand was working fast on his cock now, and he could tell by the ups and downs of Kim's voice that she was also pleasuring herself. What he

wouldn't have given to be there with her now. Why were they doing this so far apart?

"And then he just grabbed my hair, and pushed himself inside, and started to fuck me in the mouth."

Jessie exhaled.

"Did he come?" he said, in a strangled voice.

"He came," she said, her voice gasping. "He came...all...inside...my...mouth..."

There were a bizarre few minutes as they breathed into the phones, silent except for their shared post-orgasmic glow, until Jessie at last whispered, "That was hot, Kim. That was so hot."

"Jessie," she said. "I really think you should come down here. I would... I'll feel better if you come down here."

Oh, he would come down there, all right. A part of his mind was already planning the trip.

"Or maybe I should just go back..." Kim said wistfully.

Jessie leaned on his elbows, expelling air as he sat up to lend greater protest to this idea. "Kim, no," he said. Maybe too urgently. She fell silent.

"Look," he said. "I... I mean, what I mean is... didn't you have a good time?"

"Well," she said hesitantly, but he could hear in her voice that the answer was yes. Then she sighed. "But is that the only thing to think about? Jessie, I don't know, maybe this isn't the right thing to do. You know? What if it isn't?"

Jessie thought for a moment. "Listen," he said, finally. "I'll be down there soon, okay? And then we can decide. Together."

"Yeah, okay."

Jessie wished he could see her now. His conscience was suddenly tormented by Len's mysterious video, and how it had been taken – and whether or not he should tell Kim about it.

"Kim?" he said quickly.

"Yeah?"

"You really did go downstairs and give Hunter a blowjob? Or is that just something you made up?"

Silence on the other end. "*What?* What the hell is that supposed to mean? Have you listened to anything I've said?!"

"Did you?"

Kim made a few noises of protest, and then said, angrily, "Of course I did, that's why I told you about it. You see... this is what I mean, this is what I worry about -"

"Kim, stop," he said firmly. Then more gently. "Stop stop stop. That's not why I'm asking."

Another pause, this one heavy.

"So why are you asking?" Kim asked.

Jessie paused. "Why is it you sent that text to Len? Really?"

Kim made a noise. "Jessie, what are you saying? Why are you asking me all these weird questions now?"

"You promised you'd tell me everything -"

"And I did! I'm telling you... I don't even have any reason to tell you, nothing happened with Len. I just, I said I would tell you everything."

Jessie's heart felt like it was teetering on the edge of a cliff.

"And so it was really a mistake?"

Kim sighed. "The text was... I don't know. Maybe I did it on purpose, subconsciously, but I really don't remember doing it, thinking about it."

"And Len isn't there now, or, like, telling you what to do?"

"What? No. Don't be ridiculous. Why the hell are you asking me all these questions -"

Jessie sighed and interrupted. "Have you seen Len since last night?"

"Yes," Kim said. Her voice had the hurried excitement of piecing something together. "I have. Why? He came back here in the morning while I was out on the beach." She paused, and then repeated. "Why, Jessie?"

Jessie was silent for a while. Possibilities branched in front of him now, every branch a different blend of truth and lies, things that could be known and things that could not.

In the end, he could never know what Kim was thinking, and the pain of it seared him right through the abdomen, but it made his chest swell with that cold, raw desire he was enjoying so much.

"I'm coming down there," he said. "I'll find a way to get down there tonight. There's something you need to see."

"What?"

"And Kim," he said. "I love you. But if there's anything you are lying to me about, anything at all, something you forgot. Even if you think of why you sent that text to Len. Then will you please tell me when I get there?"

“There’s nothing else, Jessie, what do you mean there’s something I should see?”

“I’ll be there soon, okay? Tonight. I promise.”

Kim was quiet, and the silence on the phone was rich and erotic, all of the possibilities floating between them, painful and beautiful. There was the possibility that she had only done exactly what she’d said she’d done, and that she was telling him the truth. And beyond that possibility, so many more.

But woven into those possibilities were possibilities of treachery and lies.

And it was possible that he loved them as much as the others.

“Jessie,” she breathed, her voice feathered with desperation. “I love you.”

It was the kind of real, desperate “I love you,” that she said when they first got together, when she had whispered it in his ear while sitting on his lap with his cock deep inside of her. The kind of raw declaration of love that made him tell her to say it again and again while he bounced her on top of his cock and their sweat mingled together. It was the kind of “I love you” that was so different from the way they said it lately; carelessly, without meaning, without need.

“I love you, Kim,” he said. And that, too, was truer than it had been for a long time.

“I’ll see you tonight,” he promised. “I’ll find a flight.”

“Okay.”

“Okay.”

No matter what happened next, he at least had this moment, he thought. A reactivation of everything that had been dead for so long.

He turned to the computer, ignoring his ringing phone, Stew madly calling him again, and looked for a flight, any flight, to Orlando, as soon as possible.

No price too high.

“You have so many things to *do*,” Stew complained, when he finally called him back, only to tell him that he was returning to Florida for the weekend, possibly the week. Stew then disintegrated into a splutter.

But Jessie, his mind on something else entirely, barely heard him, focused instead on those tantalizing first moments when he would see his wife again, and yet also, it seemed, for the first time as more than just *his*

lover. Kim was no longer just *his* Kim, but a woman to acquire again, something he could lose, a risk. He felt the rush of gambling, the fever of conquest on its heels.

And that delicious mixture of heat and ice curled and coiled in his stomach, as he anticipated their reunion...

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